

UP Government approves interim hike in minimum wages

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida/New Delhi

The Uttar Pradesh Government on Tuesday approved an interim hike of around 21 per cent in minimum wages for unskilled, semi-skilled and skilled workers in Gautam Buddh Nagar and Ghaziabad, following large-scale protests by thousands of factory workers in Noida.

The fresh minimum wage structure introduced across worker categories will be taking effect retrospectively from April 1.

The agitation, which had been intensifying over several days, saw an estimated 40,000 to 45,000 workers assemble at nearly 80 to 83

locations across the Gautam Buddh Nagar commissioner-ate, including key industrial hubs such as Sector 62, Phase-2, Sector 63, Sector 60, Sector 84 and parts of Greater Noida.

The process for final wage fixation would be taken up through a wage board to be constituted soon, and the government is also considering additional welfare measures related to workers' health, pension and education of their children, Industrial Development Commissioner Deepak Kumar said.

The wage increase has been done by the high-powered committee, formed to look into the labour issues after large-scale protests by factory workers in Noida on

Monday, to provide immediate financial relief to the workers.

The State Government, however, has rejected claims that the minimum pay has been raised to ₹20,000 per month, and employers are not following this direction. The revised wages were finalised by the high-powered committee and received approval late on Monday night. Gautam Buddh Nagar District Magistrate Medha Ropam said, "The wage increase has been done by the high-powered committee... The decision was approved."

In Gautam Buddh Nagar and Ghaziabad, unskilled workers will now get ₹13,690 per month, up from ₹11,313, while semi-skilled workers



Security guards stage a protest over fee hike issues outside a residential society at Sector 74 in Noida

PTI

will receive ₹15,059 and skilled workers ₹16,868, according to an official statement.

For other municipal corporation areas, the revised monthly wages have been

fixed at ₹13,006 for unskilled workers, ₹14,306 for semi-skilled workers, and ₹16,025 for skilled workers.

In the remaining districts, unskilled workers will get

₹12,356 per month, semi-skilled workers ₹13,591, and skilled workers ₹15,224. The decision follows consultations with employers' bodies and labour organisations.

The government said suggestions and objections were examined to ensure a "balanced and practical" outcome.

The statement said that industries are facing global economic challenges, including rising input costs and declining exports, even as workers' demands regarding wages, overtime, safety and working conditions remain "relevant and important."

"In such a situation, it is essential to adopt a balanced approach between industry and labour," the Government

said, adding that provisions under the new labour codes aim to ensure fair wages and protect workers' interests.

It said it is considering an interim increase in wages based on indexation and will initiate the process for final wage fixation on the recommendations of a wage board to be constituted soon.

The committee, which visited Noida following the unrest, said workers' representatives had maintained that their agitation was peaceful and centred around demands such as wage hikes, weekly offs, double overtime pay, safety and dignified working conditions.

At the same time, the possibility of the involvement of "external elements" in the

violence was flagged, with workers themselves expressing apprehension about outsiders fuelling the unrest, they said.

To address grievances and ensure better coordination, the administration has set up a dedicated control room at the district level. Workers can register complaints and seek assistance through helpline numbers 120-2978231, 120-2978232, 120-2978862 and 120-2978702, officials said.

The State government has also issued strict directions for action against anti-social elements involved in the violence, launching a special drive to identify such individuals through technical surveillance, intelligence inputs and local information gathering.

MCD to introduce 7 thematic children's parks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) will introduce seven thematic children's parks across the city in the coming months, with designs aimed to make neighbourhood spaces more engaging for young visitors.



According to officials, the proposed parks are being developed in multiple parts of Delhi, including Janakpuri, Saket, Greater Kailash, Mayur Vihar, Swasthya Vihar in East Delhi, Karol Bagh and Mayapuri in West Delhi under the Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation (AMRUT) funds. Each park is built around a distinct theme, aimed at providing play structures and engaging activities for children.

"While Janakpuri will feature an aeroplane-themed

play structure, Mayur Vihar is set to get a prominent peacock installation rising about 20 to 25 feet, which will have a playhouse and various activities," officials said.

Construction work at the Janakpuri and Mayur Vihar sites is currently underway. Meanwhile, development at the remaining locations is still in the initial stages, with planning and groundwork in progress.

Each of the seven parks will showcase a unique

theme. While a portion of Ajmal Khan Park is being developed around an octopus theme, M Block Park in Greater Kailash-II will feature a 'Garuda' theme. Parks near PVR Saket will adopt an insect theme, Swasthya Vihar Park near the Laxmi Nagar District Centre will have a marine theme, and a park in Mayur Vihar Phase-III will highlight the peacock theme. A park near the Mayapuri DTC depot will be developed on an aeroplane theme, while another

Government to rename SRDC as Indraprastha Virasat Redevelopment Corporation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government is planning to rename Shahjahanabad Redevelopment Corporation (SRDC), the agency dedicated to restoring and revitalising the Walled City areas, as "Indraprastha Virasat Redevelopment Corporation".

The name change was proposed, finalised and approved at the last SRDC Board meeting chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on March 13 this year.

Indraprastha is the Mahabharata-era name of the present-day national capital, while SRDC is named after the Shahjahanabad city built by Mughal emperor



Shahjahan, who also oversaw the construction of the iconic Jama Masjid and Red Fort in Old Delhi.

"The Board, after due consultations and deliberations, approved the proposal to change the name of the company from Shahjahanabad Redevelopment Corporation to Indraprastha Virasat

Redevelopment Corporation," said an official document. With the board's approval, the only formality left now is the registration of the new name with the Registrar of Companies.

Several delegations had earlier met the chief minister and requested that the government rename the SRDC, officials said.

The chief minister said the time has come for a comprehensive restructuring and revival of the company. The government will not only change the board's name but also use it to accelerate the "real redevelopment" of Old Delhi and the Shahjahanabad area, she said. The Shahjahanabad Redevelopment Corporation is a special purpose vehicle

set up under Section 25 of the Companies Act, 1956.

It is tasked with protecting and conserving existing heritage sites, including ancient city walls, gates, bridges, vistas, public places, edicts and rock cut formations, and improving civic services such as water supply, sewerage, electricity supply and public transport to them.

In November 2025, during a corporation meeting, Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) Member of Parliament from Chandni Chowk Praveen Khandelwal suggested the organisation should be rebuilt from the ground up and proposed alternative names such as "Indraprastha Redevelopment Corporation" and "Chandni Chowk Redevelopment Corporation."

**SOUTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**
Follow us on @SCRailwaysIndia
Details of the Tender Notices of S Railway can be seen on our website: www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

TENDER NOTICE No. 42 to 47
DRM_W_HYB_26 dt. 10/04/2026

On behalf of the President of India, Divisional Railway Manager/Works, Hyderabad Division, South Central Railway, Secunderabad invites Open Tenders for the following works through e-procurement up to 15.00 hours of 04/05/2026.

Tender No. 42, DRM_W_HYB_26
Name of the work SC-MUE section; UPPALVAI Ballast Depot: Supplying and stacking of 50mm gauge hard and durable machine crushed stone ballast to railway's specifications at UPPALVAI Depot (Depot Collection) and loading the same in to railway hoppers / traffic ballast wagons by mechanical means (81200 Cu.M).
Approx Value Rs. 9,05,12,016 **EMD Rs.** 18,10,300

Tender No. 43, DRM_W_HYB_26
Name of the work A. Construction of boundary wall at Nizamabad Station and approaches under the jurisdiction of ADEEN/MBZ. B. HYB Div: Provision of Menstrual room at DHP C. Proposed substation building HT/LT Strengthening at Kamareddi as part of Amrit Bharat Scheme. (Civil works)
Approx Value Rs. 5,27,35,457 **EMD Rs.** 10,54,700

Tender No. 44, DRM_W_HYB_26
Name of the work Hyderabad Division: 1) Construction of Indoor Volley Ball Court at RSC/C Section SSE/Works/NLGD jurisdiction 2) Proposed Construction of new GYM with the PEB structure at RSC/C Section SSE/Works/NLGD jurisdiction 3) Repairs to ground floor, renovation of toilets in first floor room, demolition of kitchen area and construction of new hostel building in Annappurna hostel at RRC ground under the jurisdiction of SSE/W/NLGD
Approx Value Rs. 6,33,52,025 **EMD Rs.** 12,67,100

Tender No. 45, DRM_W_HYB_26
Name of the work (A) Hyderabad Division: SC -MUE section - Rebuilding of Existing Br No 735 as 1x3.0x2.0M RCC Box (By Air Pushing method) at Km 608/11-13 due to Inadequate water way between MJF - BMO stations. B) Proposed Construction of new Bridge at Rly Km 550/500-600 for crossing of Shankarampet branch canal between MZL-WDR Stations.(Pushing of already casted RCC Box and balance RCC Box Cast-in-situ and other miscellaneous works).
Approx Value Rs. 1,61,85,166 **EMD Rs.** 3,23,700

Tender No. 46, DRM_W_HYB_26
Name of the work (A)HYB Division: SC-DHNE Section: Extension of existing FOB at Thimmapur Railway Station. (B) HYB Division: SC-DHNE Section: Proposed Construction of New FOB at Yakutpura Railway Station (4M Wide FOB)
Approx Value Rs. 4,92,88,471 **EMD Rs.** 9,85,800

Tender No. 47, DRM_W_HYB_26
Name of the work Secunderabad - Dhone Section: In-Situ Welding of 60 kg rail joints at various locations between Secunderabad and Dhone Stations.
Approx Value Rs. 50,26,075 **EMD Rs.** 1,00,500

For further details visit the website www.ireps.gov.in

Divisional Railway Manager/ Works, Hyderabad
A049

For further tender conditions / details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at <https://www.ireps.gov.in> or www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

**The Pioneer**
Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Chandan Ram S/o Sh. Tej Ram Arya R/o H-16/1183, Ground Floor, Gali No.-16, Sangam Vihar, Devli Ambedkar Nagar, Distt South Delhi, Delhi-110080 declare that Chandan Ram & Chandan Ram Arya same & one Person.

PD(868)C I, Yubraj S/o S.S. Yadav, R/o 184/C-2, Niti Khand-I, Indirapuram, Ghaziabad, U.P.-201014, hereby declare that my name is recorded as "Yubraj Yadav" in my wife's Passport No. K0136358, whereas in all other documents my name is "Yubraj" (as per Aadhaar).Both names "Yubraj" and "Yubraj Yadav" refer to one and the same person.

PD(869)C I VIKAS KUMAR S/O RAJENDER PAL R/O H.NO. 3B,108A, VISHNU GARDEN, TILAK NAGAR, WEST DELHI DELHI-110018 declare that name of mine has been wrongly written as VIKAS in my minor daughter PALAK aged 13 years in her Birth Certificate No. MCDOLIR-0112-005332026. The actual name of mine is VIKAS KUMAR, which may be amended accordingly

PD(670)C I, Arpyari Devi Mother of No.16017608N Hav Kehari Singh, R/o- Vill- Nagla Ji Rajpur, PO- Ahmadgarh, Teh-Shikarpur, Dist-Bulandshahar, U.P. have changed my name from Arpyari Devi to Harpyari, vide dated 14/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(671)C I, Baby Devi Mother of- No.15230452N Hav Alok Kumar, R/o- Bagia Mangalul Po & Teh- Kaimganj, Dist-Farrukhabad, U.P.- 209502, have changed my name from Baby Devi to Vevi, vide affidavit dated 14/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(672)C I, Runa, W/o- No.14846776K Hav/SHT Ashok Kumar R/o-Chhibilwa, PO- Unaula, Teh-Sadar, Dist- Gorakhpur, U.P., have changed my name from Runa to Runa Devi, vide affidavit dated 14/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(673)C

Public Notice
We have got publication done in the Pioneer Newspaper i.e. The Pioneer English Edition and Hindi Edition on 27.03.2026 regarding mortgaged by Mrs. Patori Devi of property bearing Entire First Floor without roof rights "said floor" of Property bearing no. 184, Area measuring 70 Sq. yds, out of Kharsa No. 104/24/1, Situated in the area of village Palam, Delhi State Delhi, colony known as Raja Puri, Uttam Nagar New Delhi. In the Publication was wrongly mentioned that Original Sale Deed dated 29.01.2026 as doc. No. 708 is misplaced however correct details are Original Sale Deed dated 29.01.2016 as doc. No. 708 is misplaced. Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-4/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301. Landline(s): 9-910120 -3101683/4562809; e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

PUBLIC NOTICE
Indoor Medical Records of the patients admitted during period of 01.04.2022 to 31.03.2023 (FY 2022-23) are scheduled to be disposed of as per hospital policy. Any patient requiring his/her Medical Records may approach the undersigned within 30 days failing which the records will be disposed of without further notice.

Medical Record Officer Kailash Hospital & Heart Institute H-33, sector-27 noida G.B.Nagar
PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform that my Client, Trivedi Neelash S/o Ram Nath Trivedi D.O 17/3, Sector 108, Noida, U.P. 201304 purchased a property No.- T-5 1901 Godrej Tropical Isle, Sector 146, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, UP, in partnership with Mr. Shishir Tripathi, son of Mr. Shishir Lal Tripathi, Flat no. A, 601, Aspen Garden, Walihut Road, Goregaon East, Mumbai 400063, has voluntarily withdrawn from this partnership with effect from 04/03/2026 thus henceforth my Client, Trivedi Neelash shall be sole owner of this property and Mr. Shishir Tripathi is no longer a partner in this property. Therefore all its title, business, management, profits and losses related to this property shall now be with my client Trivedi Neelash and henceforth, Mr. Shishir Tripathi shall have no legal rights or claims over this property in any manner. It is further informed that the original documents related to this property T-5 1901 Godrej Tropical Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, UP has been lost/misplaced, as such the related authorities may kindly re-issue the documents related to this property. Sd/- Rajesh Agnawal (Adv.) Enrl No. D/5049/16 Location: Noida, Date: 15/04/2026

PUBLIC NOTICE
To be known to all that, I, Sanjeev Vijay, S/o Prembehari Vijay R/o A-4 Neha Pride, Apna Nagar, Sharnooz, Darga Road Kranti Chowk, Aurangabad, Maharashtra, 431005. The All Original Documents i.e. Allotment Letter and Fifth and Final Demand Letter and DDA Possession Letter and NCC For Electricity Water Connection and Possession Slip and Bank Challans and Others Documents of the Flat No 193, Ground Floor, Sector-A, Pocket-C, Kishan Ghar Noun As, Vasant Kunj Delhi-110070, Dda File No. F34/28/865F/SK03/11, Have been Lost/Misplaced somewhere and not traceable inspite of my best efforts. An FIR of this has been lodged in Police Station Crime Branch, Delhi vide LR.No: 230687/2026 on 13/04/2026. Any person(s) claiming any right, interest having any objection or found in possession of original documents, may write/contact with above named person at above address/phone No. 9372001015. The person claiming any right, interest, objections with respect to this notice can personally inform or write to Dy. Director, LAB(H) or Director (H)-I, D-Block, 3rd Floor, Vikas Sadan, INA, New Delhi-110023

Public Notice
Notice is hereby given to the Public at large that the conveyance deed dated 15.07.2005 executed by Valmax Construction Pvt. Ltd through Mr. Ajay Goyal and Mr. Sunder Garg in favor of Mr. Kumar Sarabhai, situated at Mouda Palast, Beni Had Nagar, Faridabad, is hereby called upon to appear before the Hon'ble District Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission-X (South-East), New Delhi, and since the Opposite Party could not be served through ordinary process, the Hon'ble Commission has been pleased to allow service by way of publication. Therefore, through this public notice, the said developer i.e. **JMS Developer & Co.** is hereby called upon to appear before the Hon'ble Commission in the said matter within the prescribed time, failing which the matter shall be proceeded ex-parte in accordance with law.
Date: 13/04/2026
Place: New Delhi
Through Advocate Manish Kumar (Delhi High Court & Delhi District and Sessions Court) Shree Legal Services and Consultants, Office at 226/2 Subhash Khand, Giri Nagar, New Delhi-110019
Email: advocate.manish@outlook.com Contact: 9871009032/7011970776/783822269

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mrs. Shaili Gupta to inform the public at large that Mrs. Shaili Gupta is the owner of the Plot No. A-1, measuring 30 Sq. Yds, Kharsa No.309/7 situated at Vandana Enclave, Khora Colony, Pargana Loni, Tehsil & Distt Ghaziabad, U.P. through Sale Deed dated 10.08.2021 (Doc. No.9067) and same will be financed & mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd., Noida. That, Original Sale Deed dated 24.12.2007 executed by Mohd. Abid in favour of Mrs. Rashmi Sharma in respect of said property, vide document no. 8869, Book No. 1, Vol no.2969, Page No.123-130, SRO-II, Ghaziabad has lost. So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP B-93B, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank Sector 2 Noida, UP-201301>Contact:90120-4269379

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given that my client, Ms. Zaibunissa, is in the process of purchasing the property bearing Plot No. 36/D, admeasuring 50 sq. yds., out of Kharsa No. 93/71, situated at Lok Priya Vihar, Makampur Colony, Pargana Loni, Tehsil and District Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, from Mr. Asif. The said property inherited by the seller, Mr. Asif, after the demise of his father, Late Mohd. Warish, who had acquired the same by virtue of GPA, ATS, and WILL, dated 15/02/2000. My client is purchasing the said property by availing a loan from Piramal Finance Ltd. All person's having any claim against or in respect of the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equity registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, family arrangement, maintenance, bequest, partnership, possession, lease, sublease, tenancy, license, lien, charge, pledge, etc., are hereby requested to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 7 days from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned. **Kamalkant Gupta (Advocate)** Unit No. FF-2, First Floor, Mahaxumi Metro Tower, Sec-4, Vaishali, Gzb., UP, Mob 9810083351

PUBLIC NOTICE
Under instructions and on behalf of my client It is hereby informed to the general public that the Applicant/Complainant **Mrs. Himani Sharma, W/o Mr. Gopal Datt Sharma, R/o Kalka Ji, New Delhi-110019**, was promised Residential plot by a developer namely **JMS Developer & Co.**, having its office at Badarpur, New Delhi, also office at Kheri Road, Sector-87, Greater Faridabad (Haryana), also resident of Village Kheri Kalan, Tehsil and District Faridabad, Haryana and also resident at Village Kulesara, Pushta Road, District Gautam Buddh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh, and also its associate **Kalka Properties, Ismlepur Extension, Faridabad**, a Residential plot admeasuring **400 Sq. Yards** situated at Faridabad, Haryana. However, despite receipt of the full & final amount, the developer failed to allot or hand over possession of the said plot. Thereafter, the developer made multiple false assurances to provide alternative plots at Sikri (near Palwal) and other locations, but no plot has been allotted till date. That the said developer has failed to respond to legal notices, summons, emails, and other communications issued by the Complainant. That the Complainant has already initiated legal proceedings bearing **Case No. CC/289/25** before the Hon'ble District Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission-X (South-East), New Delhi, and since the Opposite Party could not be served through ordinary process, the Hon'ble Commission has been pleased to allow service by way of publication. Therefore, through this public notice, the said developer i.e. **JMS Developer & Co.** is hereby called upon to appear before the Hon'ble Commission in the said matter within the prescribed time, failing which the matter shall be proceeded ex-parte in accordance with law.
Date: 13/04/2026
Place: New Delhi
Through Advocate Manish Kumar (Delhi High Court & Delhi District and Sessions Court) Shree Legal Services and Consultants, Office at 226/2 Subhash Khand, Giri Nagar, New Delhi-110019
Email: advocate.manish@outlook.com Contact: 9871009032/7011970776/783822269

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mr. Pawan Kumar to inform the public at large that Mrs. Seema W/o Mr. Pawan Kumar is purchasing the Property No. II/218-A, measuring 50.81 Sq. yards, Kharsa No.642, Situated at Village Chandrawali alias Shahdara, abadi Telivara, Ilaqa Shahdara Delhi-110032 from Mrs. Maya Kumari Singh who became owner through Sale Deed dated 27.01.2023 (Doc. No.880) and same will be financed & mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd., Noida. That, Death Certificate & Surviving Member Certificate of (1) Late Mr. Tikan Ram, (2) Late Mrs. Laj Wanti (Only SMC not available), (3) Late Mrs. Sarla Devi, (4) Late Mr. Tara Chand, (5) Late Mr. Jawhar Lal, (6) Late Mr. Pratap Singh alias Om Prakash, (7) Late Mr. Chander Prakash are not available. So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/ interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP B-93B, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank Sector 2 Noida, UP-201301>Contact:90120-4269379

6-year-old undergoes life-saving heart surgery



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A six-year-old girl suffering from a rare and complex congenital heart condition has successfully undergone a critical life-saving surgery at the Asian Institute of Medical Sciences, doctors said on Tuesday.

The child, identified as Kanishka, was born with single ventricle physiology along with multiple complications, including cTGA, non-routable ventricular septal defect, and pulmonary atresia. These conditions affect normal blood flow through the heart and require staged surgical treatment over time.

Doctors said the latest procedure performed was the Fontan surgery, which is considered the final stage of treatment for patients with single ventricle physiology. The surgery was conducted after the child showed signs of worsening health, including severe cyanosis and breathlessness during physical activity. Her oxygen saturation levels had dropped to nearly 70 per cent before the intervention.

According to the medical team, Kanishka had earlier undergone the first stage of treatment in 2020 through a Bidirectional Glenn procedure.

Govt schools to roll out year-long environmental awareness drive

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Aimed at sensitising students to challenges such as plastic waste, biodiversity loss, air pollution and climate change, government schools in the national Capital will undertake a year-long series of awareness and activity-based programmes on environmental issues beginning this month.

According to a circular issued by the Directorate of Education (DoE), the initiative will focus on structured monthly themes, starting with awareness on plastic pollution in April.

The circular said schools will organise activities such as essay writing, painting competitions and campaigns discouraging the use of single-use plastics, along with observance of Earth Day on April 22.

It further said that May will be dedicated to wildlife and biodiversity, with activities including slogan writing, skits and painting competitions.

Schools will also mark the International Day for



Biological Diversity on May 22 while promoting lifestyle changes such as conserving electricity and adopting environmentally responsible habits.

The months of June and July will emphasise ending plastic pollution through practical interventions like workshops on waste management, poster-making competitions and the use of separate bins for wet and dry waste. The circular added that Environment Day on June 5 will be celebrated during this period, it said.

The circular also outlined that in July, schools will conduct awareness drives on wildlife conservation, including debates, quizzes

and observance of nature conservation-related events. In parallel, water pollution awareness will be taken up, with a focus on proper disposal of chemicals and medical waste and discouragement of harmful practices such as pouring grease into drains.

According to the DoE, August activities will include Van Mahotsav celebrations and promotion of zero-waste practices in schools. Students will participate in plantation drives, clean campus campaigns, composting activities and initiatives like plogging. It noted that Akshay Urja Day on August 20 will also be observed.

CM, Speaker pay tributes to BR Ambedkar on birth anniversary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Speaker Vijender Gupta and other BJP leaders on Tuesday paid tributes to Dr BR Ambedkar on his 135th birth anniversary, saying her government is working for the empowerment of every citizen in the city.

She offered floral tributes at his statue at 26, Alipur Road, his Mahaparinirvan site, and paid homage to Baba Saheb's legacy. To mark the occasion, the Chief Minister inaugurated and formally dedicated state-of-the-art water ATMs for public use in the Shalimar Bagh Assembly constituency.

In a post on X, she said Ambedkar's thoughts and ideals give energy to her government to work towards a progressive and inclusive society.

"Baba Saheb's life struggle



for ensuring justice, equality and rights to even the last person in society is a source of inspiration for all of us. The Delhi government is fully committed to the empowerment and all-round development of every citizen as per his ideals," she said.

Marking Ambedkar Jayanti, the chief minister also inaugurated water ATMs at several locations in Shalimar Bagh, her assembly constituency.

The ATMs have a capacity to provide 2,000 litres of pure water per hour, based on a five-stage RO technique.

A total of seven water ATMs have been installed across wards 55, 56 and 57 in the constituency. She also distributed water ATM cards to local residents to ensure regular access to safe drinking water. Equipped with modern technology, these facilities are expected to play a key role in providing clean, safe and easily accessible water to the public.

The Chief Minister said people will be able to use water ATM cards to take 20 litres of water every day, and the machines will be monitored round-the-clock.

Govt approves 4.72-km flood protection wall along Ring Road

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Rekha Gupta Government in Delhi has approved the construction of a 4.72-kilometre flood protection wall along a vulnerable stretch of the Ring Road to shield the capital from Yamuna floods.

Sharing details, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced that a 4.72-kilometre-long wall will be built from Majnu Ka Tila to the Old Railway Bridge (ORB), with a target to complete the project before the next monsoon season.

The project draws on recommendations made in the August 2024 report of the Joint Flood Committee (JFC), which was based on

detailed hydraulic modelling and data analysis by experts from the Central Water and Power Research Station (CWPRS), Pune.

According to project details, the proposed flood wall will cover a stretch of approximately 4.72 km. Of this, about 850 metres in sections identified as high-risk flood zones will be constructed using reinforced cement concrete, while the remaining 3,870 metres will consist of brick or stone masonry barriers. The wall will be designed to stand roughly six feet above the expected maximum flood level to create a safety margin and prevent floodwaters from entering adjoining urban areas.

Once in place, the wall will

act as a robust barrier, preventing Yamuna waters from spilling into residential areas. It is expected to provide a strong layer of protection to vulnerable localities such as Civil Lines, Kashmere Gate, Yamuna Bazaar and Majnu Ka Tila areas that have historically faced the worst impact whenever water levels rise.

For decades, floodwaters have entered the city through low-lying pockets around Majnu Ka Tila, often submerging stretches of the Ring Road and bringing normal life in Delhi to a standstill. From the devastating floods of 1978 to more recent episodes in 2023 and 2025, this stretch has remained particularly exposed.

The wall will be designed to rise roughly six feet above



the anticipated maximum flood level to prevent river water from entering nearby residential and commercial zones. The proposed wall will be built close to one of the city's major transport corridors, making the project

significant for maintaining traffic movement during flood events. The Ring Road runs parallel to parts of the Yamuna and connects several key neighbourhoods and commercial districts in the northern part of the capital.

Flooding along this corridor has previously caused major disruptions to daily commuting and logistics movement.

The initiative follows the severe flooding of 2023 that affected several parts of north Delhi and disrupted traffic and daily activity in the capital. The Chief Minister noted that the existing embankments are no longer adequate to deal with future challenges, making it imperative to adopt a durable, long-term solution.

Official data shows that the Yamuna touched a record level of 208.66 metres in 2023, surpassing the previous high of 1978. In 2025 as well, the river crossed the danger mark of 205.33 metres, rising to 207.48 metres.

Warning that such extreme

situations could recur, the Chief Minister said the proposed wall offers a strong and lasting safeguard.

The Chief Minister said the decision, formally cleared as part of the budget, is rooted in the city's repeated experience with severe flooding. She underlined that the Government is now moving decisively towards a permanent solution, rather than relying on temporary or stop-gap measures.

In 2024, the Joint Flood Committee (JFC) had recommended to construct a wall, which was based on detailed hydraulic modelling and data analysis by experts from the Central Water and Power Research Station (CWPRS), Pune.

The study had clearly iden-

tified the construction of a flood protection wall along this stretch of the Ring Road as the most viable long-term solution. Gupta also pointed out that no concrete decision was taken by the previous government, leaving these areas repeatedly vulnerable to flooding.

Explaining the broader impact, she said the wall will serve as a protective shield between the river and the city, preventing overflow onto roads. It will also help check riverbank erosion, thereby safeguarding nearby roads and building foundations. In addition, the structure is expected to curb illegal dumping of waste along the riverbanks, helping preserve the floodplain and protect the Yamuna's ecosystem.

LG intervenes after brigadier assault; two accused arrested

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Tuesday said he was "deeply concerned" by the assault on a serving Army brigadier, his son, and his wife in the Vasant Enclave area of southwest Delhi and said he personally spoke with the Police Commissioner and the DCP, directing them to ensure a thorough and swift investigation.

Delhi Police subsequently arrested the two men who were seen drinking inside a luxury car outside the officer's residence, which triggered the incident.

"I have personally spoken with Brigadier PS Arora to enquire about the incident and their well-being. I also spoke with the police commissioner and the DCP, directing them to ensure a thorough and swift investigation, leading to immediate and appropriate action against those responsible," Sandhu said.

He also directed the Delhi Police to provide full securi-



ty to the officer and his family.

DCP South West Amit Goel confirmed the arrests of the two accused seen inside the vehicle. They have been identified as Satender alias Sonu, 49, son of Banwari Lal, a resident of 8/123, Mehram Nagar, New Delhi, and Sanjay Sharma, 56, son of Laxmi Narayan Sharma, a resident of 8/142, Mehram Nagar.

After the prompt action of the Delhi police, the LG appreciated the police administration. He wrote on the social media site X, "Appreciate the much-

needed swift action by Delhi police in the Vasant Enclave case. The two key accused arrested and the vehicle seized, the investigation must be fast-tracked to ensure all accomplices are brought to justice."

"We remain committed to ensuring the safety of our citizens and maintaining the accepted standards of law and order." He added.

Satender is the Director of Chaudhary Aviation Pvt Ltd, a firm that provides chartered and cargo flight services and is involved in the

sale and purchase of aircraft and aircraft parts. Sanjay Sharma runs Pandit Ji Dhaba at 8/252, Mehram Nagar. Both are being examined. The Mercedes vehicle in which they were found drinking has also been seized.

A case vide FIR No. 50/26 under Sections 115(2), 126(2), 351(2), 79, 191(2), and 190 of BNS has been registered on the complaint of the wife of the officer. During a preliminary inquiry, a lapse was found on the part of the inspector handling the investigation, and he has been suspended and sent to District Lines.

The assault occurred Saturday night after Brigadier PS Arora and his son, Tejas Singh Arora, saw two men drinking in a luxury car outside their home while on an after-dinner walk.

When they politely asked the men to move, the situation escalated. The family called the police, and according to Tejas, officers on arrival declined to record their complaint. One man spoke to the responding officer by phone, after which the officer post-

poned action.

Shortly after, seven to eight men arrived in two vehicles and began assaulting the brigadier and his son while threatening the officer's wife. Tejas said he was beaten continuously for around 15 minutes in the presence of police personnel, who did not intervene.

Tejas sustained injuries to his face, neck, and palm. The brigadier's wife alleged that the responding officer told her he could act only after his team arrived and that even after the attackers left, the officer refused to take them to the police station. "You are not the kind of people who deserve to sit on the seats," she quoted the officer as saying.

At the police station, the family alleged they were made to wait for around half an hour. Despite Tejas bleeding, police insisted on a medical report before registering the complaint and provided no vehicle for hospital transport. The brigadier eventually took his son to the Army Hospital for treatment and X-rays.

SUV crash kills toddler in Alipur, driver flees

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A two-year-old girl died after being thrown out of a car when a speeding SUV rammed into it from behind in outer north Delhi's Alipur area. The driver of the SUV fled the scene after the collision, abandoning the vehicle.

The accident took place around 2 pm on Sunday near a traffic signal on GTK Road. According to police, the SUV, identified as a Toyota Fortuner, was allegedly being driven at a high speed of around 100 to 120 km/h when it hit a Maruti Celerio carrying six occupants, including two children.

The impact of the collision was severe. Police said the smaller car spun out of control and crashed into a road divider. The force of the crash caused the toddler, identified as Devanshi, to be thrown out of the vehicle



through an open window.

A senior police officer said the child was seated on the lap of her mother's friend in the front passenger seat. The window was open because the air conditioning system of the car was not working. The sudden impact caused her to be ejected from the vehicle and fall onto the road. The child suffered critical head injuries and was immediately rushed to Satyawadi Raja Harish Chandra Hospital in Narela. Doctors declared her dead on arrival, police said.

The car was being driven by Arti, the mother of the deceased child. She was trav-

elling with her two toddlers, along with Ravindra Singh, 47, his son Deepak, and his daughter Jyoti. The group was returning from Rani Khara at the time of the incident.

In his statement to police, complainant Ravindra Singh, a resident of Sonipat in Haryana, said the windows of the car were open due to a malfunctioning air conditioning system. He stated that his daughter, Jyoti, was holding the child when the speeding SUV struck their vehicle from behind.

Police said the collision occurred just as the traffic signal turned green. The sudden impact caused the car to lose balance and spin before hitting the divider. Following the accident, the SUV driver fled the scene, leaving the vehicle behind. Police have seized both the damaged vehicles and initiated efforts to identify and trace the accused driver.

Ravindra Singh and Arti also sustained injuries in the incident. They were taken to the hospital for treatment and are reported to be stable. Police teams reached the spot soon after receiving information and carried out a detailed inspection. A crime team was also called to examine the scene and collect evidence as part of the investigation.

An FIR has been registered under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. Officials said CCTV footage from the area is being analysed to track the movement of the SUV before and after the accident. "We are trying to identify how the driver escaped from the scene and whether he used any public or private transport to flee," an officer said.

Police said efforts are ongoing to locate the accused and ascertain the exact sequence of events that led to the fatal crash.

Govt plan 'Qurani Van' as part of themed-forest initiative

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In the lines of Ritu Van, Nakshatra Van, Rashi Van, Thirthankar Van, Bel Van, and Panchvati Van, the Delhi government's forest department is planning to add a new "Qurani Van" to its list of themed forests in the national capital as part of its broader push to expand green cover while linking ecology with cultural traditions.

According to officials, the plantation plan for the Qurani Van is still under discussion, but it may include species that hold cultural or religious significance in Islamic traditions, such as date palms and similar flora.

The proposed Qurani Van is aimed at increasing plantations in Delhi while also strengthening the connection between people and nature, the official said, adding that the initiative is designed to reflect the long-



standing interconnection between communities and the natural environment. Planting trees is regarded as Sadaqatul Jaariya (ongoing charity). The one who plants trees will be rewarded for it as long as any living being benefits from it.

"These forests will enhance plantations in the national capital, add ecological value and attract more people to forest areas while educating them about different cultural aspects in an engaging manner," the official said.

The development is being added to the broader

themed-forest project that was reported earlier, which includes a series of "special vans", such as Ritu Van, Nakshatra Van, Rashi Van, Thirthankar Van, Bel Van and Panchvati Van.

Spanning over two acres in various regions of the Central and South Ridge, the plantations will incorporate themes like zodiac signs, ancient traditions, and sacred groves. This initiative seeks to provide educational experiences linked to cultural themes in an engaging manner.

Ritu Van will feature trees

linked to different seasons to showcase changes in flowering and foliage through the year, while Nakshatra Van will include plants associated with stars and constellations.

Rashi Van will be based on zodiac signs, Thirthankar Van will honour Jain spiritual teachers, Bel Van will focus on the bael tree, and Panchvati Van will draw from the concept of sacred groves linked to the five elements, the senior official said.

The forest department has started the process to develop several of these themed forests in the Central Ridge, while separate work on Nakshatra Van and Bel Van will be taken up in the South Ridge as part of the broader plan to create such green spaces across Delhi, an official tender document said. Bamboo huts and gravel-lined tracks will also be made as part of the project, according to the tender.

Delhi-Dehradun expressway is power of double-engine Govts: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta attended the inauguration of the Delhi-Dehradun highway on Tuesday and said travel time between the two cities will reduce from six hours to around two and a half hours. "This is the power of a double-engine Government. Delhi is continuously moving towards better development," the chief minister said.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday inaugurated the Delhi-Dehradun economic corridor, which will cut travel time between the two cities to nearly half. The 213 km-long, six-lane, access-controlled Delhi-Dehradun economic corridor has been built at a cost of over ₹12,000 crore.

The corridor traverses Delhi, Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand and will reduce travel time between Delhi and Dehradun from over six hours currently to around



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Deputy Chief Minister Parvesh Verma and others greet the gathering during the inauguration of Delhi-Dehradun Expressway in New Delhi

two and a half hours, according to an official statement.

She noted that projects worth nearly ₹1.25 lakh crore are currently underway in the capital under the Union Ministry of Road Transport and Highways, reshaping the city's urban landscape.

Highlighting the broader significance of the expressway, the Chief Minister said it is not merely a road project but a vital link that

connects Delhi's modern infrastructure with the spiritual ethos of Uttarakhand, often referred to as Devbhoomi. "It is a true confluence of development and faith," she said.

Delhi LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu said in a post on X that the expressway was a "game changer" for Delhi residents. "It will reduce travel time to Dehradun from nearly six hours to just

about two and a half hours. With seamless, signal-free connectivity beginning from key points such as Akshardham, Geeta Colony, and Shastri Park, it promises to significantly decongest city roads while catalysing regional trade, tourism, and economic activity," Sandhu said.

He dubbed the inauguration of the economic corridor "yet another historic

milestone" in India's infrastructure journey. This mega project stands as a powerful testament to the Prime Minister's "transformative vision" coupled with the "dynamic execution" led by Union Minister Nitin Gadkari, he added.

The expressway is expected to reduce travel time between Delhi and Dehradun from around 6-7 hours to just 2-2.5 hours, bringing substantial relief to commuters and boosting tourism and economic activity. Gupta pointed out that India's expressway and high-speed corridor network has expanded to over 3,000 km, while the national highway network has grown from about 51,000 km to nearly 1,46,000 km, an indicator of the country's accelerated infrastructure growth. Referring to the strength of 'double-engine governance,' she said better coordination between the Centre and the Delhi government is helping the city move ahead at a faster pace.

Fake cosmetics racket busted, 4 held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police Crime Branch has busted a large counterfeit cosmetics manufacturing unit in the capital and arrested four persons, including the alleged kingpin, in connection with the illegal production and supply of fake branded products.

Deputy Commissioner of Police, Crime Branch, Delhi, Harsh Indora, said the operation led to the seizure of over 20,000 counterfeit items, including filled tubes, packed products, raw materials, and packaging equipment. "This action dismantled an organised network involved in manufacturing and distributing fake cosmetic products. We have recovered a large quantity of counterfeit goods and arrested the key accused involved in the racket," he said.

The accused have been identified as Neeraj Gupta, the alleged mastermind, along with his associates



Ravi, Suresh Kumar Rajput, and Dinesh Chandra Sati. All four were actively involved in manufacturing, packaging, and distributing counterfeit versions of Veet Hair Removal Cream in local markets.

Police said the racket was operating from an illegal manufacturing unit in Sanjay Gandhi Transport Nagar in the Badli area of Delhi. The unit was unearthed during a raid conducted on April 6 following a complaint from an authorised representative of Reckitt Benckiser India Pvt Ltd regarding the sale of fake products under its brand name.

A team of the Crime Branch carried out the operation under the supervision of

senior officers after receiving specific intelligence inputs. During the raid, the police found a fully operational setup where counterfeit cosmetic products were being produced using substandard materials and packed in fake branding designed to resemble original products.

A case has been registered under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Copyright Act at the Crime Branch police station. Officials said the accused were engaged in large-scale manufacturing and distribution of fake goods, causing financial loss to the original company and posing potential health risks to consumers.

IN FOCUS



Union Communications and Minister of Development of North Eastern Region Jyotiraditya Scindia on Tuesday inaugurated a Philatelic Exhibition "Ek Bharat, Shreshth Bharat: Celebrating India's Unity and Democracy through Postage Stamps" at the Pradhanmantri Sanghralay. PIONEER PHOTO

Delhi-Dehradun Corridor to boost connectivity: Yogi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Saharanpur

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Tuesday said the newly made Delhi-Dehradun Economic Corridor will significantly boost connectivity and economic growth.

Addressing a public gathering in Saharanpur ahead of the corridor's dedicated to the nation by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Adityanath congratulated people of the region and expressed gratitude to the prime minister, Union Transport Minister Nitin Gadkari and officials of the National Highways Authority of India for executing the project.

Adityanath also paid tributes to B R Ambedkar on his birth anniversary.

UP Governor Anandiben Patel, deputy chief ministers Keshav Prasad Maurya and Brajesh Pathak, BJP state chief Pankaj Chaudhary, among others were present at the event in Saharanpur. They were virtually connected with the PM's event for the corridor



inauguration taking place in Dehradun. "This Delhi-Baghat-Saharanpur-Dehradun Economic Corridor is a major gift for the region. It will accelerate economic development and improve connectivity," he said. The chief minister said travel time between Saharanpur and Delhi, which earlier took five to six hours, will now be reduced to around two-and-a-half to three hours.

He added that the corridor will also improve connectivity to Dehradun, benefiting trade, agriculture and local industries. Referring to Ambedkar's 135th birth anniversary, the chief minister said the occasion holds special significance as the architect of the Constitution laid the foundation for equality and social justice in India.

Samrat Choudhary: From ousted minister to CM

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Patna

It has been a chequered political journey for Samrat Choudhary, who began his political career as a minister in Bihar nearly three decades ago, only to be removed by the then Governor following allegations about his eligibility.

Things seem to have come full circle for the 57-year-old leader, whose meteoric rise in the BJP after joining it nine years ago culminated in becoming the party's first chief minister in the State.

Choudhary, earlier known as Rakesh Kumar, had first hit headlines in 1999, when the then chief minister Rabri Devi inducted him into her cabinet.

His induction into the cabinet was said to have been the result of an understanding between the Samata Party and the RJD.

However, a complaint soon reached the Raj Bhavan (now Lok Bhavan) that Choudhary, who was then not a member of the state legislature, had not completed 25



years of age. Accordingly, the then Governor Suraj Bhan ordered Choudhary's sacking, in a rare instance of the removal of a minister being effected without the government not recommending the same.

After his unceremonious dismissal, the RJD, headed by Rabri Devi's husband Lalu Prasad, fielded him in the assembly polls of 2000, and Choudhary was re-inducted as a minister, this time to enjoy a full term. In 2005, the RJD lost power to the JD(U)-BJP combine, but

Choudhary remained with the RJD and was appointed as the chief whip of the party five years later.

By 2014, Choudhary seemed to have been disenchanted with the RJD, and he led a split in the party and joined the JD(U) government, then headed by Jitan Ram Manjhi.

Manjhi stepped down months later after Nitish Kumar, his patron, decided to make a comeback as the chief minister. This caused Choudhary to lose his ministerial berth. In 2017, he joined the BJP, and, by virtue of being a Koeri.

Choudhary then transformed from a staunch critic of Nitish Kumar, while the JD(U) supremo was out of the NDA, to a trusted aide of the alliance partner whose backing was vital for his own rise to the top. More than six feet tall, Choudhary, till a few years ago, was always seen in public with a turban on his head. In private, the BJP leader used to joke that he would take off his headgear only after unseating the JD(U) supremo from power. In 2024, when Nitish Kumar

returned to the NDA "for good", Choudhary, who had by now risen to be the state BJP president, superseding many old party hands, was named as a Deputy CM.

The naming of Choudhary and Vijay Kumar Sinha, another vocal critic of Nitish Kumar, as Deputy CMs was viewed by some political commentators as the BJP's attempt to offer reconciliation, while cynics saw it as an attempt to slight the JD(U) supremo.

Choudhary took to his new role as fish to water and, in a span of less than two years, emerged as a leader whom Nitish Kumar could trust enough to part with the crucial Home portfolio, which he had chosen to keep with himself since 2005. Besides the Home portfolio which was allocated to him in November last year after the NDA won a stunning victory in elections, another episode had helped Choudhary catch public attention in the thick of the assembly polls.

While canvassing in Tarapur, an assembly seat represented by his

father Shakuni Choudhary for a record number of six times, Union Home Minister Amit Shah urged the people to vote for his son, promising that he would be made "a big man". Choudhary, who had returned to direct elections after spending nearly a decade in the legislative council, won Tarapur by a comprehensive margin of 45,000 votes.

The new CM was born in a village in Bihar's Munger district to Parvati Devi and Shakuni Choudhary, an army man-turned-politician who had started as a Congress man and later switched allegiance to Lalu Prasad and Nitish Kumar.

Choudhary now faces the daunting challenge of transforming Bihar into a BJP stronghold like the rest of the Hindi heartland, while accommodating allies like the JD(U), which is likely to feel a tinge of resentment over no longer being "the party of the chief minister", and smaller allies which have been prone to change loyalties over trifles.

Women's reservation: No fixed LS seat count; South likely to gain

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Constitution amendment bill proposing 33 per cent reservation for women from 2029 does not specify the exact number of Lok Sabha seats to be enhanced from the current 543, stating that the total membership should be "not more than" 850, with the final figure to be decided by a delimitation commission.

Government sources said the allocation of seats among states and union territories will be based on proportional representation, and southern states



are likely to benefit under this formula.

The final number of seats will be determined by a delimitation commission, and the bill therefore does not specify an exact

strength, stating only that the Lok Sabha shall comprise "not more than 815 members" chosen via direct elections from states and "not more than 35 members" from Union

Territories. "The figure of 850 represents only the upper limit for the total number of Lok Sabha seats," sources said. The 2011 Census will serve as the reference point, and due to more effective population control in southern states, they could see a relative advantage in seat allocation compared to northern states, where population growth has been higher. Sources said Prime Minister Narendra Modi will speak in the Lok Sabha on the bill and provide details on the "historic" step taken by the government.

Discussion and voting in

the Lok Sabha will take place on April 16 and 17.

A total of 18 hours has been allotted for the debate on the three legislations — the Constitution (One Hundred and Thirty-first Amendment) Bill, 2026; the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026; and the Delimitation Bill, 2026.

Discussions and voting in the Rajya Sabha will take place on April 18.

A duration of 10 hours has been set for the proceedings. Sources also said that the election for the Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha will be held on April 16 and 17.

No scope for large aircraft at Kargil airport: Ladakh LG

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kargil

Ladakh Lt Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Tuesday said there is currently no scope for operating large aircraft at Kargil Airport due to runway constraints, though smaller planes



could be introduced after necessary upgrades, subject to commercial viability.

Speaking to reporters before concluding his four-day tour of the district, Saxena said he inspected the airport — located 6 km from the main town and operated by the Indian Air Force — following repeated public demand for its operationalisation.

"After holding a detailed discussion with officials, including IAF representatives, I came to know that the runway, measuring about 6,000 feet, is short, narrow, and in a worn-out condition, making it unsuitable for large aircraft operations. Even with

a possible extension of up to 3,000 feet, operational challenges would remain," he said.

He added that the landing approach requires a difficult turn for large aircraft, while a mountain ahead poses a challenge during takeoff.

FROM PAGE - 1

Police probe conspiracy behind Noida unrest

"Some have been taken into custody and the rest are being identified." Anti-social elements, she added, escalated the situation once the core workforce had stepped back.

What began as a peaceful agitation by factory workers demanding a wage hike on par with neighbouring Haryana quickly drew an estimated 40,000-45,000 participants across 80-83 locations, including Sectors 62, Phase-2, 60, 63, 84 and parts of Greater Noida. By 9:30 am, roads were blocked, the Noida Expressway choked, and key arteries like NH-9 turned into parking lots. Police deployed nearly 3,000 personnel. While most workers dispersed after initial counselling, violence erupted in pockets.

As arrests continue and digital trails are followed, police sources say the investigation is shifting from street violence to the command-and-control network that allegedly hijacked a wage protest. Whether it was local anti-social elements, coordinated bots or cross-border handlers, officials are clear: Monday's mayhem was no spontaneous outburst. The genuine anger of Noida's factory workers has been weaponised, they allege and the full extent of that conspiracy is now under the microscope.

The Uttar Pradesh Special Task Force (STF) is tracing digital footprints. Investigators have flagged over 50 bot accounts created within 24 hours that amplified inflammatory content and false narratives. Two FIRs target these rumour mills. Police are also probing funding sources and links to earlier labour-related arrests in Manesar.

Uttar Pradesh Labour Minister Anil Rajbhar called the violence a "well-planned conspiracy" to disrupt law and order and industrial growth. Agencies are now examining a possible Pakistan link, citing the recent arrests of four suspected terrorists in Meerut and Noida who were in contact with handlers across the border. "In such a situation, the possibility of a conspiracy to create instability gains strength" Rajbhar said, adding that anti-national forces could be attempting to exploit worker unrest.

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath did not mince words and warned of a potential Naxal revival. "Naxalism is at the point of elimination, but attempts to revive it could be part of a larger conspiracy," he said. "Some protests may have involved misleading and disruptive elements" posing as labour representatives. The chief minister said that he has directed intensified intelligence gathering in industrial zones and strongest action possible against infiltrators.

Despite the chaos, the state Government moved swiftly on the workers' core demands. Four of five key demands including wage revision, weekly offs and grievance cells have been accepted. A high-powered committee comprising labour, MSME and industry officials has been formed to resolve remaining issues. Late-night meetings with over 2,500 workers were held even as the probe intensified to identify the real

faces behind the planned conspiracy to instigate violence in the neighbourhood of India's national capital.

Govt eyes constitutional changes to enforce...

"The next census and the consequential delimitation exercise thereafter will take considerable time and thus, delay the effective and dedicated participation of women in our democratic polity. Hence, the objective of the proposed bill is to operationalise one-third reservation for women, including women belonging to the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes, in the House of the People and the legislative assemblies of the states, the National Capital Territory of Delhi and the Union Territories through delimitation exercise to be undertaken on the basis of the population figures of the latest published census," says the statement of objects and reasons of the draft Constitution amendment bill.

Asserting that it is the "collective sentiment" of the nation, PM Modi who earlier in the day wrote an open letter to women citing about Women's reservation said, "This is the wish of every sister and daughter of this country, and we must fulfil it with unanimity."

The PM asserted that Indian democracy will become stronger and more vibrant if elections to the Lok Sabha and various assemblies in 2029 are held with a women's quota fully in place.

India proposed to grow at 6.5%: IMF

At 3.1 per cent for 2026 and 3.2 per cent for 2027, the forecasts mark a deceleration from the estimated 3.4 per cent achieved in 2025.

At market exchange rates, world output is projected to grow by 2.6 per cent in both 2026 and 2027, it said. The relatively modest downward revision to global growth in the reference forecast relative to the January 2026 WEO Update owes to continued tailwinds partially offsetting the negative shocks from the conflict, including lower tariffs, preexisting policy support, and carryover from stronger-than-expected outturns at the end of 2025 and the first quarter of 2026 in some cases. (PTI)

Protests continue in Noida despite wage...

Police officers conducted flag marches and deployed heavy reinforcements, including 15 companies of Rapid Action Force (RAF), Provincial Armed Constabulary (PAC) and Quick Reaction Teams, alongside drone surveillance. The administration continues engaging workers through committees, dismissing rumours of a flat ₹20,000 minimum wage as inaccurate and attributing

some violence to outsiders rather than local labourers.

The protests, which erupted on a large scale on Monday, involved over 40,000 workers across nearly 80 locations in the Gautam Buddha Nagar district. Workers have drawn a leaf out from Haryana's 35 per cent wage hike, demanding that Uttar Pradesh match or exceed it. Many earn as little as ₹13,000 monthly, with complaints of exploitative practices such as short-term terminations to avoid allowance hikes and inadequate overtime pay.

On Tuesday, even after the Uttar Pradesh Government announced an interim wage revision late Monday night effective retrospectively from April 1, 2026, the demonstrations persisted. For Gautam Buddha Nagar and Ghaziabad, unskilled workers' wages rose from ₹11,313 to ₹13,690, semi-skilled from ₹12,445 to ₹15,059, and skilled from ₹13,940 to ₹16,868. Similar hikes were notified for other categories.

UP Government officials described the move as a goodwill gesture, with additional worker welfare measures like pre-November bonuses, double pay for overtime and weekly off-days, women-chaired sexual harassment committees, and complaint boxes at workplaces. Yet, many workers dismissed the revisions as insufficient and unverified at the factory level.

By late Tuesday, authorities reported relative calm in key areas like Cleo County, Gari Chaukhandi, Sector 70, and Phase 2, with law and order re-established through sustained policing. Traffic advisories remained in place on routes like the Noida Expressway and NH-9, but major disruptions eased.

The Noida protests highlight deeper issues in India's industrial belts: wage stagnation amid inflation, contract labour vulnerabilities, and the ripple effects of regional policy differences.

Pakistan presses for fresh US-Iran talks

A senior Hezbollah official on Monday said the Lebanese militant group will not abide by any agreements that may result from direct Lebanon-Israel talks set to start Tuesday in Washington.

Lebanese officials hope to broker a ceasefire in the Israel-Hezbollah war that has killed at least 2,089 people in Lebanon. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has said he doesn't want a ceasefire, and the goal is Hezbollah's disarmament and a potential peace agreement between Lebanon and Israel.

Meanwhile, Italian Premier Giorgia Meloni said Tuesday that her Government has suspended the automatic renewal of a defence agreement with Israel, citing "the current situation."

Meloni and other Italian Government officials have strongly condemned Israel's air and bombing campaign in Lebanon, which has hit civilians as well as an Italian convoy that is part of a UN peacekeeping force. The agreement, rat-

ified in 2005, includes ongoing cooperation between the two countries' defence ministries and armed forces. It is automatically renewed every five years. A US blockade of Iranian ports that began Monday and Iran's threatened retaliation set up an extraordinary showdown posing serious risks for the global economy and raising the spectre of a ceasefire collapse and resumed fighting.

Trump dials PM Modi on West Asia conflict

Gor said the leaders discussed developments in the Middle East and broader India-US engagement. "They just got off the phone a few minutes ago. The President gave an update on what is happening in the Middle East, along with some of the big-ticket items happening in Washington between the United States and India," he said.

He also indicated that economic engagement could deepen further, saying "some big-ticket deals, including on energy, are expected between India and the US in the next few days and weeks."

During the exchange, Modi told Trump, "People of India love you," while Trump responded, "I just want you to know we all love you." The leaders had earlier spoken on February 2 to review progress on a bilateral trade deal, and again on March 24 to discuss the evolving regional situation.

The latest interaction comes amid continued uncertainty over the fragile ceasefire and expectations of further diplomatic engagement between the United States and Iran. End-

PM Modi launches Delhi-Dehradun corridor

Citing recent developments in the Delhi-Western UP-Uttarakhand region, the PM noted the expansion of Delhi Metro, the launch of Metro services in Meerut, the inauguration of the Delhi-Meerut Namoo Bharat Rail, and the start of the Noida International Airport, all within a short span of time. "Imagine the scale at which infrastructure is being built across the entire country, what is happening in this one small region is just a glimpse of that," Modi remarked.

Elaborating on the benefits of the Delhi-Dehradun Economic Corridor, the PM said that in addition to significant reduction in travel time and costs for commuters and freight, farmers and animal herders will also benefit as their produce will reach larger markets sooner. He observed that the corridor, which passes through Ghaziabad, Baghpat, Baraut, Shamli and Saharanpur, is poised to revitalise these cities in UP as well.

Emphasising the tourism potential of the new expressway, the Prime Minister noted that Dehradun, Haridwar, Rishikesh, Mussoorie and the Char Dham circuit will all be more accessi-

ble. He added that Uttarakhand is increasingly becoming a premier destination for winter tourism, winter sports and destination weddings.

Union Minister of Road Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari spoke about the Government's focus on economic corridors across the nation and gave details of the various infrastructural projects underway in Uttarakhand.

Uttarakhand chief minister Pushkar Singh Dhama also addressed the event which was virtually attended by the Delhi CM Rekha Gupta and her UP counterpart Yogi Adityanath.

Earlier, Modi offered prayers at the Dat Kali Mandir at the border of UP and Uttarakhand in the presence of UP Governor Anandiben Patel and CM Yogi Adityanath. He took out a roadshow on a stretch about 12 kilometres long to reach the venue of his public address.

Choudhary elected BJP leader as Nitish exits...

Following Choudhary's election legislative party leader of the BJP, the oath ceremony for the next CM of Bihar is likely to be held on Wednesday, with an expected attendance by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, some of his cabinet colleagues and senior BJP leaders.

"Samrat Choudhary was unanimously elected as the BJP's legislative party leader," said Union minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, whom the BJP parliamentary board named central observer for the legislature party leader's election. The BJP is the single largest party in the 243-strong Bihar assembly with 89 MLAs.

Nitish Kumar submitted his resignation as CM early on Tuesday after dissolving his Cabinet following its last meeting in Patna. "I have done a lot of work for the people of Bihar. Recently, I decided to leave the post of chief minister...and therefore, after today's cabinet meeting, I met the governor and submitted my resignation to him," Nitish posted on social media.

What came as a surprise was the sidelining of Nitish's son. The JD(U) had bargained hard for one deputy CM post for Nishant Kumar.

Now, however, three senior leaders from JD(U) — Vijendra Yadav, Vijay Chaudhary and Shrawan Kumar — have emerged as frontrunners in the race for deputy CM in Bihar. Sources indicate that two of these three leaders are likely to be appointed in the new Government. The 243-member Bihar Assembly allows for a Cabinet of up to 36 ministers. Sources said most current ministers may be retained.

The 202-strong NDA also includes 85 MLAs of the JD(U), besides 19 of the Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) and five of the Hindustani Awam Morcha, headed by Union ministers Chirag Paswan and Jitan Ram Manjhi, respectively. In addition, there are five MLAs of Rashtriya Lok Morcha, led by Rajya Sabha MP Upendra Kushwaha.



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Law and Justice Arjun Ram Meghwal led a plantation drive and Shramdaanat on Tuesday at Windsor Place Roundabout NDMC Park Janpath, New Delhi, as part of the ongoing Swachhta Pakhwada.

Underscoring the Government's commitment to environmental sustainability and cleanliness, the Minister planted a sapling under the ongoing Swachhta Pakhwada and encouraged all to contribute wholeheartedly in planation of trees.

Government circulates bills to increase Lok Sabha seats

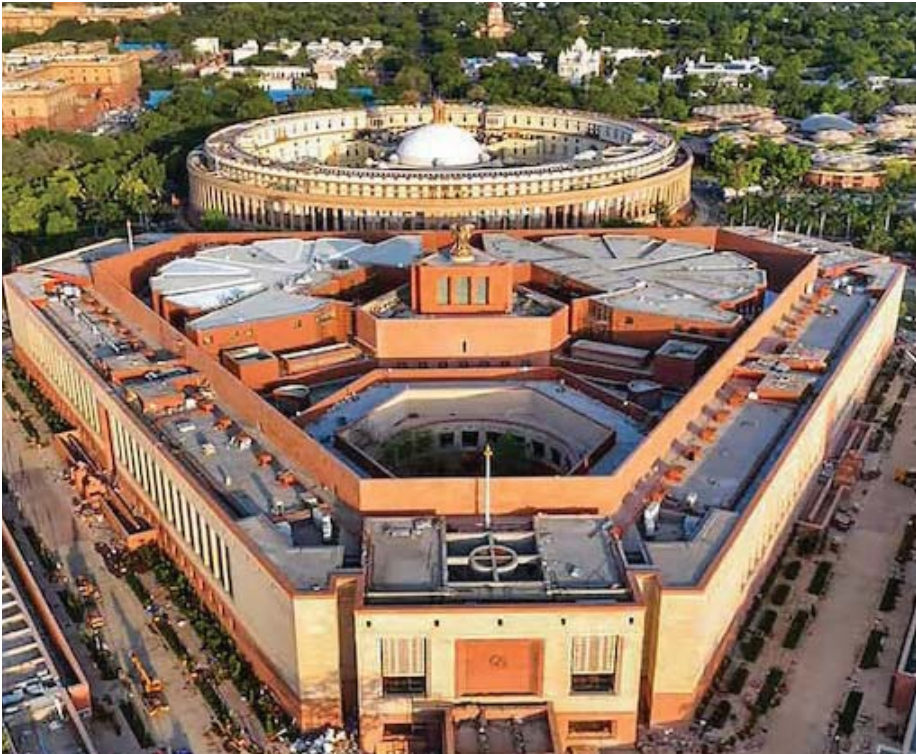
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Hardly 48 hours before the Special Session of the Parliament, Government on Tuesday evening circulated three Constitution amendment bills to increase the seats in Lok Sabha up to 850 and change of Delimitation Act to find seats reserved for women.

The Delimitation Bill, 2026 is to replace the 2002 law, which will give power to Government to constitute a Delimitation Commission to distribute the seats in the Lok Sabha and Legislative Assemblies on the basis of the 2011 census. The bill has been circulated among Members of Parliament along with 'The Constitution (One Hundred and Thirty-First Amendment) Bill, 2026' and 'The Union Territories Laws (Amendment Bill), 2026' in an exercise aimed at operationalising the women's reservation law by the 2029 elections.

Several of the provisions of the new delimitation bill are similar to the 2002 law, which would be repealed. According to the draft Delimitation Bill, 2026, "The Central Government may, from time to time, by notification, constitute a Commission to be called the Delimitation Commission.

"The Commission shall comprise of the following members, namely: one member, who shall be a person who is or has been a Judge of the Supreme Court, to be appointed by the Central Government, as the Chairperson of the Commission; the Chief Election Commissioner or an Election Commissioner nominated by the Chief Election Commissioner, ex



officio' and the State Election Commissioner of the State concerned, ex officio." The Central Government may, by notification, specify the term of the Commission, the bill says.

The Central Government may, on the request of the Commission, extend the term of the Commission by such further period as it may consider necessary, it says. "The Election Commission shall act as Delimitation Commission for the purpose of delimiting constituencies in the Legislative Assembly of the Union territory of Jammu and Kashmir falling under the occupation of Pakistan, when the area of the Union territory of Jammu and Kashmir under the occupation of Pakistan ceases to be so occupied," the bill says.

"It shall be the duty of the Commission to readjust, on the basis of the latest census figures, the allocation of seats in the House of the People to the States and Union territories, the total number of seats in the Legislative Assembly of each state and the division of each state and Union territories into territorial constituencies for the purpose of elections to the House of the People and to the Legislative Assembly," the draft law says.

The bill to "operationalise" 33 per cent reservation to women in Lok Sabha and State assemblies by increasing the strength of the lower house to up to 850 from the present 543. To redraw constituencies, the bill seeks to take into account the 2011 Census data. The bill seeks to amend Article 81 of the

Constitution. The 33 per cent seats reserved for women in Lok Sabha and legislative assemblies "shall be allotted by rotation to different constituencies in a State or Union territory," the bill circulated among Lok Sabha members said.

It states that "The House of the People (Lok Sabha) shall consist of not more than 815 members chosen by direct election from territorial constituencies in the States; and not more than 35 members to represent the Union territories, chosen in such manner as Parliament may by law provide."

The expression "population", according to the bill, means the population as ascertained at such Census of which the relevant figures have been published. As of now, figures of 2011 Census are available.

Women's reservation bill need of the hour: Shah



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Terming the Women Reservation Bill the need of the hour, Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Tuesday said everyone should support the historic move, a change "that should certainly take place for the better, without delay".

In a post on X, Shah said, "Women's Reservation Bill is the need of the hour. This is the rightful due of our Nari Shakti to contribute to policymaking and empower the nation. The Modi Government is resolved to bring and implement this legislation." "This is a change that should certainly take place for the better, without delay. I hope everyone will step forward and support this historic move," he said.

Parliament passed the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, commonly known as the Women's Reservation Act, in September 2023, marking a significant step towards enhancing women's representation in legislative bodies. The Act provides for the reservation of one-third of the seats in the Lok

Sabha and State assemblies for women.

The amendments to the Women's Reservation Act, when passed, will ensure an increase in the number of Lok Sabha seats to 816, of which 273 will be reserved for women.

The provision to provide 33 per cent reservation to women in the Lok Sabha and State assemblies was brought by amending the Constitution in 2023.

Under the current law, the reservation for women would not have become enforceable before 2034, as it was tied to the completion of the delimitation exercise post Census 2027.

To implement it from the 2029 Lok Sabha election, changes were needed in the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam. Hence, the Government is holding a special sitting of Parliament from April 16 to April 18 to pass the amendments to the law.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi said in an article on Tuesday that Parliament will reconvene in the next two days to discuss and hopefully, pass an important constitutional amendment relating to the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam.

Nation Focus



PM GREETES NATION ON BAISAKHI, PUTHANDU, PANA SANKRANTI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday greeted people on the occasion of Baisakhi, Puthandu and Maha Bishuba Pana Sankranti and wished that this special day furthers the spirit of togetherness in society and brings peace, happiness and prosperity to all. In separate messages in English, Gurmukhi, Tamil and Odia, Modi also hoped that the festivals would bring happiness, prosperity and fresh energy in everyone's lives. "Warm greetings on the joyous occasion of Baisakhi," he said. The prime minister said this vibrant festival marks the spirit of gratitude, renewal and hope. It celebrates the hard work of our farmers, whose dedication keeps our nation fed.



PM MODI, VICE PRESIDENT PAY TRIBUTE TO BR AMBEDKAR

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Tuesday led parliamentarians and people in paying floral tributes to BR Ambedkar in Parliament complex on his 135th birth anniversary. Every year, hundreds of people line up to pay tributes to one of the key architects of the Indian Constitution at his statue in the Parliament complex. Vice President Radhakrishnan, who is also the Rajya Sabha Chair, PM Modi, Speaker Birla, and Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge offered flowers at the portrait and statue of Ambedkar.

CBI raids 8 States after 22 new FIRs in builder-bank nexus case



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI on Tuesday conducted searches at 77 locations across eight States after registering 22 new cases in connection with builders-financial institutions nexus case, officials said.

The searches were spread across Delhi, Chennai, Puducherry, Bengaluru among other locations, they said. "The cases relate to an alleged nexus between certain builders and officials of financial institutions, leading to the cheating and defrauding of innocent homebuyers," a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) spokesperson said in a statement.

These coordinated search operations conducted across different States are part of a nationwide crackdown, the statement said, adding that the operation resulted in the seizure of incriminating documents, digital devices and

other materials, which are being examined.

The action is aimed at gathering crucial evidence to unravel the larger conspiracy involving alleged diversion of funds, financial irregularities and fraudulent practices in the housing real estate sector, the statement said.

The case was handed over to the CBI by the Supreme Court, which on April 29, 2025, had directed the agency to register seven preliminary enquiries against builders in NCR, including Supertech Limited. Later in the year, the court directed it to register 22 cases in which homebuyers were duped in the NCR by using the subvention scheme.

In September 23, last year, the top court had allowed the CBI to register six more regular cases into the "unholy nexus" between banks and developers to dupe homebuyers in real estate projects in Mumbai, Bengaluru, Kolkata, Mohali and Prayagraj.

Punjab CM launches monthly assistance scheme for women

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Adampur

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Tuesday rolled out his Government's ambitious 'Mukh Mantri Mawan Dheeyan Satkar Yojna', under which women from the general category will receive a monthly financial assistance of ₹1,000 while women from Scheduled Castes will get ₹1,500.

Calling it a true tribute to Babasaheb Ambedkar's vision of social justice and

equality, the CM launched the registration process for women beneficiaries, while ensuring doorstep facilitation through a massive network of camps and support staff.

The rollout begins in nine constituencies and will expand across the remaining 108 from May 15, with financial assistance starting July.

With 26,000 registration centres and dedicated 'Mahila Satkar Sakhis' deployed in every village and ward, the scheme is



Bhagwant Mann

designed for scale, access and certainty, positioning it among the most expansive direct financial support initiatives for women in the country.

Accompanied by senior AAP leader and Punjab 'Prabhari' Manish Sisodia, Mann announced that the scheme has been rolled out as a pilot across nine locations, including Adampur, Malout, Sri Anandpur Sahib, Dhirba, Sunam, Moga, Kotkapura, Batala and Patiala Rural.

"Registration for women in remaining 108 constituencies will start from May 15 onwards. Monthly payments of ₹1,000 or ₹1,500 will start from July onwards," he added while addressing a

rally in Adampur in Jalandhar.

"There is no deadline for registration and the ladies need not worry as it doesn't matter when they register whether April 15 or May 15 or August 15," he said clarifying that delayed registration would not affect benefits.

"They will get their full payment payable from July onwards, so even if they register at the end of September, they will get full payment for three months meaning July, August and September," he noted.

Left, trade unions slam brutal repression of NCR workers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Communist Party of India (Marxist) and major central trade unions, including CITU and AITUC, on Tuesday lashed out at the BJP-led Governments in Haryana and Uttar Pradesh for unleashing "brutal repression" on industrial workers agitating across the National Capital Region (NCR).

In a sharp escalation of the industrial unrest that has gripped the region, the Polit Bureau of the CPI(M) condemned the police action in Noida, Greater Noida, and Gurugram. The party alleged that the State machinery is being used to



defend corporate interests by filing false cases against labour leaders and branding genuine protests as "external conspiracies." "Police are raiding vil-

lages, indiscriminately beating up workers, and arresting hundreds. The whereabouts of those detained are not being shared with their families,"

a CPI(M) statement said. The party demanded the immediate and unconditional withdrawal of all cases.

Echoing these sentiments, the Centre of Indian Trade Unions (CITU) has called for a nationwide protest on April 16. CITU General Secretary Elamaram Kareem stated that the upsurge, which saw nearly 50,000 workers take to the streets in Noida alone, is a "direct class confrontation."

CITU highlighted that while the cost of living remains identical to Delhi, workers in UP and Haryana are paid "starvation wages" of ₹10,000- ₹12,000. The unions are demanding a minimum wage of ₹26,000

per month, an eight-hour workday, and the abolition of the contract labour system. They also pointed to the "ruthless exploitation" under the new Labour Codes, which they claim legalise 13-hour workdays and weaken trade union rights.

The All India Trade Union Congress (AITUC) also condemned the "house arrest" of union leaders in Noida and the disproportionate use of force against women workers. AITUC General Secretary Amarjeet Kaur remarked that the desperation seen in industrial hubs like Manesar, Panipat, and Barauni is a result of the total denial of collective bargaining.

NCPEDP calls for political reservation for persons with disabilities



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Hailing Prime Minister Narendra Modi for a landmark reform to mainstream women's political participation, the National Centre for Promotion of Employment for Disabled People (NCPEDP) has called for a parallel national discourse on ensuring political representation for persons with disabilities.

As Parliament convenes from April 16-18 to deliberate on the Constitution (106th Amendment) Act, which proposes 33 per cent reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies, along with an expansion of seats, NCPEDP has termed this a historic opportunity to address the long-standing underrepresentation of persons with disabilities in legislative bodies.

UGC approves Birkbeck's plan to set up a global campus in Bengaluru

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a significant step towards advancing India's global education ambitions, Birkbeck, University of London, has received a Letter of Intent (LoI) from the University Grants Commission (UGC), Government of India, to establish its global campus in Bengaluru.

The development aligns closely with the vision of the Government of India to position India as a global hub for higher education by 2030, as outlined in the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020,

and reflects the growing momentum in India-UK academic collaboration championed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

The launch event was attended by distinguished leaders from Government, academia, and international organisations, including Vineet Joshi, Chairperson, UGC and Secretary, Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Education; Lindy Cameron, British High Commissioner to India; Sally Wheeler, Vice-Chancellor, Birkbeck, University of London; Alison Barrett, Country Director India, British Council; and KM



Prafulachandra Sharma, Joint Secretary, Ministry of Education, GoI, along with senior officials from the Government, UK Embassy, British Council, and academic leadership from Birkbeck University of London.

With the establishment of its Bengaluru campus, Birkbeck will offer Indian students access to globally recognised University of London degrees at nearly 60 per cent lower cost, while maintaining the same academic standards, research-led teaching, and industry-integrated curriculum as its UK counterpart. This initiative directly sup-

ports India's goal of increasing its Gross Enrolment Ratio in higher education to 50 per cent by 2030 and expanding access to high-quality international education domestically.

Highlighting the significance of this initiative, Joshi said the handing over of the Letter of Intent marks a gateway to global learning for Indian students.

Emphasising the policy framework, he added, "At the heart of the NEP 2020 is the internationalisation of education. "Through progressive UGC regulations, we are enabling high-quality global

institutions to establish a meaningful presence in India. The students will now be able to access world-class international education at significantly lower costs, nearly 60 per cent less compared to studying abroad. This is critical to ensuring equity and expanding opportunities," he added.

Professor Sally Wheeler, Vice-Chancellor, Birkbeck, University of London, said, "We are proud to be part of India's education journey. This campus represents our commitment to making high-quality, transformative education more accessible to students in India."



States Focus



MARATHI TO BE MANDATORY FOR TAXI DRIVERS IN MAHARASHTRA

Knowing Marathi will be mandatory for all licensed rickshaw and taxi drivers in Maharashtra from May 1, and a statewide campaign will be conducted through the offices of the Motor Transport Department, Cabinet minister Pratap Sarnaik said on Tuesday. In a statement issued by his office, Sarnaik warned that the licenses of drivers who do not possess basic knowledge of Marathi will be cancelled. "From May 1, coinciding with Maharashtra Day, it will be mandatory for all licensed rickshaw and taxi drivers to know Marathi. A state-wide inspection campaign will be conducted through 59 regional and sub-regional offices of the Motor Transport Department to verify if drivers can read and write the language," the minister stated.



J&K: LG SINHA URGES COLLECTIVE FIGHT AGAINST DRUG ABUSE

Jammu and Kashmir Lt Governor Manoj Sinha on Tuesday underscored the importance of selfless service, calling on people to work collectively for the welfare of society, the city, and the nation. Speaking at a ceremony to mark the upgradation of 'Apna Bhojanalaya' at Government Medical College in Jammu, he urged people to commit to the cause of feeding the needy and building a legacy worthy of pride. The Lt Governor also called upon all sections of society to unite in the fight against drug abuse. "Our aim should be selfless service to our neighbours, our city, and the nation that unites us. A strong J&K means strong families, strong communities...when we uplift every sector, we uplift the Union Territory as a whole," Sinha said. "There is no higher duty than serving those in need.

BJP to resolve Gorkha issue without dividing West Bengal: Amit Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gangarampur/Manikchak (WB)

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Tuesday said the BJP, if voted to power in West Bengal, will resolve the Gorkha issue in the Darjeeling hills in a constitutional manner without dividing the State.

Addressing a poll rally in Gangarampur in Dakshin Dinajpur district, Shah referred to the BJP's election manifesto to offer a host of north Bengal-centric development projects. "I want to tell my Gorkha brothers of Darjeeling that, once in power, the BJP will not only develop an eco-adventure hub in the hills, but also resolve the Gorkha issue in a constitutional manner without dividing the State," Shah said.

The century-old demand of the Nepali-speaking Indians in the Darjeeling hills for a separate State of Gorkhaland has



Union Home Minister Amit Shah addressing the gathering during a public meeting in support of BJP candidates ahead of the West Bengal Assembly elections at Gochiar in Dakshin Dinajpur on Tuesday

repeatedly taken violent turns. Despite the formation of the semi-autonomous Gorkhaland Territorial Administration (GTA) in 2011 to administer the upper reaches of Darjeeling and parts of the foothills, violent agitations took place till as late as 2017. The region witnessed multiple twists and turns over political partnership between the local Gorkha parties, like the Gorkha Janmukti

Morcha (GJM) and the Gorkha National Liberation Front (GNLF), and bigger players like the BJP and TMC, where the demand for a separate Gorkhaland has always acquired political centre stage.

In the upcoming polls, the TMC is in a strategic seat-sharing alliance with the Anit Thapa-led Bharatiya Gorkha Prajatantrik Morcha (BJPM), a

breakaway faction of Bimal Gurung's GJM, and has left the Darjeeling, Kalimpong and Kurseong seats to its partner.

The BJP, on the other hand, has yet again secured the support of Gurung, its former alliance partner in the hills, although the saffron party is directly contesting the polls from the region this time.

Laying his thrust on the issue of illegal immigration in West Bengal, the Union home minister said that the BJP will end political violence, syndicate and cut-money raj in the State and evict infiltrators with priority. "Press EVM buttons next to the lotus sign so hard that once they are pressed in regions of north Bengal, infiltrators across India can feel the electric shock," he said.

Shah has been paying regular visits to the State over the last few weeks and has held multiple rallies across the State in the run-up to the April 23 polls.

SIR rule used selectively in Bengal to help BJP: Mamata



West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee addressing a public meeting ahead of the Assembly election in Howrah on Tuesday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee on Tuesday alleged that "logical discrepancy" under the SIR exercise is not an officially recognised term under the Election Commission framework and was selectively applied in West Bengal, unlike Bihar, to benefit the BJP.

Addressing a public rally at Pingla in Paschim Medinipur district, Banerjee urged women to "stand firm" against security forces if attempts are made to prevent people from voting, while asserting that she was not asking anyone to indulge in violence.

The chief minister said, "There is no officially recognised term like 'logical discrepancy' under the framework of the Election Commission. It is being selectively applied in West Bengal, unlike in Bihar, to benefit the BJP."

Banerjee added that she has not seen a "dirty party" like the BJP. "The job of the central police is to maintain peace. We have no objection to that. But what if they prevent people from voting? I will request women to keep brooms in their hands and stand firm against those wearing boots and carrying arms. I am not asking you to assault anyone or incite a riot, but you must do everything to

safeguard your rights," Banerjee said.

"I even moved the Supreme Court to protect your rights, and only after that, the names of 32 lakh voters were enlisted," she added. Later, speaking at another rally in Tamluk in Purba Medinipur district, Banerjee questioned why such a large number of central forces were brought to West Bengal.

"They have brought in officers who are close to the BJP and replaced the ICS... If your sole aim was to keep peace here, you could have used the West Bengal Police. Why, instead of doing that, did you take away all their powers and bring in central forces from outside? People don't see central forces during any natural calamity or riot," she alleged.

The CM asked people to lodge complaints against any police officer if they were "tortured". "Lodge complaints whenever police torture you," she said. The TMC supremo, urging people to vote against the BJP, said, "The BJP has snatched everything from you... Voting against it would be your only way to take revenge."

The BJP is holding rallies at places that have direct railway connectivity with Uttar Pradesh and Bihar so that they can bring in people from those States to fill up the venues, she alleged.

BJP destroying Constitution, TMC failed on jobs: Rahul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raiganj/Malda (WB)

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Tuesday launched a two-pronged attack in poll-bound West Bengal, accusing the BJP and the RSS of destroying the Constitution with their "hate-filled thinking", while claiming the ruling TMC has failed in fulfilling its promise of providing jobs to the state's youth.

Addressing poll rallies in Raiganj and Malda, he claimed that 84 lakh youths in Bengal have applied for the unemployment allowance promised by the Mamata Banerjee Government.

"Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee promised jobs to



LoP in the Lok Sabha and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi addressing a public meeting in support of party candidates ahead of the West Bengal Assembly elections at Samserganj in Murshidabad on Tuesday

five lakh people. But 84 lakh youths have applied for unemployment allowance," he said.

Targeting the BJP and RSS, the leader of the opposition

in the Lok Sabha accused the two outfits of destroying the Constitution by their "hate-filled thinking" and being "involved in vote theft". Rahul Gandhi termed the

Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls "unconstitutional" and alleged that wherever the BJP and RSS get a chance, they make insinuations against the Constitution. He accused the BJP of pitting one community against the other in the name of religion and caste to win elections.

Gandhi claimed that once the Congress forms a Government, the names of those wrongly struck off the electoral rolls under SIR will be reinstated. Claiming the Trinamool Congress cannot take on the BJP across the country, he said the Congress is the only party which can stand up against and defeat the saffron camp.

BJP States harassing Bangla speakers: Abhishek Banerjee

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Senior Trinamool Congress leader Abhishek Banerjee on Tuesday alleged that Bangla-speaking people were being harassed and intimidated in BJP-ruled States by labelling them as Bangladeshis.

Addressing a gathering after a roadshow in north Bengal's Cooch Behar, he accused the Narendra Modi Government of denying Bengal its rightful dues as "an act of revenge" for electing the TMC to power repeatedly, spurning the BJP.

"They have persecuted and tormented Bangla-speaking people in BJP-ruled States. They have insulted our icons, belittled our culture, tried to dictate our food habits, questioned the legitimacy of our language, and above all, conspired to rob the people of their



democratic rights," the TMC national general secretary said. The Diamond Harbour MP, who is the de facto number two in the TMC, also said, "While Bangla-speaking people are attacked, intimidated and labelled Bangladeshis in States ruled by the BJP, they are also forbidding the sale and

consumption of fish and meat in many areas."

He exuded confidence that the people of Bengal would humble the "arrogant anti-Bengal zamindars" on May 4, the day of the results for the Assembly polls.

"This one strike will remind these arrogant despots that no matter how much power they wield in Delhi, people can push them off their throne. The ultimate power always rests with the people," Banerjee said.

He said, "The hollowness in the BJP's love for communities like Rajbanshi and Matuas stands exposed as lakhs of names of members from these communities have been arbitrarily deleted through the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral roll." He assured people that the TMC would ensure that no legitimate voter is left out of the electoral rolls.

Boiler tube explosion at power plant in Chhattisgarh kills 13; 21 injured



Smoke billows after an explosion at a power plant in Chhattisgarh's Sakti district

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Sakti (Chhattisgarh)

In a major industrial accident, at least 13 workers were killed and 21 others injured after a steam-carrying tube connected to a boiler exploded at a Vedanta Ltd power plant in Sakti district of Chhattisgarh on Tuesday afternoon, police said.

The powerful blast occurred at around 2:30 pm in a tube supplying high-pressure steam from the boiler to the turbine at the Vedanta Ltd power plant in Singhitarai village causing severe burns to workers, Sakti Superintendent of Police (SP) Prafull Thakur told PTI.

Soon after the accident, local administration personnel and police teams rushed to the spot and launched rescue operations, he said.

While four workers died on the spot, around 30 others were injured and rushed to different hospitals in neighbouring Raigarh and Bilaspur districts, the IPS officer stated.

"Nine more workers succumbed to injuries later. Twenty-one injured workers are being treated in different hospitals," an Industrial Safety Department official in Raigarh said.

The company put the death toll at 10. At least six of the injured are stated to be in critical condition, said power plant officials. Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai expressed grief over the incident and announced a compensation of ₹5 lakh to the kin of each deceased worker and ₹50,000 to those injured.

Sai ordered the Commissioner of Bilaspur division to conduct an inquiry into the tragedy and said the strictest possible action would be taken against anyone found guilty in the probe.

The district administration has ordered a separate magisterial probe into the industrial accident, while Vedanta has initiated its own inquiry.

The CM termed the incident "extremely tragic" and expressed condolences to the bereaved families.

Nadda unveils BJP manifesto in Tamil Nadu, slams DMK's rule

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

The people of Tamil Nadu are "fed up" with the DMK and want to get rid of "family rule", former BJP national president and Union Minister JP Nadda said on Tuesday.

He alleged that the State has been turned from a "cultural capital" into a "crime capital" under the MK Stalin-led DMK Government.

Unveiling the Bharatiya Janata Party's election manifesto for the April 23 Assembly Elections-Pudhiya Yugam Padaikkum Thamarai Vaakuruthi (Creating a New Era through Lotus Promise) 2026-he claimed that the DMK had "failed Tamil Nadu on all fronts."

The poll manifesto, prepared by a 13-member committee under former Governor Tamilisai Soundararajan, covers 12 subjects, including governance and law and order, social justice, women and child development, healthcare, and farmers' welfare.

The manifesto, released coinciding with Tamil New Year's Day, assures that Thaipoosam will be declared a State festival to honour Lord Muruga (Subrahmanya Swamy), and that the tradition of lighting the Karthigai Deepam at the Tirupparankundram hilltop will be resumed and protected. The manifesto also promises a "ganja-free" State, a dedicated helpline for swift action, special fast-track courts, and capital punishment under the NDPS Act for repeat offenders and cartels.

Key promises include providing monthly assistance of ₹2,000 to



Union Minister JP Nadda with Tamil Nadu BJP leaders during the launch of the party manifesto ahead of the State Assembly elections in Chennai on Tuesday

women heads of households, along with a one-time grant of ₹10,000 to every household if the party is voted to power. The party also promised to provide three LPG cylinders free of cost annually, one each during the Pongal harvest festival, Tamil New Year, and Diwali. Nadda said that the DMK was run "like a dynasty".

"It is a family-run party where Stalin is at the top, Udhayanidhi Stalin is the heir, Kanimozhi Karunanidhi is a key figure, and Sabareesan is the manager. This is how the party operates-it is family rule," he claimed.

"We have to understand this. The pulse of the people across the State reflects full resentment against the DMK, dynasty rule, crime, corruption,

and its allies. People will expose this unholy alliance in the election," Nadda said.

"We Indians take immense pride in Tamil Nadu being the cradle of one of the world's oldest civilisations. However, under the current DMK Government, this cultural capital is sadly being turned into a 'crime capital'," he alleged.

The DMK, Nadda said, has "betrayed" the faith of women, youth, and marginalised sections of society. He alleged that the party believes in the "3Cs"-corruption, collection, and commission.

"Their leader, Udhayanidhi Stalin, compared Sanatana Dharma to dengue and coronavirus, which clearly reflects their hatred. They also

approached the Supreme Court against the High Court's order to light the Deepam atop the Tirupparankundram hills," Nadda said. He claimed that Tamil Nadu has become a "drug capital."

"The people are fed up with the DMK. They want to get rid of family rule," he reiterated.

The manifesto said it would tackle crimes against women on a war footing through streamlined zero-FIR reporting, victim-witness protection, special fast-track courts for heinous cases, including sexual offences, installation of blind-spot-free CCTV cameras in buses, schools, and universities, and optimised utilisation of the Nirbhaya Fund.

Other assurances include providing a subsidy of ₹25,000 to eligible women to purchase e-scooters.

The party promised a ₹3,000 top-up to the central PM-Kisan scheme for farmers, taking the total annual assistance to ₹9,000 per farmer under the proposed 'Uzhave Thai' scheme. It proposed the creation of a drug eradication department with a specialised anti-narcotics task force, along with a narcotics intelligence wing to monitor sea smuggling. Other promises include loans of up to ₹50 lakh for women-led cooperatives, SHGs, and MSMEs.

It proposes mandating 20 per cent of Government procurement from women-led cooperatives.

A one-time grant of ₹50,000 will be provided to small and marginal farmers for activities such as animal husbandry, cattle rearing, shrimp farming, beekeeping, and poultry farming.

Your Trusted Management Advisory

www.transglobeadvisors.in

Order Order

SC Collegium recommends Liz Mathew, Preeta Aravindan as Kerala HC judges



Preeta Aravindan (Left) Liz Mathew (Right)

The Supreme Court Collegium has recommended the appointment of two lawyers as judges of Kerala High Court. The decision was taken at a meeting of the Collegium held on April 14. Liz Mathew is practising in Supreme Court and was Kerala's standing counsel. Preeta Aravindan is practising in Kerala High Court. The Collegium headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant also approved a proposal for appointment of three judicial officers as judges of the Karnataka High Court. The names of these judicial officers are Rajeshwari Narayana Hegde, Kedambadi Ganesh Shanthi, and Mahadevappa Brungesh.

In another decision, the Collegium gave its nod to the appointment of four additional judges as permanent judges of the Telangana High Court.

They justices Yara Renuka, Nandikonda Narsing Rao, E Tirumala Devi, and BR Madhusudhan Rao. The Collegium further approved a proposal for appointment of Justice Manjusha Ajay Deshpande, additional judge, as permanent judge of the Bombay High Court.

Sucheta Dalal moves Delhi court against ban on media reports linked to Sandesara



Journalist Sucheta Dalal has moved a Delhi court challenging the order banning any news content linking Manoj Kesari Chand Sandesara or his family members to the alleged Sterling Biotech bank fraud case. District Judge Vinod Kumar Meena of the Tis Hazari Courts heard the matter on April 13 and issued notice to Manoj Sandesara, Google and Meta. The case will be heard next on April 29.

Dalal's Moneylife magazine and digital news portal – has challenged the Civil Judge's order of April 4, imposing a ban on Google, Meta and unknown parties (including media houses) from publishing any content linking Sandesaras to Sterling Biotech case. The Civil Judge had passed an ex parte 41 page interim injunction and ordered Google and Meta and John Doe defendants (unknown persons) to "de-index, de-list, and de-reference the URLs and content of articles flagged by Sandesara. This included three articles and a YouTube video published by Moneylife.

It is Dalal's case that the Civil Judge's order was overly broad, failed to identify specific defamatory content, violates free speech, and was issued without giving her publication a chance to be heard. Moneywise has claimed it was not named directly in the original suit despite its content being targeted, and only became aware of the same after takedown notices were sent by YouTube. "The Impugned Order also fails to recognize that the Plaintiff is pursuing the defamation claim not only on behalf of him, but also on behalf of the "his family name concerning the case of Sterling Biotech Limited and bank fraud". This effectively means that the Plaintiff is seeking reliefs on behalf of himself, his family, and Sterling Biotech Limited, even though no other family member or authorised representative of Sterling Biotech Limited is part of the Suit," Moneywise has said. The appeal contends that the Civil Judge's order providing an ex parte injunction effectively chokes any form of reporting, publication or criticism by Monewise and other publications concerning the Sandesaras and Sterling Biotech bank fraud case.

Unfavourable order not ground to transfer case: Delhi HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Unfavourable order by a judge cannot be a ground to seek transfer of a case on account of any bias, the Delhi High Court has held.

Justice Saurabh Banerjee said that in case of an unfavourable order, it is open to the litigant to take recourse to the options available in law.

The order was passed by Justice Banerjee on a petition by a woman who sought

transfer of her matrimonial case from one mahila court to another.

In an order passed on April 7, Justice Banerjee observed that the principal and district judge concerned rejected the petitioner's plea to transfer her case to another judge by passing a well-reasoned order.

The court noted that the principal judge's order held that the mere discharge of her husband and mother-in-law in the criminal case against them over alleged



NIA court sentences three in terror attacks linked to Al-Qaeda

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Three men have been sentenced by a National Investigation Agency (NIA) court for involvement in an Al-Qaeda-linked terror conspiracy to carry out attacks in Uttar Pradesh, officials said on Tuesday.

The trio men have been identified as Museeruddin alias Raju and Minhaj Ahmad alias Minhaj of Lucknow, and Tawheed Ahmad Shah alias Sobu Shah, hailing from district Budgam of Jammu and Kashmir, they said.

The Lucknow special court on Monday pronounced varying jail terms, ranging from 5 years of rigorous imprisonment (RI) to life imprisonment, against the three accused, the officials said. The terror convicts have also been fined a sum of up to ₹20,000, they said.

Three other accused, namely Shakeel, Mohd Mustaqeem and Mohammad Moid (all residents of Lucknow), were convicted earlier in this case after they



had pleaded guilty under the Arms Act.

NIA had filed charges against all the six convicted accused in the case through two chargesheets in 2022.

The case was originally registered by the Uttar Pradesh police following the arrest of Mushirudeen and Minhaj, both members of the banned Al-Qaeda terrorist organisation, by its Anti Terrorist Squad (ATS) in July 2021.

The duo was found involved in radicalisation and recruitment of vulnerable youth for raising Ansaar Gajwatul Hind

(AGH) as a module of AQIS (Al-Qaeda in Indian Subcontinent) in Lucknow, a statement issued by the probe agency said.

The conspiracy was aimed at carrying out terrorist acts in various cities of UP, including the capital, ahead of the Independence Day celebrations in 2021, it said.

NIA, after taking over the case, found that Minhaj was radicalised by Tawheed and another accused, Adil Nabi Teli alias Musa.

Together, these three men had conspired to recruit

members for the banned AGH for committing terrorist acts, the statement said.

Investigations by the anti-terror agency further revealed that Museeruddin was also roped into the conspiracy by Minhaj, and had even taken 'Baiyat' (oath of allegiance) at the latter's behest, it said.

Subsequently, Museeruddin and Minhaj had procured arms, ammunition and explosive materials with the help of Shakeel, Mustaqeem and Moid as part of the terror conspiracy intended to wage war against the Government of India, the NIA said.

During the course of the investigation, Musa was found to be a declared terrorist affiliated with TRF, an extended outfit of the banned Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) terror organisation, it said.

Investigations revealed that Musa had received funds from Minhaj through Tawheed.

Musa was killed in an encounter with security forces in March 2022 and NIA had filed an abated chargesheet against him in August 2022, the statement said.

Tripura minister files defamation suit against Tipra Motha MLA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Agartala

Tripura Forest Minister Animesh Debbarma has filed a defamation suit against Tipra Motha Party MLA Ranjit Debbarma for allegedly making "false and derogatory" remarks against him, a senior lawyer said on Tuesday.

The petition was moved before the Chief Judicial Magistrate (CJM) court, West Tripura, the minister's counsel said. Both the minister and the legislator belong to the Tipra Motha Party.

In the petition, the forest minister claimed that Ranjit Debbarma, during the campaigns for the Tripura Tribal Areas Autonomous District Council (TTAADC) elections, had made "derogatory remarks" against him.

The party MLA alleged that Animesh Debbarma had purchased "two flats and a plot"



Tripura Forest Minister Animesh Debbarma

and "talks were going on to buy a flat in Delhi", the lawyer said.

"These claims are false," Animesh Debbarma's counsel Sankar Lodh said.

"The Tipra Motha Party's Ramchandraghat MLA (Ranjit Debbarma) also accused the minister of staying in forest bungalows to attend parties with a few women. This allegation is baseless," he said.

The defamation petition will be taken up for hearing in

the CJM court on April 30, Lodh said.

When contacted, Ranjit Debbarma claimed that he did not name any minister in his speeches during the election campaigns on March 29 and April 9, as mentioned in the petition.

"I have not mentioned any minister's name in my speeches. I will submit a statement clarifying my stand when the defamation notice is served to me," he said.

SC to hear plea of Assam Government against anticipatory bail to Cong leader Pawan Khera today

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court is scheduled to consider on Wednesday a plea of the Assam Government against the Telangana High Court order granting one-week transit anticipatory bail to Congress leader Pawan Khera in a case registered against him for levelling allegations against Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma's wife.

On April 10, the High Court granted one-week transit anticipatory bail to Khera with certain conditions and gave him a week to file an application before the court concerned.

The State Government's plea was filed on Sunday through advocate Shuvodeep Roy.

A bench of Justices JK Maheshwari and AS Chandurkar will hear the matter on April 15.

The Congress leader had, on April 5, in a press conference alleged that the Assam CM's wife, Riniki Bhuyan Sarma, has multiple passports and foreign property, which were not declared in the chief minister's election affidavit for the April 9 Assembly polls in that state. The Sarmas had rejected the allegations as false and fabricated.

The case against Khera was registered at the Guwahati Crime Branch Police Station under several sections of



the BNS sections, including 175 (false statement in connection with an election), 35 (Right of private defence of the body and of property) and 318 (cheating).

"Without expressing any opinion on the merits of the case, this court is of the view that the petitioner has made out a case for the grant of limited transit anticipatory bail, as his apprehension of arrest appears to be reasonable and supported by material on record," the High Court had said in its order.

The conditions were that the petitioner shall be released on bail in the event of arrest on his executing a personal bond for ₹one lakh with two sureties for the like

sum each, cooperate with the investigation and make himself available for interrogation as and when required by the Investigating Officer and that he shall not leave the country without prior permission of the competent Court.

The conditions further include that the petitioner shall, within the stipulated period, approach the competent jurisdictional court in Assam and seek appropriate relief and he, being a public figure, shall exercise restraint in making any further public statements in relation to the subject matter of the present case, which may prejudice the investigation, the order said.

cruelty under the Indian Penal Code could not form any basis to assume bias and the onus to substantiate the allegations was on the petitioner.

"Even otherwise, since the said order(s) were passed by a Court of law in discharge of the duties, merely because it was not a favourable order in favour of the petitioner does/ cannot involve an element of bias, all the more whence it is always open for the petitioner to take recourse to the

appropriate remedies as available to her in accordance with law," the court said.

Before the High Court, the petitioner assailed the order of the principal and district judge refusing to transfer her case to another judge.

The court dismissed the petition and said the petitioner was again trying to re-agitate the very same issues which had been negated by a well-reasoned speaking impugned order by the Principal Judge.

Nashik court remands 'godman' Kharat to 5-day police custody

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Nashik

A court in Nashik on Tuesday remanded self-styled godman Ashok Kharat to police custody till April 18 in the fourth case of rape against him for allegedly sexually exploiting a woman who had approached him seeking solutions to her family problems.

The special investigation team (SIT) probing the cases against the former merchant navy officer had on Monday filed a request application demanding his custody in the fourth case. As the court granted them the necessary permission, the SIT took Kharat's custody and produced him in the court of Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate AG Behere on Tuesday.

During the proceedings held via video-conferencing, public prosecutor Shailendra Bagde pleaded that a further inquiry was



necessary in the case. He alleged that the accused had administered sedatives to the victim, who had approached him seeking solutions for some family problems, and sexually exploited her.

Kharat's lawyer, Satish Bhate, however, argued that the accused had been in police custody for a long time, and since the SIT has investigated the case, further police remand was not needed.

However, considering the sensitive nature of the case, the court granted five-day police custody to Kharat till April 18.

SC to hear plea on guidelines for welfare insurance schemes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has sought responses from the Centre and the Life Insurance Corporation of India on a plea seeking a direction to the LIC to frame and implement disability-sensitive guidelines for welfare insurance schemes.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta agreed to hear the plea which sought a direction to the Centre to exercise policy oversight to ensure that welfare insurance schemes for persons with disabilities are implemented in conformity with the guarantees under Articles 14 and 21 of the Constitution.

While Article 14 deals with equality before law, Article 21 pertains to protec-



tion of life and personal liberty.

"Issue notice, returnable within four weeks," the bench said in its April 13 order.

The petition has sought a direction to the LIC to frame and implement disability-sensitive guidelines for welfare insurance schemes, including 'Jeevan Aadhar' policy. The LIC's 'Jeevan Aadhar' policy may be offered to an individual

who has a handicapped dependant satisfying conditions as specified in Section 80DDA of the Income Tax Act, 1961. It provides life insurance cover throughout lifetime of the purchaser.

Section 80DDA of the Income Tax Act pertains to deduction in respect of deposit made for maintenance of handicapped dependant.

The plea has sought a direction that claims under such welfare insurance schemes involving beneficiaries with intellectual, mental and congenital disabilities resulting in inability to independently understand, communicate or assert contractual and legal rights, be decided on a case-by-case basis through reasoned, humane and non-mechanical decision-making processes.

Delhi court convicts man for rape on pretext of marriage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has convicted a man for repeatedly raping a woman after luring her into a relationship with the false assurance of marriage, saying that the assurance was "false" and driven by "clandestine motives to satisfy his lust".

Additional Sessions Judge Kapil Kumar was hearing a case against Mohit Rajpal, who was accused of having physical relations with a

377 (unnatural offences), 313 (carrying miscarriage without consent) and 506 (criminal intimidation).

The court noted that the promise was dishonest from the outset and was used as a tool to obtain her consent.

"The false promise to marriage extended by the accused was the sole reason for the prosecutrix to consent to repeated physical relations with the accused," the judge said.

The survivor had alleged



woman on the pretext of marriage and said that such consent cannot be considered legally valid.

In an order dated April 9, the court said, "It is proved that the promise of marriage extended by the accused to prosecutrix was a false promise to marriage and made with clandestine motives to satisfy his lust without having any intention to honour the same since inception".

According to the prosecution, the accused established physical relations with the woman from 2016 to 2018 by falsely assuring her of marriage. A case was registered against the accused under IPC Sections 376(2) (aggravated rape),

that the accused also subjected her to forced sexual acts, coerced her into terminating a pregnancy, and threatened her with dire consequences if she took legal action.

"The consent of prosecutrix for physical relations proved not to be free consent, being vitiated for the misconception of fact in her mind consequent to false promise to marriage extended to her by accused," the court said.

The court reiterated the settled legal position that a conviction in sexual offence cases can be based solely on the testimony of the prosecutrix if it is found to be credible and trustworthy.



Editor's
TAKE

Jaaiye aap
kahaan jaayenge...

With Asha Bhosle's passing, an era of Indian music draws to a close. She leavs behind a voice that will echo through generations

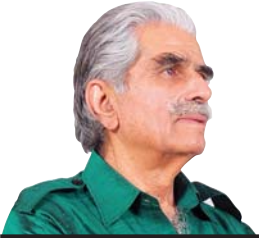
Asha Bhosle, the playback singer with a gifted voice, is no more. Yet her voice would always be there to evoke nostalgia of yesteryears when the music was largely instrument-driven and auto-tune wasn't heard of. Though her singing career spans eight decades but she adjusted and adapted to changing times beautifully and sang for several generations. She had a voice that teases, consoles, and soars – sometimes all within a single song. With her demise at 92, Indian music does not merely lose a singing legend; it loses the grainy innocence of early cinema.

She began her career in 1943, as a teenager under the shadow of her sister Lata Mangeshkar, but soon carved a place for herself with patience and sheer hard work and hours of practice. It was the time when compensation for playback singers was a pittance. In those early years of Indian cinema, royalties were a distant dream. To sing was to survive. And yet, Bhosle endured as a restless artist who refused to be boxed in. Bollywood has a bad habit of typecasting - be it an actor or a singer - they don't take chances, and very rarely do they allow themselves to break free of the mould that they define a singer or an actor with. The industry tried to cast her as the voice of mischief and dance numbers. Songs like *Piya Tu Ab To Aaja* became Asha's signature. But she resisted confinement with quiet defiance. She showed the range she had. She sang ghazals like *Dil Cheez Kya Hai*, classical songs, pop, folk, and more. She did not just adapt to change – she became a vehicle for change. Her collaborations with composers across decades ensured she remained relevant.

Her journey is the journey of Indian music itself. Bollywood has changed, from a time when playback singers barely survived to the present times when they are handsomely rewarded through royalties, global tours, streaming revenues and TV shows. Asha lived it all. Her legacy is not just artistic but financial. Reports estimate a net worth of ₹200-250 crore, with properties worth nearly ₹100 crore and an international restaurant chain, Asha's, spanning cities from Dubai to the United Kingdom, all created by a young girl, unpaid for her voice to a global brand built on it. But to reduce her life to commercial success would be doing an injustice to her. For Asha, music was breath. Even at 90, she stood on stage for hours, performing with a vitality that defied age and expectation. She sang across generations. When she performed contemporary tracks late in life, it was not reinvention; it was affirmation that she had always belonged to every era. Her life journey is a lesson for the upcoming artistes. Today's playback singers inherit an industry far more equitable, visible, and lucrative. Yet it is built on the uncredited labour, the resilience, and the quiet battles of artistes like Bhosle, who sang through personal hardship, professional typecasting, and systemic neglect. What she leaves behind is not just a catalogue of thousands of songs but a blueprint of artistic courage-the refusal to be defined by others, the instinct to evolve, and prove herself. Asha Bhosle ensured that even in silence, her voice will echo through every era that follows.

The book that wasn't: Silence, strategy, & security

The controversy surrounding former Army Chief M M Naravane's Four Stars of Destiny has reopened troubling questions about transparency, civil-military trust, and the limits of democratic debate



ASHOK K
MEHTA

It is necessary to revive the vital issue of national security suppressed, presumably at the behest of the government, by former COAS Gen MM Naravane's declaration on February 10, that his controversial book Four Stars of Destiny has not been published. For a full one week, the unpublished book paralysed Parliament and gave it publicity of high order. The book contains an oral operational directive presumably from PM Narendra Modi to Naravane at the height of the India-China crisis on Kailash Ridge on August 31, 2020 – “jo uchit samjho woh karo” (JUSWK). The situation obtaining at the time is well known and does not require recall. In his book Naravane wrote: “I was handed a hot potato” adding something few have recounted earlier, that he was told by the highest authority: “I should not be the first to open fire”. This was in accordance with prevailing protocols promulgated in 1993-96 on “no use of firearms”. JUSWK was clearly a case of passing the buck.

On December 15, 2023, Naravane issued a tweet, “Hello friends, my book is available....follow this link”. The book was to hit the stands in January 2024. On 10 February 2026, he said (or was forced to say): “My book has not been published”, which terminated several adjournment motions in the Lok Sabha. The publisher, Penguin Random House, repeated the claim on the same day. Both author and publisher were muzzled. Earlier in October 2025, at a literary festival in Kasauli, Naravane said: “The book is under review. The publisher has to get clearance; now it is between the publisher and the government”. In December 2023, the publisher provided extracts from the book to PTI. Two chapters, one on the events of 31 August 2020 - Operation Snow Leopard - and the other on Agnipath scheme, showed up the government in a poor light, reflecting the absence of civil-military coordination at the highest level.

Naravane has praised the government in his book, though he has much to answer for: allowing the Chinese PLA to commit aggression across a 2000km frontage in East Ladakh and occupying 1500 km of Indian Territory, this after claiming that all was normal on the LAC. But that is a separate topic as the government has papered over Chinese aggression and settled for disengagement without de-escalation and de-militarisation. Worse, it has lost 26 of 65 patrolling points, accepted buffer zones (not established earlier at Barahoti or Sumdorongchu), lost grazing grounds, but still normalised relations on 1 April 2025 by cutting



a cake on the 75th anniversary of India-China relations. The bottom line of the Army Chiefs since the aggression has been 'status quo ante April 2020'.

Ashley Tellis of Carnegie Endowment had said: “India has still not received from China any explanation for what it did in East Ladakh; that normalisation had begun before de-escalation”. NSA Shiv Shankar Menon had noted: “we know what happened in Fingers Area, but nothing about Kailash Heights”. Extracts from Naravane's unpublished book throw some light without explaining the cover-up for the faux pas in agreeing to withdraw from Kailash Heights, which was India's Trump card. The other revelation in the extracts is the 'bombshell' of Agniveer which Naravane disparages in detail. Former IAF and Navy Chiefs have made extremely negative comments about the scheme. It has damaged long-term India-Nepal relations as Nepal has not accepted the revised terms of engagement, and recruitment remains suspended since 2020 following COVID. A strategic bond will soon be lost.

It is these two issues – Chinese aggression of 2020 and Agniveer – which were intended to be blocked from discussion in Parliament. The government succeeded in preventing any debate about the Galwan episode also saying any debate on national security will undermine the morale of soldiers.

This method has been patented to block any discussion on inconvenient topics involving national security. Instead, the government follows a simple procedure of making statements in Parliament on heroic and swift counter-deployment of 50,000 soldiers in response to Chinese aggression. In no other democracy is debate on national security disallowed in Parliament. But enough is out there in the public domain about China's inscrutable behaviour in 2020 and India's reactionary response.

When asked by ANI, Jaishankar said: “How can I fight China? It has a big (five times)

economy”. Unfortunately the Iron Curtain has concealed the excellent redeeming manoeuvre during Operations Snow Leopard and Chengiz on the North and South Banks of Pangong Tso Lake, Rajnath Singh, on 10 February 2021 merely informing Parliament that withdrawal from these areas had been done without mentioning the strategic loss of Kailash Heights. But he did add the usual: “not an inch of territory was lost”. The Naravane story has been carried faithfully by Caravan magazine and Wire portal

Not only was an Army Chief silenced about his unpublished book, but also the publishers. Both dutifully complied in saying that the book

Four Stars of Destiny had not been published. Former Army Chief, Gen NC Vij's book Alone In the Ring-Decision Making in Critical Times was delayed by several months from release,

but was freed later after vetting. The government has systematically persuaded mainline TV and print media not to publish matters that will show government infirmities, but also not to publish the views of the opposition parties. This is evident from watching TV and reading newspapers. Inconvenient journalists have been quietly eased out. As a thoroughly apolitical veteran, I would like to see free debate and discussion flourish in the largest and most populous democracy. The military is not above criticism. The government's new rules on retired public servants writing will inhibit them from recounting their instructive experiences during government service.

On April 3, The Public India Digital Media held a function to recognise journalists who are discovering and inventing ways and means to bypass government fiat on control of news and limit adversarial content. Naravane knew that his book would not fly; so he wrote the novel The Cantonment Conspiracy in 2024 when he triumphantly announced, not without sarcasm, “Now I am a published author” The message is out even if the author has been rendered hors de combat.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

THE
GOVERNMENT
SUCCEEDED IN
PREVENTING
ANY DEBATE
ABOUT THE
GALWAN
EPISODE ALSO
SAYING ANY
DEBATE ON
NATIONAL
SECURITY WILL
UNDERMINE
MORALE OF
SOLDIERS

The writer, a retired Major General, served as Commander, IPKF (South), Sri Lanka, and was a founder member of the Defence Planning Staff, now the Integrated Defence Staff

dailypioneer
 @TheDailyPioneer
 The Pioneer

When history returns in the same tone



SANJAY
CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

Our holiday in Poland was filled with laughter and companionship. Yet, interspersed were moments that were far more sombre.

We walked through the Jewish quarters and the remnants of the ghettos in Warsaw. These were not just places on an itinerary; they were spaces that demanded silence, reflection. At the start of a walking tour in Warsaw, our guide made a statement. The events, she said, could not possibly be condensed into two and a half hours. It was easy to reduce history to simple binaries-to label all Germans as perpetrators, or to question why Polish citizens did not stand up for their Jewish neighbours.

Then she asked us to pause and imagine a world where offering shelter to a persecuted individual could invite death-not only for oneself, but for one's entire family.

Imagine the weight of that choice, and in that moment history moved away from abstraction and became something far more human, and far more complex.

At the end of the walk, she left us with another thought that was even more unsettling. If one were to read the speeches of Hitler and his followers, and then listen to certain global leaders and their supporters today, one might find an uncomfortable familiarity in that language. It is not identical, but it echoes, and that echo is both uncanny and deeply disturbing.

The visit to Auschwitz-Birkenau from Krakow was heavier still, and there are no words that can fully capture what one feels walking through those grounds. The scale of suffering defies comprehension-men, women, children, no distinction, no mercy. The structures remain, but what lingers is not just history; it is the evidence of what human beings are capable of doing to one another.

Our young guide spoke with a voice that often faltered under the weight of what she was recounting. At one point, she said something that cut through all detail and stayed as a simple, stark truth: that much of what happened there was rooted in hatred-of one race against another.

And then came the question, unspoken but unavoidable: if we cannot find it within ourselves to let go of our prejudices, then who are we? It is perhaps this question

that travels with us long after such visits end, especially when one reflects that these events unfolded less than a century ago. Not in some distant, unrecognisable past, but within a timeline that still touches our present. One would have hoped that such history would have firmly anchored us in a commitment to a more humane future, that it would have sharpened our ability to recognise the early signs of division and hatred.

And yet, as one listens more closely to the world around us, there are moments when the language begins to sound familiar again. History does not always repeat itself in the same form, but it often returns in the same tone. And perhaps what matters most is not that we remember what happened, but that we recognise when it begins to happen again. Remembrance is not enough. It must

be accompanied by vigilance-an awareness of the words we use, the silences we accept, and the prejudices we allow to persist within us.

History may belong to the past, but its warnings are always addressed to the present. And if there is to be hope for the

future, it will lie not in what we have seen, but in what we choose to refuse, resist, and rise above.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The writer is founder of Kala - Krazy About Literature And Arts, is an author, speaker, coach, arbitrator, and strategy consultant

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A new sacrilege law in Punjab

Punjab's proposed sacrilege law seeks to penalise acts that disrespect revered scriptures such as the Guru Granth Sahib, Quran, Bible, and Bhagavad Gita. It covers damage, defecation, or insults expressed through words, gestures, actions, or digital platforms, and extends punishment to attempts or abetment.

With stringent penalties, including life imprisonment, concerns arise over vague definitions that could lead to misuse or unintentionally restrict free expression.

The law aims to treat all major religions equally, ensuring balance and non-discrimination. However, it is not yet in force and will become operative only after gubernatorial assent and official notification.

A balanced approach appears prudent. While past incidents have caused genuine public distress, particularly regarding the Guru Granth Sahib, a hastily framed law may create more challenges. Moreover, this will help maintain the law and order and curb chances of any misunderstanding amongst communities.

Refining definitions, narrowing scope, and adding safeguards against misuse would help uphold both communal harmony and constitutional freedoms.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

Violent worker's protest in NOIDA

There is criticism against the Centre a day after violent workers' protests in Noida, and unrest as the “final cry” of labourers struggling under rising costs and stagnant wages.

The scenes on the streets reflected deep economic distress. What unfolded on the streets of Noida was the final cry of this nation's workers a voice that went unheard at every turn, a voice weary from ceaseless pleading.The financial strain faced by daily-wage earners, who earn around ₹12,000 a month while paying ₹4,000 – ₹7,000 in rent. Before their wages can catch up, unbridled inflation strangles life, plunging them into debt this is the stark reality.

The rising living costs and have forced them to struggle for survival.The burden of America's tariff wars, global inflation, and fractured supply chains has fallen upon daily-wage labourer. The protests by factory workers demanding higher wages and better conditions turned violent across several industrial hubs in Noida.

Vehicles were torched, public property vandalized and stone-pelting reported, disrupting traffic and leaving thousands stranded on key routes linking Delhi.With this all is not well in Noida.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Vehicle laws must be strictly implemented

Despite unambiguous rules and regulations it is highly deplorable that many vehicles, including cars, continue to use tinted glasses beyond the permissible limits and the law enforcers are looking the other way. Tinted sunglasses, to cut off the light entering the interiors of cars, was a fashion until a Supreme Court judgment of 2012 banned the use of “black films” in windshields and window glasses. Rule 100 of the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989 clearly states that factory fitted glasses should allow 70 percent visibility or visual light transmission (VLT) for front and rear windshields and 50 percent for the side windows. However, all aftermarket black films are banned in compliance with the court order. These tinted glasses, popularly referred to as “sunglasses of the windows”, fell into disrepute after a few unscrupulous elements used them for nefarious activities.

Besides, law enforcers could not clearly decipher whether or not drivers followed rules like wearing seat belts due to reduced visibility. Since laws are regularly flouted, a spurt in crimes, especially against women in moving cars, are blamed on tinted glasses. When the intention is evil, can the action be virtuous? Also, the present fine for offenders is too meagre. Repeat offenders' licences should be confiscated.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

PIC TALK



A man with a child takes a dip in the holy sarovar at Golden Temple on the occasion of Baisakhi, in Amritsar

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

www.dailypioneer.com

facebook.com/dailypioneer @TheDailyPioneer
 instagram.com/dailypioneer linkedin.com/in/The Pioneer

TCS BOWS TO PRESSURE, ACKNOWLEDGES
SEXUAL HARASSMENT CASE ON ITS PREMISES

Thanks to the media pressure, the largest IT company in India, TCS has been forced to acknowledge the sexual and religious harassment case at their Nashik BPO office. It has sent deep shockwaves across the corporate corridors of India. Allegations like outraging modesty, establishing physical relationship, lewd advances, stalking and coercion for religious conversion are not the allegations we associate with a firm like TCS, a known Tata brand. TCS claimed that it took swift action after the complaints but the fact is that it has allegedly been going on for the last four years tells a different story. Such incidents highlight serious gaps in implementation of existing safeguards meant to protect employees, especially women. Although India has a robust legal framework in the form of the

Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act, 2013, its effectiveness depends largely on sincere enforcement by organizations, companies must ensure that Internal Complaints Committees function independently, transparently, and without bias. In this case what was the HR head doing, what SOPs were in place for HR management, why wasn't there any escalation system for POSH. The investigation must be thorough, transparent and unbiased. To prevent such cases, corporates should conduct regular awareness programs, encourage employees to report misconduct without fear, and establish strict accountability for those who violate ethical standards. Anonymous reporting mechanisms can strengthen trust in the system.

BAL GOVIND | NOIDA

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.



BR Ambedkar: His life, legacy and beyond

BR Ambedkar gave India its Constitution and a vision of equality and justice. He rose from deep social discrimination to become one of the greatest thinkers of modern India. His life reminds us that democracy must be built on dignity and equal rights

FIRST
Column



K P
TENNETI

India is a nation built on the shoulders of extraordinary individuals, men and women who dared to dream of equality, justice and dignity for all. Among those towering figures, one stands apart - not merely as a statesman, jurist or economist, but at the intersection of law, public morality and social justice. His name: BR Ambedkar. As we commemorate him today, I would like to take a moment not only to delve into the life of an individual who transcended the brutal circumstances of birth to become one of the finest legal and intellectual minds of the twentieth century, the principal architect of the Constitution of the Republic of India, but also to shed light on the post-independence political marginalisation and, ultimately, the slow but deliberate reduction of his legacy.

Our story begins 135 years ago on this day, 14 April. The year was 1891, and in a small town called Mhow (now BR Ambedkar Nagar in modern-day Madhya Pradesh), a baby was born to the family of Ramji Maloji Sakpal and Bhimabai, their 14th child. The family belonged to the Mahar caste, classified as 'untouchable', thereby subjected to one of the most systematic and dehumanising forms of social discrimination the world has ever known.

From a very young age, Ambedkar faced harsh social exclusion. In school, he was made to sit separately. He was not allowed to touch water vessels. If he needed water, someone from a higher caste had to pour it for him, if they agreed at all. Many times, he simply went without water. These experiences were not isolated incidents. They reflected a deeply unjust social system that denied basic dignity to entire communities.

Despite these hardships, BR Ambedkar showed exceptional intelligence and determination. A teacher gave him the surname "Ambedkar", replacing his original surname. While this small gesture became part of a much larger journey, it lit a fire of determination and zeal in a child who was denied basic rights, pushing him to become one of the most educated and influential minds of his time.

In 1907, a young Ambedkar passed his Matriculation examination from Bombay University with outstanding results. He subsequently joined Elphinstone College in Mumbai in 1908, a prestigious institution that



FOR AMBEDKAR,
FREEDOM
WITHOUT
EQUALITY AND
EQUALITY
WITHOUT
FREEDOM COULD
LEAD TO ABSOLUTE
DICTATORSHIP.
WE SEE HIS
EFFORTS TO
TACKLE THIS IN
ONE OF HIS MOST
MONUMENTAL
CONTRIBUTIONS
TO A NEWLY
INDEPENDENT
INDIA, THE HEART
AND SOUL OF OUR
DEMOCRACY, THE
INDIAN
CONSTITUTION

The writer is a Member of
Parliament (Lok Sabha),
Panel Speaker, and
retired DGP

dailypioneer
@TennetiKrshnaMP
The Pioneer

very few Dalits of that era could even aspire to enter. In 1912, he graduated in Political Science and Economics from Bombay University.

In 1913, following his father's death, Ambedkar departed for the United States to study at Columbia University in New York, where he was awarded a PhD for his thesis 'The Evolution of Provincial Finance in British India'. His very first published article, 'Castes in India: Their Mechanism, Genesis and Development', announced to the world the arrival of a scholar of the first rank.

He returned to India briefly and then travelled to England, where he studied at the London School of Economics and qualified at Gray's Inn to be called to the Bar. During his time in London from 1920 to 1923, he completed another landmark thesis titled 'The Problem of the Rupee', for which the University of London awarded him the degree of DSc. The multitude of recognition from prestigious institutions worldwide confirmed his standing as one of the most academically accomplished men of the twentieth century. However, for all practical purposes in his own country, he was still seen as an untouchable, with discrimination and prejudice making it very difficult for Ambedkar to find acceptance among the elite of India at that time. Yet, he remained firm in his resolve to use education as a tool for social change.

After returning to India, Ambedkar dedicated himself to the upliftment of the oppressed. In 1920, he started the newspaper Mooknayak (Leader of the Silent) to raise awareness among Dalits. His activism was practical and structured. He believed in creating institutions and movements to bring change. In 1923, he founded the Bahishkrit

Hitkarini Sabha to promote education and improve the economic condition of the down-trodden. In 1927, he led the Mahad Satyagraha at the Chowdar Tank, asserting the right of Dalits to access public water. This was a major moment in the fight against caste discrimination.

In 1930, he launched the Temple Entry Movement at the Kalam Temple in Nashik, demanding equal religious rights.

A major turning point came in 1932 with the debate on separate electorates for the Depressed Classes. The British Communal Award granted this provision, which Ambedkar supported. However, Mahatma Gandhi opposed it and began a fast unto death. Under immense pressure, Ambedkar signed the Poona Pact, replacing separate electorates with reserved seats.

This was the start of many differences between Ambedkar and Mahatma Gandhi, with the fundamental difference being that while Mahatma Gandhi referred to untouchables as 'Harijans' and sought reform from within Hinduism, Ambedkar, who had experienced untouchability in the flesh, believed that the caste system was fundamentally incompatible with human equality and dignity and needed to be abolished entirely.

His 1936 work, Annihilation of Caste, strongly criticised the caste system. However, the Congress party at that time was not aligned with this and felt that Ambedkar was going against the work of Mahatma Gandhi. This difference is seen aptly in the 1945 writing of Ambedkar titled What Congress and Gandhi Have Done

to the Untouchables, a damning account of how the Congress party had repeatedly failed the Depressed Classes, prioritising the interests of the upper-caste Hindu majority over the rights of those at the bottom of the social order.

Ambedkar's contribution to India's freedom struggle is sometimes misunderstood. It is rather unfortunate that this misunderstanding has been encouraged, deliberately or otherwise, by those who preferred to see him as a sectional leader rather than a national one. The truth is more complex, and considerably more honourable.

Ambedkar's vision of freedom was categorically different from that which dominated the Congress-led national movement. For him, freedom without equality was hollow. He wrote and argued repeatedly that the independence of India from British rule, while necessary, would mean little to millions of Dalits if the new rulers simply replicated the social hierarchies and injustices of the old order. For Ambedkar, freedom without equality and equality without freedom could lead to absolute dictatorship.

We see his efforts to tackle this in one of his most monumental contributions to a newly independent India, the heart and soul of our democracy, the Indian Constitution.

Within weeks of our country gaining independence, on 29 August 1947, the Constituent Assembly established a Drafting Committee to prepare a Constitution for the new republic and elected Ambedkar as its Chairman. The task was of an almost impossible magnitude. The Constituent Assembly 'moved, discussed and disposed of as many as 2,473 amendments' during its deliberations. Rajendra Prasad, Chairman of the Constituent Assembly, acknowledged the zeal and devotion of the members of the Drafting Committee and especially its

Chairman, Ambedkar, in delivering our nation a Constitution despite deteriorating health and in conditions of extraordinary difficulty. Ambedkar ensured that our Constitution included robust protections for Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and Backward Classes. He insisted on the separation of powers, an independent judiciary, and the fundamental rights of every citizen regardless of caste, creed, sex or religion. He advocated democracy in every field: social, economic and political. For him, social justice meant maximum happiness for a maximum number of people.

The tragedy of Ambedkar's post-independence years is inseparable from the tragedy of the Congress government's failure to

honour one of its own greatest servants. Having used his towering intellect and prodigious labour to draft the Constitution, Ambedkar was subsequently marginalised, humiliated and politically destroyed by the very party whose government he had served. When differences emerged between him and the ruling government of Jawaharlal Nehru, he chose to resign from the government rather than remain part of what he did not believe was making the necessary efforts to uplift the Dalits, oppressed and marginalised classes.

This apparent slight was not forgiven by the Congress, which made sure to undertake measures in the 1952 elections to effectively torpedo Ambedkar's political career. As the first independent elections in India approached, Ambedkar contested from the Bombay North Central constituency as the candidate of his Scheduled Castes Federation. Not only did the Congress field a former assistant of Ambedkar against him, they decided to work with the other major party in the region to effectively deny one of our greatest minds the opportunity to stand in the Lok Sabha and raise the issues of those he fought his entire lifetime for.

The toll of elections, politics and long health issues eventually took its toll, and Ambedkar died in 1956. Rather than celebrate his legacy, his name remained in practical political isolation. It took until 1990, close to thirty-four years after his death, and forty-three years after independence for the Indian State to formally confer the Bharat Ratna upon BR Ambedkar. It was the cabinet of the seventh Prime Minister, V. P. Singh, that took that step. The Congress governments that preceded him had not seen fit to extend this honour to the man who had given India its Constitution, rather choosing to confer it upon themselves.

BR Ambedkar gave India its Constitution and a vision of equality and justice. He rose from deep social discrimination to become one of the greatest thinkers of modern India. His life reminds us that democracy must be built on dignity and equal rights.

He was not only a leader of the oppressed but a nation-builder of the highest order. His ideas remain central to India's progress. His iconic call to "Educate, Agitate, Organise" continues to guide generations not just in India but across the world at large.

To honour Ambedkar is to uphold constitutional values and fight injustice. His legacy is not just history; it is a collective responsibility that must continue to be passed down to generations so that they are made aware of the man who gave his today for our tomorrow and forever.

Pakistan's paradox: Peace abroad, repression at home



NILANTHA
ILANGAMUWA

Who decides which lives are expendable in the name of national interest? Whose blood allegedly writes the records of peace, and whose screams are buried beneath diplomatic statements? Can a state preach mediation and broker ceasefires while reportedly waging covert operations against its own citizens and neighbours? Declaring a commitment to peace may appear noble, yet history repeatedly shows human civilisation advancing through conflict, with moral compromise left in its wake.

Karbala, the city of Shia martyrdom, embodies this collision of principle and brutality. Pilgrims walk barefoot to mourn Imam Hussain, grandson of Prophet Muhammad, betrayed and slain centuries ago. Centuries later, in the 1980s, the massacre of Iranian soldiers during the Iran-Iraq War echoed this horror. Saddam Hussein, reportedly armed by Western powers and regional allies, deployed chemical weapons with devastating efficiency.

Entire units, many unarmed, were allegedly killed in gas attacks, their bodies left to rot in trenches and deserts. One Iranian journalist recounted: "Soldiers were helpless, bleeding from the nose; no bullets fired. Hundreds of thousands died." The slaughter reportedly proceeded with almost no international scrutiny, as geopolitical expediency allegedly outweighed moral responsibility. Saddam, once a darling of the West, became a pariah, yet the deaths of victims were never fully accounted for. Pakistan occupied a shadowed role. While Western powers reportedly provided arms and intelligence to Iraq, Pakistan allegedly supplied weapons to Iran, including systems derived from Chinese and US inventories. Officially, Islamabad maintained diplomatic ties with post-revolution Tehran, yet clandestine coordination allegedly occurred through shared strategic interests, particularly in Afghanistan against the USSR. Pakistani troops were reportedly sent to Saudi Arabia, Iraq's backer, ostensibly for protection. The nation acted both as broker and executor, instrumentalised to serve external powers while domestic development lagged.

This duality is evident domestically. In Balochistan, decades of insurgency have reportedly been met with enforced disappearances, extrajudicial killings, and indiscriminate military campaigns. Entire communities have allegedly been displaced; civilians, often unarmed, are targeted under the guise of counter-terrorism.

Human rights organisations, including Amnesty International and Human Rights Watch, report that most victims are ordinary citizens. Yet the state reportedly justifies these actions in the language of national security, cloaking systematic repression in the rhetoric of patriotism.

Afghanistan presents a similar pattern. On the same day Pakistan drafted the peace proposal known as the "Islamabad Accord" to halt hostilities in the Iran conflict, cross-border shelling in Afghanistan's Khost, Paktia, and Paktika provinces has allegedly forced families into makeshift shelters and caves, displacing tens of thousands of civilians amid ongoing clashes. Children reportedly freeze on stone floors; mothers recount having "nowhere to go" after villages are destroyed. Taliban authorities claim that Pakistani mortar, missile, and drone strikes have killed civilians, including children, under the pretext of targeting militants. This incident followed on 16 March 2026, when Pakistani airstrikes reportedly struck the Omid drug rehabilitation centre in Kabul, Afghanistan, killing hundreds and causing severe casualties. Reports indicate massive casualties, with Afghan officials stating that over 400 people were killed, while the UN reported at least 143 initial deaths, most of them children. Yet internationally, Islamabad presents itself as a stabilising actor, the guardian of peace. Civilians appear sacrificed for strategic depth, while the state accrues legitimacy abroad.

Pakistan's domestic politics reinforce this paradox. Opposition leaders, notably Imran Khan, have faced imprisonment. An interview published in December 2025 in The Times UK claims: "Locked up for over 28 months in solitary confinement in what his sons call a 'death cell' in Adiala jail, Khan was allowed no visitors for the whole of November." The 73-year-old former cricket captain was reportedly "kept in a 6ft by 8ft cell, usually reserved for death row, allowed no reading material apart from the Quran, and given brown water to drink and wash with."

Previous leaders, including Nawaz Sharif and Benazir Bhutto, suffered exile or judicial disqualification. The military, constitutionally a guardian of the state, reportedly functions as the ultimate arbiter of political survival. Democracy is performative; institutions operate within the military-civilian framework. Media and civil society reportedly face pressure, dissent is criminalised, and political contestation is conditional on compliance with strategic imperatives.

The 2024 Iran-Pakistan incident illustrates this duality internationally. Iranian missile strikes in Balochistan, targeting Jaish ul-Adl militants, were condemned by Islamabad as violations of sovereignty. Pakistan retaliated with strikes inside Iran. By April 2026, reports claimed Pakistan helped broker a ceasefire between Iran and the United States. Here, diplomacy and coercion

coexist; aggression allegedly balances negotiation, violence with dialogue. Pakistan projects indispensability internationally while tolerating or perpetrating violence domestically. Historical parallels reinforce the pattern. In 1971, East Pakistan was violently suppressed under General Yahya Khan, with hundreds of thousands allegedly killed and millions displaced. The United States reportedly tolerated the massacre to protect strategic interests. During the Cold War, Pakistan acted as a conduit for US- and Saudi-backed operations in Afghanistan, training and arming mujahideen while its own civilian infrastructure allegedly languished. Weapons were supplied to Iran while clandestine coordination with Iraq reportedly continued. Human development, accountability, and institutional integrity were reportedly subordinated to strategic utility.

The Shia population along Pakistan's Iran border further demonstrates the stakes. Millions live in a region critical to regional balance yet often neglected in civic protection. They exist simultaneously as citizens and as instruments in a broader geopolitical calculus, exposed to cross-border violence, insurgency, and state neglect. The military's prioritisation of strategic leverage allegedly over civic welfare renders these communities vulnerable, even as Pakistan cultivates an image of mediation abroad.

Decades reveal a perfected dual strategy: domestically, repression; regionally, projection; internationally, negotiation. Civilian deaths, enforced disappearances, and political imprisonments coexist with diplomatic success. The military-civilian complex sustains relevance by appearing indispensable while tolerating internal oppression.

In Afghanistan, civilians recount fleeing shelling and living in caves with little food, water, or medicine-realities absent from narratives of mediation. A similar pattern persists in Balochistan: civilians displaced, insurgencies crushed, the state praised abroad.

Nothing captures this duality more starkly than global tolerance for strategy over human life-from Kissinger's secret diplomacy to the suffering of East Pakistan. Pakistan allegedly operates as facilitator abroad and executor at home, where influence is secured at the cost of its own citizens. Peace is brokered abroad; war executed at home.

Negotiations are public; killings clandestine. Citizens are displaced, silenced, expendable. Pakistan's double-edged strategy is structural and persistent. Advocating peace internationally while masking domestic repression may be nothing more than a mirage.

The writer is a columnist
based in Colombo

dailypioneer
@ilangamuwa1
nilanthailangamuwa

Electrifying growth in the capital



KUSHAN
MITRA

This past Saturday, as one state, Karnataka, announced that it was effectively withdrawing incentives for electric vehicles, particularly four-wheelers, the government of Delhi announced an extremely generous policy offering subsidies and benefits to buyers of electric vehicles. Such demand-side subsidies, particularly for two — and three-wheelers, as well as benefits on road tax and registration for four-wheelers below thirty lakh, if approved, are being seen as a positive step.

Or is it?

I would like to raise a couple of points here. Demand-side subsidies for electric vehicles, when the industry was nascent, were important to get sales moving along. Whether through FAME or PM-eDRIVE, these subsidies have had a huge impact.

In the three-wheeler space (non e-rickshaw), data released by the Federation of Automotive Dealer Associations, itself collated from the VAHAN portal of the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH), shows that over 60 per cent of three-wheelers sold across India last year were electric. Clearly, while subsidies helped, passenger and cargo operators saw the significant operating benefits of electric vehicles.

Running any electric vehicle is much cheaper than running an internal combustion engine, by a factor of five to ten times. When costs matter, particularly for commercial operators, this makes a significant difference to livelihoods.

There is no doubt that the central and state governments want to reduce India's dependency on oil and gas imports. This has become an even more vital issue today with the ongoing crisis in West Asia. Thankfully, major progress has been made in improving India's electricity grid and supply infrastructure, but challenges remain in EV adoption across the board, and instead of simple demand-side subsidies, including the lower rate of GST for EVs, these issues must be addressed more urgently through supply-side interventions.

While the Performance Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme has had some success in encouraging manufacturing, the main problem remains charging. This is particularly acute for passenger vehicles. An urban commuter today in any major city should ideally consider an electric vehicle but faces significant issues with charging — not just due to a lack of commercial charging infrastructure, but mainly at home. As Indians increasingly live in apart-



ments, many such societies have placed unreasonable roadblocks in installing chargers, and many who wish to buy an EV face hurdles in installing either personal or even community chargers. This issue needs to be addressed if electric vehicle adoption is to reach 10-15 per cent of all vehicles sold.

One interesting aspect of the new Delhi EV policy is the 50 per cent reduction in road tax for strong hybrid vehicles. Some have criticised this as an unnecessary incentive, but sales of hybrids are increasing across the world, including in China, where EV subsidies have been reduced. This is particularly interesting this year, as several manufacturers have announced that they will be launching new hybrid models in the market.

The promotion of electric vehicles is admirable by the Delhi government, as there is no doubt that vehicular pollution is a problem in the metropolis. However, several issues still need to be resolved, and these will require hard work rather than simply providing subsidies.

As an automotive evaluator, I believe electric vehicles have come a long way in the past decade. Electric vehicles are now enjoyable and reliable to drive, and range is largely not an issue. Sure, an EV may not fulfil every single niche in the market, which is why hybrids are also important.

While subsidies may continue for a few more years, I believe it is time that electric vehicles — whether scooters, three-wheelers, or passenger vehicles — stand on their own merit. One does not want a situation where EV sales collapse once subsidies are withdrawn. That is why building robust infrastructure and encouraging more chargers in residential areas, as well as battery-swapping stations, is crucial and should be the main focus of state governments.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The writer is Director and the
Printer & Publisher of
The Pioneer

kushanmitra
@kushanmitra
kushanmitra

iexceed

Appzillon™

AI Powered Digital Banking Solutions

WWW.i-exceed.com

BLASÉ CAPITAL

SPRING SURPRISES

As the global finance-related officials meet this week for the spring meetings of the World Bank and International Monetary Fund (IMF), the focus will be the war, and its economic consequences. The arguments, debates, and discussions will revolve around global growth, inflation, interest rates, shortages, disruptions, and currencies. Yet, there are forces, both internal and external, which wish the two main agencies to talk about other issues that are as important, and more crucial for the long term. The war will get over within weeks, a month, or months, and the economies will get back to normalcy within months, a year, or a couple of years. Yet, as the World Bank president, Ajay Banga, put it, jobs will possibly be the most critical issue over the next 10-15 years. Activist agencies like Oxfam, which recently released a report on IMF's tax advisories to nations, feel that inequality is what will define the world over the next decade or two, and will make or break it.

Banga estimates that 1.2 billion people will reach the working age in the developing nations in the next 10-15 years, and demand adequate and decent-paying jobs. He feels that based on the current growth trajectories in these nations, they will not be able to generate more than 400 million jobs. Thus, 800 million, or two-thirds of the new workforce will either remain jobless, or be employed in something hateful, painful, and less-paying. It will create public dissent, anger, desperations, frustrations, jealousies, stifled ambitions, even crime. Even more worrisome, the world's attention is on the short term due to the pandemic, Russia-Ukraine war, Iran war, and trade and tariff battles. Hence, he wants the officials to be engaged with the war, but think seriously about the longer horizon, and issues like jobs. Apart from this, he talks about access to basic amenities like clean water, and electricity in the developing and poor nations. "We have to walk, and chew gum at the same time. Short-velocity cycle is what we are going through. Longer velocity is this job's circumstance," he said in an interview.

According to the United Nations, more than 100 million people were displaced worldwide in 2025, and were obviously without jobs. These are in addition to the newcomers, who enter the working age. Add to them the mass layoffs across sectors due to tech disruptions. The looming scenario is one of doom as far as employment is concerned. Yet, Banga is confident about the future, and feels that the agencies like the World Bank and IMF, along with experts, will find solutions. "I do not know if you can ever get to a situation of utopia, and everybody is taken care of in the coming 15 years. I would doubt that is going to happen, but if you do not do it, the implications are quite severe in terms of illegal migration, and instability," he said. One needs to talk urgently to officials and businesses in the emerging markets and poor nations on how they can create local jobs, and those elsewhere.

Oxfam feels that one of the solutions may be for the rich nations, and even middle-income ones to tax the wealthy progressively, i.e., more tax as wealth grows or on higher wealth. In its recent report, it talks about the moves to build a global consensus towards effective and internationally-coordinated taxation of high net-worth individuals. There was a suggestion of a global two per cent minimum tax on billionaires and centimillionaires to raise \$300-390 billion. This money can be used by the nations to create jobs, remove inequalities, and raise the incomes of the poor and low-income groups. At the 2024 Spring Meetings, a senior IMF official said, "Many times, one hears calls for taxation targeting the super-rich; one sees calls for wealth taxation. Our position at the Fund is that taxing the returns from wealth is generally less distorting, and more equitable than a wealth tax." While the IMF has not endorsed net wealth tax, it has displayed a less hostile attitude towards it, and admitted that "there can be a case for using a net wealth tax to complement capital income taxes."

Yet, in practice, Oxfam found troublesome insights. IMF's overall global tax advice is "slightly regressive globally, i.e., when putting aside the income level, and location of countries examined. First, the Fund's policy advice in these years (2022-24) has focused slightly more on direct tax measures, i.e., those that target income (such as personal income taxes, corporate income taxes, and capital gains taxes) and wealth (property taxes and net wealth taxes). In total, 41 per cent of IMF tax advice concerns direct taxes, while advice on indirect taxes (such as consumption taxes and carbon taxes) accounts for around 33 per cent of overall advice. Several factors may play into this, including that (partly due to IMF advice and conditionality) value-added tax is now widespread across the globe. Nevertheless, tax advice is still characterised by a push for regressivity, i.e., shifting the tax burden away from the wealthiest in society at the expense of everyone else."

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | WEDNESDAY | APRIL 15, 2026

BUSINESS

10

Who is the loser in this slick zone?

Confusion reigns. It is the US, Iran, China, Saudi, or all of them

Of course, the immediate reactions were that the major loser due to the US blockade in the Strait of Hormuz, despite hints of a second round of Iran-US talks, is Iran. The estimates came out instantly. According to one estimate, Tehran may lose more than \$400 million a day. Yes, per day, or more than \$12 billion a month. This included \$150 million a day loss in the exports of 1.5 million barrels of crude oil at an average price of \$87, and a complete blockade that will impact 90 per cent of exports. Add to this figure, the exports of petrochemicals, and other products.

Some columnists, who are the supporters of Donald Trump, contend that the blockade is a better option than a ground-level military operation. It is the president's strategy at its best, better than bombarding a civilisation forever. The move effectively shuts off the crucial and sensitive Kharg Island, which accounts for 90 per cent of Iran's oil exports, and will "inflict similar damage to the Iranian economy without the risks involved in deploying US ground forces." The US economic-military action from distance will squeeze Teheran's cash flows, apply maximum pressure, and bring it to its knees.

Fair enough, because the US warships can allow friendly tankers from allies like Saudi Arabia to pass through the Strait to non-enemy consumers like India, and other Asian nations. The military can strangle the movements of Iranian vessels, which carry both legal and smuggled black contraband. This will put pressure on China, America's Enemy No. 1 (or is it Cuba,

Greenland, Iran?), which gets almost 50 per cent of its crude, and almost a third of its liquefied natural gas supplies through the Strait. So, China logically and naturally emerges as a critical collateral damage.

Let us not forget a huge caveat. According to various sources, there are already 140-190 million barrels of Iranian oil in the high seas, a part of it "west of Singapore," and a bulk of it "east of it," with most of it "destined for China." This represents anything between 90 to 130 days of exports, or anything up to \$15-16 billion of "floating inventory... in deferred revenues." It implies that if Iran can get the money into its coffers through secret payments in cryptos, or non-dollar currencies through surreptitious and legal banking channels, it can sustain, withstand, and counter the US blockade for 3-4 months.

However, once we have dusted and done away with Iran, and other enemies, the focus shifts to the US. The blockade will, theoretically, lead to huge traffic through the Strait of Hormuz, which will be difficult to monitor. America will need several warships, and military logistics to stop the Iranian flows, and this will cost huge amounts. Keeping a large battleship at sea is not cheap. Hence, it will cost the US. An analyst explains that the success will depend on the seizures of Iranian vessels in the initial days. "But in all likelihood... it will be difficult for the US to enforce," he adds. The costs can go up enormously.

Of course, the US will use the opportunity to use its tankers to come to the Strait, and ship the oil to the friendlies. This implies extra shipping and insurance costs, which may be paid by the buyers, but some costs will be borne by the Americans. Add to these costs, there is a feeling that the pump prices in the US will go up, which will be paid by the Americans. Apart from the economic costs, there are political costs attached with this scenario. Do not forget that the mid-term US elections are seven months ahead, and high pump prices are bad news.

Despite the excitement about the opening of the Strait of Hormuz, which handles 20-30 per cent of oil supplies, the Middle East is doubtful about the other implications. Saudi Arabia, according to reports, has told the US to back off from the blockade because Iran may target the Red Sea choke point. Since the closure of the Strait, Saudi has used this alternate route to ship oil. In the past, Iran-backed rebels have targeted the Red Sea, and there was speculation that the same may happen before the blockade. Now, the certainty value may go up.

According to a media report, "Saudi Arabia, after weeks of disruptions, managed to get its oil exports back up to its pre-war level of around seven million barrels a day by piping its crude across the desert to the Red Sea.... Riyadh is worried those supplies would be at risk if the Red Sea's exit routes were also closed." This stems from further doubts that the Strait may not be completely safe, despite the US efforts, and two routes may be a more effective and smart way to ensure supplies. Iran is desperate enough to do whatever it takes to stop the US.

One of the policy advisors to Iran's supreme leader, said in a social media post that Teheran looks at the Red Sea the way it looks at the Strait. In effect, it can close either or both the choke points. He warned that the flow of global energy and trade can be disrupted with a "single signal." In a statement, the Iranian military stated, "If the security of Iran's port... is threatened, no port in the Persian Gulf and the Sea of Oman will be safe." A part of the overall costs of the blockade will quickly shift to the Middle East producers and suppliers.

Although oil prices dropped from the above-\$100 a barrel to the high-\$90s after the US decision to squeeze Iran's oil, any escalations in the Red Sea, the US' inability to defend the Strait, or attacks on friendly tankers passing through it may push up the oil prices. This will put a part of the burden on the oil buyers, including more friendlies. In essence, several nations, and not just Iran, will pay the price for the blockade. It is a case of extreme damage to both the enemies and friends, including the main protagonist and instigator, the US.

However, Trump seems clear, at least as of now, that he wants the Strait cleared and safe. He can think of the Red Sea when it turns black with damaged oil pipelines and tankers. He wants to push back Iran, as far back economically as he can. He needs to show some victories.

OUR TAKE

A Contrarian Investor

Lots of SIPs to mop up stocks

Small investors throng to markets despite the mayhem in March

lump-sum amounts. Hence, the new account additions in March were just a fifth of the numbers in February, the possibilities of higher amounts or lump-sums seem justified. Some ran away but others were brave. The latter put the fears aside, and took higher risks for several reasons.

Market corrections triggered by geopolitical shocks encouraged the existing investors to increase allocations. Many retail investors are now smart and savvy, and based on past experiences, have realised that the steep declines, which are temporary like wars, are entry opportunities rather than exit signals. During both the financial crisis of 2008, and pandemic, such small investors lost the chances to make huge profits, as they went helter-skelter, away from stocks, only to see their shares, and indices bounce back rapidly and majestically. This time though, many of the war and Covid-scarred ones stayed put.

As far as the AUMs are concerned, the dip is self-explanatory. As the indices tumbled, and stocks took a beating, despite the inflows, the market values of the mutual funds' holdings declined. Since they need to

immediately resort to mark-to-market, and adjust AUMs as per the current prices, the values took a logical dip. One needs to figure out if the managers of the mutual funds decided to stay put, or increase their exposures to stocks, rather than quietly cash out from shares where they had earned handsome returns, and wait to buy at the lows.

Anand Vardarajan, Chief Business Officer, Tata Asset Management, noted, "It was heartening to see nearly ₹40,500 crore in the equity (mutual fund) category, and investors used the market fall in March to increase their equity allocations. As FY26 comes to a close we have seen some major shifts in flows. Flexi-cap saw the highest inflow for the month and for the year. Midcap and small-cap were close next." Thus, the retail investors showed confidence in stocks, even though the prices were down, and indices were hammered through March.

Pankaj Shrestha, Head of Investment Services, PL Wealth Management, said, "The strong net equity inflow of ₹40,450 crore in March, despite it being one of the most volatile months in the near term, reflects robust investor conviction in the long-term

equity story. Rather than being deterred by short-term fluctuations, investors used the opportunity to increase their equity allocations. The record SIP inflow... reflects growing investor discipline, and a clear shift towards systematic investing." In essence, small investors are more disciplined, and habitual when it comes to SIPs, even if some are scared.

The data further underscores the growing importance of domestic investors in stabilising Indian markets, especially when the foreign investors pulled out funds amid global uncertainties. Karthick Jonagadla, founder and CEO, Quantace Research, said, "March 2026 AMFI data strengthens the Indian constructive case: Households

treated global stress as a buying opportunity, not a signal to retreat. From an Indian market perspective, domestic savings are no longer just supportive liquidity; they are an active shock absorber. That does not remove macro risk, but it does mean external volatility is increasingly being met by a deeper, steadier domestic bid."

A closer look at the flow trends reveals a strong preference for diversified and growth-oriented categories. Flexi-cap funds emerged as the top category, followed closely by mid- and small-cap funds, indicating that investors are willing to take calibrated risks for higher long-term returns. Normally, the small-caps and midcaps are the stocks that face the worst battering due to downturns and corrections. As Vardarajan highlighted, hybrid categories saw selective flows, with investors gravitating towards multi-asset strategies for diversification, while arbitrage and debt funds faced pressure.

Overall, March's data reinforces a key trend: Indian retail investors are no longer passive participants but active, disciplined allocators of capital, capable of absorbing global shocks and sustaining market momentum through consistent inflows.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

Reserve Bank of India’s monetary policy focuses on growth



In the monetary policy announced by the Reserve Bank during the first week of April, the central bank delivered a strong message by keeping the repo rate and other policy interest rates unchanged, and simultaneously maintaining its stance as ‘Neutral’ (or status quo). This signals that, despite rising crude oil prices, supply chain disruptions, blockages in international trade routes, and global turmoil, India’s policymakers remain confident in the country’s economic fundamentals and are committed to sustaining a growth-conducive environment within the nation.

Prior to the monetary policy announcement, however, apprehensions were being voiced that the trajectory of successive repo rate reductions — which had been pursued through 2025 — might face reversal. It was feared that, driven by inflationary expectations, the repo rate could either be hiked or, at the very least, the monetary policy stance might be downgraded from ‘Neutral’ to ‘Accommodative’.

However, dispelling these apprehensions, the economic outlook presented by the Reserve Bank demonstrates that — notwithstanding global turmoil and challenges — the economy remains in a robust position. Consequently,

maintaining the repo rate at 5.25 per cent is deemed an appropriate policy measure to keep the path of economic growth unhindered. It is noteworthy that by keeping the repo rate low through its monetary policy, the Reserve Bank can stimulate domestic investment as well as the demand for durable goods and housing, thereby paving the way for accelerated economic growth. However, the primary prerequisite for lowering the repo rate is that domestic inflation levels must be low. If inflation is high — or if future inflationary expectations are elevated —reducing the repo rate could potentially exacerbate inflation further. Therefore, in a scenario where inflation is running high, the central bank (the RBI) cannot afford to take the risk of lowering the repo rate. However, despite the prevailing geopolitical landscape, fears of rising inflation, and disrupted supply chains, the Reserve Bank has undertaken the crucial task of keeping the engine of growth running by making the difficult decision to maintain the repo rate at a steady level — a move involving a calculated risk.

Inflation and growth expectations

Inflation forecasts suggest that the rate is likely to range between 4.5 per cent and 4.6 per cent in the year 2026-27. Although this figure is significantly higher than the 2.1 per cent inflation recorded in 2025-26, it is still projected to remain within the target range of 2 per cent to 6 per cent set for the Monetary Policy Committee. As per the monetary policy framework effective April 2026, the formulation of monetary



policy must ensure that inflation remains within the band of 4 per cent (plus or minus 2 per cent). Consequently, should there be any risk of this limit being breached, it becomes imperative to raise the repo rate and adopt other measures to tighten monetary conditions. It is for this reason — given that inflation currently remains within the prescribed limits set for the Monetary Policy Committee — that the Reserve Bank has decided to keep the repo rate unchanged.

Growth outlook

The Reserve Bank has pegged growth prospects for 2026-27 at 6.2 per cent. Notably, GDP growth is expected to stand at 7.4 per cent in 2025-26. This implies that there is a possibility of a

decline in growth, albeit a marginal one. It is worth noting that the potential impact of global turbulence on growth has not swayed the Reserve Bank from its stance. The underlying reason for this is the robust fundamentals of the Indian economy, which ensure that global volatility will not be able to undermine India’s growth prospects.

Liquidity management

It is essential to understand that maintaining liquidity at an optimal level is just as crucial as keeping the repo rate low, ensuring that short-term interest rates remain anchored around the repo rate. To achieve this, the Reserve Bank manages liquidity using instruments such as Open Market Operations (OMO),

variable repo rates, and variable reverse repo rates. Through these instruments, the Reserve Bank ensures that appropriate liquidity levels (neither too low nor too high) are maintained, thereby ensuring that the call rate — specifically the Weighted Average Call Rate (WACR) — does not exceed the repo rate by more than 0.10 to 0.15 percentage points. The call rate is the interest rate at which a bank borrows funds from other banks for the short term.

Currently, a major challenge confronting Indian banks is that their credit growth continues to significantly outpace their deposit growth. To bridge this gap, banks are compelled to borrow funds at interest rates higher than their lending rates. This situation has arisen because, for some time now, individuals have been channeling their savings into mutual funds rather than depositing them in banks. The Reserve Bank will need to find a solution to this issue as well.

It must be recognised that, through its monetary policy, the Reserve Bank endeavors to achieve a diverse range of objectives and targets. It is gratifying to note that, thanks to appropriate policy measures, Indian banks have largely overcome the problem of ‘NPAs’ — or Non-Performing Assets. The overall health of the banking sector is improving. Through monetary policy, inflation is being brought under control on one hand, while economic growth is gaining momentum on the other, thanks to lower policy interest rate.

As digitisation helps reduce operational costs for banks, the Reserve Bank is poised to play a pivotal role in guiding the nation toward its goal of becoming

a developed economy. To realise the objective of self-reliance, banks must ensure an adequate flow of credit while simultaneously ensuring the timely repayment of loans; this necessitates rigorously vetting credit proposals against the criterion of repayment capacity. It is reasonable to anticipate that the monetary policy announced in April will prove instrumental in achieving these developmental goals.

Despite global headwinds, the RBI has been able to steer the rupee towards relative stability, even after a sharp depreciation of more than 4 per cent in a short span, through a judicious mix of policy measures and direct interventions in the foreign exchange markets. These include curbs on speculative activities, which have historically been a major cause of significant volatility in the rupee’s value.

Now, the challenge before the RBI is to ensure that growth prospects are not adversely affected by the global scenario marked by wars and conflicts, disruptions in global value chains, and blocked international trade routes.

A firm monetary policy, focused at growth with stability, by preventing a rise in interest rates and providing sufficient liquidity to to boost growth and at the same time, keeping inflationary tendencies under check would be crucial. The RBI’s task will be formidable in ensuring adequate credit flow, managing liquidity, keeping inflation under control, and providing a boost to growth.

The writer is a National Co-convenor, Swadeshi Jagran Manch Former Professor, PGDAV College and University of Delhi

China’s exports grew 2.5 per cent in March in sharp slowdown as Iran war raises uncertainty

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Hong Kong



China’s exports grew 2.5 per cent in March from a year ago, significantly slowing from the previous two months as uncertainties rose from the Iran war and its impact on energy prices and global demand.

The March export data released by China’s customs agency Tuesday missed analysts’ estimates and was sharply down from the 21.8 per cent export growth recorded for January and February.

Imports last month surged 27.8 per cent, up from the 19.8 per cent year-on-year increase in the first two months of this year.

Technology-related exports including a jump in shipments of semiconductors

from China on the global artificial intelligence boom have powered its robust exports in early 2026, but economists say impacts from the prolonged Iran war could affect overall global demand for Chinese exports this year. “China’s exports have decelerated as the Iran war

starts to affect global demand and supply chains,” said Gary Ng, a senior economist for Asia Pacific at French bank Natixis. Despite the significant rebound in China’s export growth in January and February, demand is likely to weaken due to the war’s

energy shock, Bank of America economists led by Helen Qiao wrote in a recent research note.

The risks will “arise from a persistent global slowdown in overall demand if the conflict lasts longer than currently expected,” they wrote.

US President Donald Trump’s elevated tariffs on Chinese exports and tensions between Washington and Beijing have also been straining China’s shipments to the US over the past months, with China stepping up its exports to other regions including Europe, Southeast Asia and Latin America.

Analysts are also closely watching Trump’s planned visit to Beijing in May to meet with Chinese leader Xi Jinping following a delay due to the Iran war.

Fuel price freeze: ₹18/litre loss on petrol, ₹35 on diesel

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi



Losses on petrol have widened to ₹18 per litre and to ₹35 on diesel as state-owned fuel retailers continue to keep pump prices frozen despite a sharp rise in input costs, sources said.

Despite prices being deregulated more than a decade back, state-owned Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPL) have not changed the retail petrol and diesel price since April 2022. Global crude oil prices have seen sharp fluctuations over this period — from above \$100 per barrel following the Russia-Ukraine war, to easing to around \$70 a barrel earlier this year, before surging again to about \$120 last month after

the US-Israel attacks on Iran triggered fresh supply concerns.

The three firms were incurring losses of about ₹2,400 crore per day at the peak last month, which have since narrowed to around ₹1,600 crore daily after the Government cut excise duty on petrol and diesel by ₹10 per litre each — a reduction that was not passed on to consumers but used to partly offset losses, industry

sources said. The losses in March have wiped away all gains they made in January/February, they said, adding the three firms are most likely to post losses in the January-March quarter. Macquarie Group, in a report on ‘India Fuel Retail’, said, “At spot petrol-diesel pricing of \$135-165 per barrel, we estimate India’s oil marketing companies lose ₹18 and ₹35 per litre on petrol and diesel sales (respective-

ly).” Every \$10 per barrel increase in crude adds roughly ₹6 per litre to marketing losses, the report said.

The brokerage flagged a high likelihood of retail fuel price hikes after elections in key states like West Bengal and Tamil Nadu at the end of this month. “We see risk of higher pump prices post state elections in April.”

India, which imported about 88 per cent of its crude oil requirement in 2025, remains highly exposed to global price swings. Around 45 per cent of imports came from the Middle East, 35 per cent from Russia and 6 per cent from the United States. Despite this, the country continued to be a net exporter of key petroleum products, including diesel, petrol and aviation turbine fuel.

India set to emerge as world’s 2nd largest solar market in 2026: NSEFI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India is poised to become the World’s second-largest solar market in 2026 in terms of annual installation, the National Solar Energy Federation of India (NSEFI) said on Wednesday.

India has achieved its fastest-ever addition of 50 GW of solar capacity in just 14 months, reaching the landmark 150 GW milestone, according to an NSEFI statement.

This marks a significant acceleration compared to the 11 years it took to reach the first 50 GW, followed by nearly three years to scale up to 100 GW.

NSEFI CEO Subrahmanyam Pulipaka said that solar energy is projected to reach 280-300 GW to support India’s 500 GW non-fossil

capacity target by 2030. With the current pace, India is nearing an annual addition trajectory of 50 GW, firmly aligning with this goal.

In fact, the country is witnessing strong potential for solar capacity to exceed these projections, driven by initiatives such as PM Surya Ghar, the upcoming PM KUSUM 2.0, dedicated floating solar policies, and the growing demand linked to the National Green Hydrogen Mission over the next four years, Pulipaka noted.

Amid shifting geopolitical dynamics, NSEFI projected that India is well on track to become the world’s second-largest solar market in 2026 in terms of annual installations.

Global trends point to a potential slowdown in capacity additions across major markets, such as the United



States and the European Union, which are currently competing for the second position in terms of annual installed capacity, it noted.

In contrast, India continues to accelerate its renewable energy deployment and consistently outpaces key milestones and is set to emerge as a nation with the second-

largest annual installations in the coming year, Pulipaka added.

NSEFI highlights that Distributed Renewable Energy (DRE) and Commercial & Industrial (C&I) solar adoption will be the key drivers of growth over the next three years.

“The C&I segment has sur-

passed expectations, crossing double-digit annual installations of nearly 10 GW for the first time, and this is just the beginning.

Policy enablers, such as Green Energy Open Access, Virtual Power Purchase Agreements (VPPAs), and the Renewable Consumption Obligation (RCO) framework, are unlocking substantial demand.

Within the next two years, we expect C&I capacity additions to rival those under utility-led PPAs,” Pulipaka noted. Flagship Government programmes, such as PM Surya Ghar and PM KUSUM, have significantly boosted DRE adoption.

While DRE currently accounts for nearly 20 per cent of India’s installed solar capacity, NSEFI projects this share to increase to 35 per cent by 2030.

Govt should cap charges of product testing under quality control order: GTRI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Government should cap testing charges for routine industrial products as high costs to comply with the quality control orders (QCOs) may impact the country’s manufacturing and small importers, think tank GTRI said on Tuesday.

While the QCO policy aims to improve product quality and consumer safety, the pace of expansion is putting pressure on testing infrastructure and has created significant compliance bottlenecks for MSMEs, the Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) said.

“India’s expanding quality control regime is imposing such high testing and certification costs that many



MSME importers may be pushed out of business, leaving the market increasingly dominated by large importers,” GTRI Founder Ajay Srivastava said.

The charges arise under the Foreign Manufacturers Certification Scheme (FMCS) of the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS), under which foreign manufacturers of products covered by India’s

Quality Control Orders have to obtain BIS certification before exporting to India.

The process requires foreign suppliers to appoint an authorised Indian representative, submit technical documents, undergo BIS factory inspections, provide samples for testing at BIS-approved labs, and secure a BIS licence before exports can commence, he said.

India must cut fertiliser import dependence, leverage AI and precision tech: ICAR chief

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi



A comprehensive approach spanning short, medium and long-term strategies is needed to reduce India’s dependence on fertiliser imports, ICAR Director General ML Jat said on Tuesday, calling for greater use of artificial intelligence, precision nutrient management and sensor-based systems to optimise fertiliser use.

Addressing mediapersons after a brainstorming session to develop a roadmap for achieving ‘Atmanirbharta’ (self-reliance) in fertilisers, organised by the National Academy of Agricultural Sciences (NAAS) here, Jat

balanced and need-based fertiliser application, and enhancing awareness among farmers are important steps in the right direction.

Jat said crop diversification towards pulses and oilseeds, recycling organic waste under the Waste-to-Wealth initiative, and increasing the use of biological sources would further contribute to reducing dependence on chemical fertilisers.

The session was attended by representatives from concerned government departments, academia, the fertiliser industry and farmers, who unanimously stressed the necessity of self-reliance in the critical sector.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) today announced that all sectors of the Indian Automobile industry — passenger vehicles, two-wheelers, three-wheelers and commercial vehicles all recorded the highest ever sales volume in a financial year for the year ended March 31, 2026.

Passenger vehicles sales touched 46.43 lakh units, a growth of 7.6 per cent from the previous year and two-wheeler sales touched 2.17 crore units with a growth of 10.7 per cent.

Three-wheelers registered a sales growth of 12.8 per cent and Commercial Vehicles 12.6 per cent. Exports also significant growth with passenger



vehicle imports touching 9 lakh units and 51.8 lakh two-wheelers were also exported from India.

Speaking to the media in Delhi, Shailesh Chandra, Managing Director, Tata Motors Passenger cars and

President, SIAM attributed the growth to multiple factors starting with income tax reform at the start of the year, reduced interest rates and finally the major GST 2.0 reforms in the second half of the year.

While pointing out that the outlook for the coming year was generally positive with major institutions predicting continued economic growth of between 6.5 - 7.5 percent, the current West Asia crisis is creating some concerns.

This he said could be seen in the spike of demand for electric vehicles in March, “While March does see increased sales due to buyers wanting to take advantage of depreciation benefits, speaking about Tata Motors I can tell you that almost 30 per cent of our electric vehicle buyers were choosing to buy an EV because of concerns with fuel prices going forward.”

He highlighted that SIAM and its members were in constant communication with the Government around

the crisis. “While there are no immediate concerns with fuel supplies or with supply chain management, if the war continues, supplies could get constrained and if fuel prices go up, that will certainly have an inflationary impact”, Chandra said. Exports could get impacted because of increased tariffs in Mexico and supply issues to West Asia and North Africa which are major export markets for Indian passenger cars and two-wheelers.

But he said that the industry was still very positive after hitting such sales numbers, and despite SIAM members often lobbying against each other especially around the CAFE-III norms that will be implemented from April, 2027, the industry was looking forward to continued growth.

FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

16 arrested in Punjab province

Pakistan's security agencies have arrested sixteen terrorists belonging to various terror outfits in multiple operations conducted in Punjab province, an official said on Tuesday. Security forces conducted 113 intelligence-based operations (IBOs) over the past week in different districts, which led to the arrest of these terrorists, a spokesperson for the Counter Terrorism Department (CTD) said. A major terror plot was foiled by Punjab police by arresting 16 terrorists belonging to various banned organisations, including Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), Al-Qaeda and Daesh (ISIS), he said. "A dangerous suicide bomber of Fitna-ul-Khawarij has also been arrested from Jhang, while another terrorist identified as Moin Khan, involved in attacks on security institutions, was arrested from Sargodha," he added.

AUSTRALIA

Harry arrives in Melbourne

Prince Harry and his wife Meghan, the Duke and Duchess of Sussex, arrived in Melbourne on Tuesday for their first Australian visit since their official royal tour in 2018. The lower-key four-day Australian visit comes after the couple announced in 2020 they planned to "step back" as senior royals and to become financially independent in their Californian base. The Sussexes describe their visit as privately funded, and they flew to Melbourne business class from Los Angeles on a commercial Qantas Airways flight. But there have been public complaints about the added security costs for police agencies as the couple visits Melbourne, Canberra and Sydney. The cost of security explains why the couple won't be greeted by thousands of people at public events as they were during their 16-day tour as newlyweds in 2018 to Australia, New Zealand, Fiji and Tonga.

Won't abide by Lebanon-Israel agreement: Hezbollah

ABBY SEWELL ■ Beirut

The Lebanese militant group Hezbollah will not abide by any agreements that may result from the direct Lebanon-Israel talks in the United States, negotiations it firmly opposes, a senior Hezbollah official said. Wafiq Safa, a high-ranking member of Hezbollah's political council, spoke on the eve of the talks expected in Washington between Lebanese and Israeli ambassadors to the US. It will be the first time in decades that envoys from Lebanon and Israel, which do not have diplomatic relations, meet face-to-face in direct talks. "As for the outcomes of this negotiation between Lebanon and the Israeli enemy, we are not interested in or concerned with them at all," Safa told *The*



Wafiq Safa, senior Hezbollah political council member, speaking during an interview with *The Associated Press* in Beirut

Associated Press. "We are not bound by what they agree to," he added in a rare interview with international media. He spoke next to a cemetery as an Israeli

drone buzzed overhead.

Lebanese officials are looking to broker a ceasefire in the Israel-Hezbollah war in the US talks. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin

Netanyahu, meanwhile, has said the goal is Hezbollah's disarmament and a potential peace agreement between Lebanon and Israel. Shosh Bedrosian, a spokesperson for Netanyahu said Monday that there will be no ceasefire with Hezbollah. Separately, in US-Iran peace talks held last weekend in Pakistan, Iran has sought to include Lebanon in any ceasefire deal of its own with the US-Israel and the US have insisted Lebanon would not be a part of it. Hours after Tehran and Washington announced a truce last Wednesday, Israel launched more than 100 strikes across Lebanon, including in densely packed residential and commercial areas of central Beirut. And though the US-Iran talks broke up without an agreement, Safa said Hezbollah has been

informed that Iran "was able to obtain a cessation of attacks" in the entire administrative region of Beirut, Lebanon's capital, including Beirut's southern suburbs — a Hezbollah-strong area known as Dahiyeh. Israeli strikes on Beirut and its southern suburbs have halted since Wednesday but intense fighting has continued in southern Lebanon. Hezbollah's entry into the war Israel and Hezbollah have fought multiple wars since the Iran-backed Lebanese militant group was formed in the 1980s as a guerrilla force fighting against Israel's occupation of southern Lebanon at the time. The latest round began on March 2, two days after Israel and the US launched a war on Iran. Hezbollah entered the fray, firing missiles across the border into Israel. Israel

responded with aerial bombardment and a ground invasion. Since then, the war has displaced more than 1 million people in Lebanon and killed more than 2,000, including more than 500 women, children and medical workers. Many Lebanese have blamed Hezbollah for pulling Lebanon into the war, accusing it of acting on behalf of its patron, Iran. Safa said Hezbollah's actions were preemptive because its leaders believed "Israel was preparing for a second battle with Lebanon" with the aim of destroying Hezbollah. It was "an appropriate moment for Hezbollah ... to rebuild a new equation" and restore deterrence against Israel, he said, denying any prior deals with Tehran that Hezbollah would enter the war if Iran was attacked. (AP)

Guterres urges continued US-Iran talks

YOSHITA SINGH ■ United Nations

UN chief Antonio Guterres has called for continued constructive discussions between Iran and the US, while stressing the ceasefire "must absolutely be preserved" after the talks between the two nations on the West Asia conflict concluded without a deal. The 21-hour-long negotiations between the US, led by Vice President JD Vance, and Iran in Pakistan on Saturday concluded without an agreement to end the war. "While no agreement was reached at the talks hosted by Pakistan between the United States and the Islamic Republic of Iran in



Islamabad, the discussions themselves underscored the seriousness of their engagement and constituted a positive and meaningful step toward renewed dialogue," a statement issued by the spokesperson for the UN Secretary General Guterres

said on Monday.

"They have chosen not to accept our terms," Vance had said in a news conference in Islamabad. "We leave here with a very simple proposal: a method of understanding that is our final and best offer," he said, adding that "We'll see if the Iranians accept it."

Guterres said that given the deeply rooted differences, an "agreement cannot be reached overnight" and called on the talks to continue constructively for an agreement to be reached.

"At the same time, the ceasefire must absolutely be preserved. All violations must cease," Guterres said, adding that after weeks of

destruction and distress, it is clear that there is no military solution to the current conflict in the West Asia. Last week, the United States and Iran announced a two-week ceasefire in the fighting. Guterres thanked the continued efforts of the mediators — Pakistan, which hosted talks Saturday, as well as Saudi Arabia, Egypt and Türkiye — and called for the international community to support those efforts.

The Secretary-General's Personal Envoy, Jean Arnault, also remains actively engaged in the region, consulting closely with key stakeholders and continuing his outreach in support of a comprehensive and durable agreement. (PTI)

Macron, Starmer to co-chair talks on Hormuz mission to protect shipping

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Paris

French President Emmanuel Macron and British Prime Minister Keir Starmer will co-chair a conference Friday in Paris, bringing together non-belligerent nations willing to participate in a mission in the Strait of Hormuz "when security conditions allow." Other participants will take part via videoconference, Macron's office said. European and other partners are ready to contribute to a "purely defensive mission aimed at restoring freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz," the statement said. France and



A cargo ship sailing in the Persian Gulf towards Dubai port as seen from Ajman, United Arab Emirates

Britain have been working in recent weeks to set up an operation to escort oil

tankers and container ships to help ensure safe passage through the strait.

Misri reaches Berlin for India-Germany Foreign Office consultations

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ London

Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri reached Berlin on Tuesday where he will hold talks with German officials on a wide range of issues, including trade and investment, defence and security, technology, green energy and other key global and regional developments. "Foreign Secretary @VikramMisri arrives in Berlin for India-Germany Foreign Office consultations," the Indian Embassy in Germany said in a post on X. "The visit follows Chancellor Friedrich Merz's successful visit to India in January 2026 and reflects continued regular high-level exchanges between



India and Germany," it added.

Misri will co-chair the India-Germany Foreign

Office Consultations alongside Geza Andreas von Geyr, State Secretary of the German Foreign Office.

The discussions will cover diverse domains of bilateral co-operation, including trade and investments, defence and security, technology, green energy, development co-operation, education and people-to-people ties as well as global and regional matters of mutual interest, the Ministry of External Affairs said ahead of his visit. His visit provides an opportunity to review the full spectrum of the India-Germany Strategic Partnership, India's Ambassador to Germany Ajit Gupte said in a social media post. "Advance discussions across key pillars of the bilateral agenda and exchange perspectives on regional and global developments" are

scheduled to take place during the visit, he added. Misri arrived in Germany from France, where he held discussions on a wide range of issues, including civil nuclear energy, defence, space and digital co-operation. His visit to France and Germany comes amid escalating tensions in West Asia after the US and Iran failed to secure a lasting peace deal to end hostilities following their marathon talks in Pakistan over the weekend. US President Donald Trump has announced the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz in a bid to cripple Iran's oil supplies to China and other countries amid a deepening global energy crisis.

Pope starts Africa tour in Algeria and calls for peace against Iran war's backdrop

NICOLE WINFIELD/ AOMAR OUALI/ PAOLO SANTALUCIA ■ Algiers

Pope Leo XIV called for peace and the end of "neocolonial tendencies" in world affairs on Monday during the first papal visit to Algeria, all while facing an extraordinary broadside by President Donald Trump over his criticism of the US-Israeli war with Iran. Leo's arrival in Algiers marks the start of an 11-day tour of four African nations - Algeria, Cameroon, Angola and Equatorial Guinea - that will bring the first US-born pope deep into the growing heart of the Catholic Church. Leo is in Algeria to promote Christian-Muslim coexistence in the majority Muslim nation at a time of global conflict, and to honor the locally born inspiration of his religious spirituality, St Augustine.



The trip began, however, against the backdrop of a growing feud between the Leo and Trump over the Iran war. Trump overnight said he didn't think Leo was doing a good job as pope and suggested he should "stop catering to the Radical Left." Leo responded by saying his appeals for peace and reconciliation are rooted in the Gospel, and that he didn't fear the Trump administration. (AP)



People participating at the Baishakhi Shobhajatra procession to celebrate the first day of the Bangla New Year in Dhaka, Bangladesh

West Asia conflict threatens to push 2.5 million people in India into poverty: UNDP report

YOSHITA SINGH ■ United Nations

The conflict and military escalation in West Asia threatens to push 2.5 million people in India into poverty and the country is projected to experience some loss in its human development progress, according to estimates and projections by the United Nations. The United Nations Development Programme, in a report titled 'Military Escalation In The Middle East: Human Development Impacts Across Asia And The Pacific' noted that the conflict is "widening human development pressures across Asia and the Pacific. Through higher fuel, freight, and input costs, the shock is diminishing household purchas-



ing power, raising food insecurity, straining public budgets, and weakening livelihoods." The preliminary assessment, issued on Tuesday, estimates that globally 8.8 million people are at risk of falling into poverty and the West Asia military escalation could cost Asia-Pacific up to \$299 billion. In India, poverty is expect-

ed to rise from around 400,000 to 2.5 million, the report said. It added that the number of people pushed into poverty in the world as a result of the conflict rises from approximately 1.9 million to nearly 8.8 million across scenarios, with South Asia accounting for the largest share, ranging from about 1.7 million to over 8 million, reflecting both the subregion's population size and its higher exposure to income and price shocks. China is estimated to experience a more moderate increase in the number of people at risk of falling into poverty, from around 115,000 to over 620,000, reflecting small proportional changes applied to a very large population base. Highlighting the estimated

poverty impact of the military escalation (28-day conflict, most severe scenario with 8-month adjustment), the report said that India's poverty rate is estimated to rise to 24.2 per cent post-crisis from 23.9 per cent, pushing 2,464,698 people into poverty. An estimated 3,54,033,698 people are projected to live in poverty in the country post-crisis as compared to 351,569,000 pre-crisis. The UNDP simulation estimates the impact of the conflict on the Human Development Index (HDI) for countries across the region. It indicates that Iran's HDI could decline by an amount equivalent to roughly one to one and a half years of human development progress. "India is projected to experience a loss of approximate-

ly 0.03–0.12 years of HDI progress, followed by Nepal at around 0.02–0.09 years and Viet Nam at 0.02–0.07 years, while for China, the estimated effects on HDI remain limited in magnitude, ranging roughly 0.01–0.05 years," it said. The report notes that among the region's larger importers, India meets over 90 per cent of its oil needs through imports, sourcing more than 40 per cent of crude imports and 90 per cent of LPG imports from West Asia. Further, West Asian countries supply over 45 per cent of India's fertiliser imports, while 85 per cent of the country's domestic urea production depends on imported regasified liquefied natural gas. The shock of the conflict is also

influencing energy choices in several countries. On trade and supply chain disruptions, UNDP country-level analysis indicated significant impacts in 25 out of 36 countries through freight surcharges, war-risk insurance premia, route diversions, and delayed delivery of intermediate and consumer goods. India's assessment shows that West Asian markets account for 14 per cent of exports and 20.9 per cent of imports, with roughly \$48 billion in non-oil exports, particularly in basmati rice, tea, gems and jewellery, and apparel. Bangladesh also reports significant disruption as Gulf carriers cancelled flights, shipments from Bangladesh and

India were stranded, it said. Highlighting the impact of the military escalation on food security, the report said that "For several countries, including India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, and the Philippines, food security pressures could also be compounded by remittance losses, and reduced Gulf economic activity weakens household incomes and purchasing power." "In India, the timing is especially sensitive: any prolonged disruption would coincide with the preparations for the Kharif (the monsoon cropping season), which begins in June. Urea stocks stood at 6.114 million tons, providing a near-term buffer but not fully insulating the sector if disruptions persist into the planting season," it said. (PTI)

Zelenskyy meets German Chancellor in Berlin

KIRSTEN GRIESHABER
■ Berlin

Ukraine and Germany are starting work on plans for the joint production of advanced drones and other battle-tested defence systems, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Tuesday, as Kyiv looks to scale up its more than four-year fight against Russia's all-out invasion.

"We have proposed to Germany a bilateral drone deal covering various types of drones, missiles, software and modern defence systems. Our teams are starting concrete work," Zelenskyy said at a joint news conference with German Chancellor Friedrich Merz during a visit to Berlin.

Merz said that Germany's commitment to supporting Kyiv's war effort is "a very clear signal" to



German chancellor Friedrich Merz welcomes Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy for German-Ukrainian Government consultations in Berlin Germany AP

Russia. "We will not waver in our efforts to defend Ukraine," he said.

US-led diplomatic efforts to end Russia's war on its neighbour have recently petered out as the Iran war grips the Trump administration's

attention, although Tammy Bruce, the deputy US ambassador to the United Nations, told the UN Security Council on Monday that Washington "will continue to push for a negotiated and durable end"

to the war. Russia has occupied about 20 per cent of Ukraine so far. That includes the Crimean Peninsula, which Russia seized in 2014.

Ukraine has the capacity to produce twice as much military equipment as it's currently deploying, but lacks funding to step up production, according to Zelenskyy. "We simply don't have enough money," he said.

A key to unlocking that potential lies in obtaining a promised 90 billion-euro (\$106 billion) loan from the European Union.

That was being held up by Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orban, but his impending departure from office after a weekend election could free up the money.

Ukraine needs those funds "urgently," Merz said. After Berlin, Zelenskyy was due to visit Norway,

another important financial and military ally, while defence leaders from the 50-plus partner nations who regularly gather to coordinate weapons aid for Kyiv will hold an online meeting on Wednesday, Ukraine's Defence Ministry said.

Kyiv is heavily reliant on US intelligence for targeting inside Russia and needs more sophisticated American-made air defence systems to stop Russian missile attacks on its power grid.

If the Iran war drags on, it could erode vital US support for Kyiv, Zelenskyy fears. Furthermore, the Ukrainian army is short-handed, facing around 200,000 troop desertions and draft-dodging by around 2 million people, Ukrainian Defence Minister Mykhailo said in January. Germany will help Kyiv facilitate the return home of Ukrainian men of military age, Merz said. (AP)

Harvey Weinstein goes on trial again in New York rape case



JENNIFER PELTZ ■ New York

After years of #MeToo infamy, legal peril and prison, Harvey Weinstein is again going on trial on a rape charge in New York City. Jury selection is set to start as early as Tuesday in the onetime movie mogul's latest retrial, where jurors will weigh – for the third time – whether he raped hairstylist and actor Jessica Mann in a Manhattan hotel in 2013.

But "it's not going to be a mirror image of the last trial," new Weinstein lawyer Marc Agnifilo told Judge Curtis Farber last month.

This time, jurors will weigh only one charge based on one accuser, rather than the array of allegations that were aired at Weinstein's previous trials in New York and Los Angeles.

The Oscar-winning producer

denies all the accusations and declared in court this winter that he had "acted wrongly, but I never assaulted anyone." The judge has indicated he might revisit some rulings about exactly what evidence gets presented about Weinstein's and Mann's years of interactions. And Weinstein's recent change in attorneys could shift the trial's tenor and tactics. Agnifilo and his partners took on the case only in February, when longtime Weinstein lawyer Arthur Aidala stepped aside from the retrial to focus on the former studio boss's appeals and civil matters. Both Aidala and Agnifilo are well-known New York defense attorneys, but their litigation styles differ. Aidala is folksy, while Agnifilo is more buttoned-up. (AP)

Türkiye: Gunman opens fire at high school, 16 injured



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Ankara

A former student opened fire at a high school in southeast Türkiye on Tuesday, wounding at least 16 people before killing himself, an official said.

The 18-year-old attacker, armed with a shotgun, fired randomly at a vocational high school in Siverek, Sanliurfa province, before hiding inside the building. He later killed himself with the same shotgun, Gov Hasan Sildak said.

The attack left 10 students, four teachers, a canteen employee and a police officer wounded, Sildak said. While most of them were being treated in Siverek, five of the wounded teachers and students were transferred to a hospital in the provincial capital because their conditions were more serious, the governor said. The motive for the attack remains unclear. School shootings are rare in Turkey. Earlier, media reports said all students were evacuated and police special operations units were deployed after the assailant refused to surrender.

Policy to improve relations with India remains unchanged: China

KJM VARMA
■ Beijing

China on Tuesday said its policy to improve relations with India has not changed as it defended its move to publish new names for various regions in Arunachal Pradesh.

India on Sunday categorically rejected China's efforts to assign "fictitious names" to Indian territory, asserting that such attempts to create "baseless narratives" cannot alter "undeniable reality" and could derail efforts to normalise bilateral ties.

New Delhi's sharp reaction came against the backdrop of Beijing establishing a third new administrative county in Aksai Chin, a



Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun

region India maintains as its sovereign territory.

"India categorically rejects any mischievous attempts by the Chinese side to assign fictitious names to places which form part of the territory of India," External Affairs Ministry spokesper-

son Randhir Jaiswal said.

Reacting to Jaiswal's remarks, Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun told a media briefing here that Zangnan is China's territory, and China has never recognised the "so-called Arunachal Pradesh".

Zangnan is the Chinese name for Arunachal Pradesh. China claims Arunachal Pradesh as part of southern Tibet.

It is entirely within China's sovereignty to standardise the names of some places in the Zangnan region, Guo said, defending Beijing's move to publish six batches of names for Arunachal Pradesh. He said at present, China-India relations are generally stable. China's policy committed to improving and developing China-India relations remains unchanged, Guo said.

"We hope the two sides will work in the same direction and act more in ways conducive to bilateral relations," Guo added. On March

26, China's Xinjiang Uyghur Autonomous Region announced the creation of Cenling county, a strategic region located near the Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) and Afghanistan.

It is also reportedly close to the western sector of the Line of Actual Control (LAC) with India.

Cenling, located near the Karakoram mountain range, is the third new county established by China in Xinjiang, a predominantly Muslim Uyghur region.

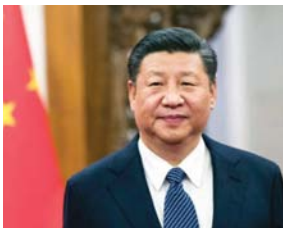
India last year lodged a protest with China over the creation of Hean and Hekang counties, stating that parts of their jurisdiction fall within its Union territory of Ladakh. (PTI)

Xi, Sanchez say, China and Spain should help safeguard multilateralism

E EDUARDO CASTILLO
■ Beijing

The leaders of China and Spain on Tuesday pledged to strengthen their relations and work to safeguard multilateralism at a time when the world is being impacted by various conflicts, including the recent war in Iran, during a meeting in Beijing on Tuesday.

"We should strengthen communication, consolidate mutual trust, cooperate closely, oppose the world's retrogression to the law of the jungle, and jointly safeguard genuine multilateralism," said Chinese President Xi Jinping during a



reception for Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez at the Great Hall of the People.

Sanchez agreed and said both countries "can contribute to finding solutions to the various trade tensions that exist, to the geopolitical difficulties and complexities of today's world, to the wars, to the environmental and social

challenges that afflict the world."

Sanchez is in China for his fourth trip in just over three years to the world's second-largest economy.

Spain is looking to strengthen its political and commercial ties with Beijing, and the visit comes as Sanchez faces a strained relationship with the U.S. over his opposition to the war in Iran.

Sanchez sees China as key to end the war. Later, during a press conference, Sanchez said that China was the only global player he could see helping end wars in Iran and other places, such as Ukraine. (AP)

5.7 earthquake jolts rural Nevada near Carson city

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

A magnitude 5.7 earthquake struck a rural part of Nevada east of the state's capital of Carson City on Monday.

The tremor hit just before 6.30 p.m., the US Geological Survey said. It was centred 20.7 kilometres east of the town of Silver Springs at a depth of 5 kilometres.

Video shot in the town of Fallon showed shattered glass and food scattered on the floor in the aisles of a grocery store.

Trina Enloe was sitting with one of her daughters



as she did homework in their dining room when the quake hit.

"You could hear the rumbling just coming before it even got to us," Enloe said.

The shaking continued for about a minute, she said. The jolt knocked over some cast iron candle holders but Enloe didn't see any cracks or damage in her home in Fallon.

Romuald Wadagni secures Benin presidency

VIRGILE AHISSOU
■ Cotonou (Benin)

Benin Finance Minister Romuald Wadagni won the country's presidential election held on Sunday with over 94 per cent of votes, according to election officials, fulfilling the expectation he was the anointed successor after President Patrice Talon's decade in power.

The outcome was based on more than 90 per cent of votes counted with voter turnout of 58.75 per cent, Sacca Lafia, head of the West African country's independent electoral commission, announced on national television late Monday. The final results must be confirmed by Benin's constitutional court and are expected in the coming weeks.

Paul Hounkpe, the sole opposition candidate who received 5.95 per cent of votes, conceded defeat ahead of the announcement Monday. Wadagni, 49, was considered the chosen heir to Talon, who is stepping down at the end



Romuald Wadagni

of May after serving in office from 2016 to 2026. Analysts had predicted a sidelined opposition would result in Wadagni's win.

Talon leaves a mixed legacy of economic growth, a growing jihadi insurgency in the north and the suppression of opposition critics. While Benin has historically been among the most stable democracies in Africa, opposition leaders and human rights organisations

have accused Talon of using the justice system as a tool to sideline political opponents.

Amnesty International and Human Rights Watch denounced a sustained crackdown on dissent under Talon, citing arbitrary detentions, tighter restrictions on public demonstrations and mounting pressure on independent media outlets.

In a parliamentary election in January, the opposition failed to cross the threshold of support from 20 per cent of registered voters in each of the country's voting districts before standing for election, leaving Talon's two allied parties with control of all 109 seats in the National Assembly.

Renaud Agbodjo, leader of The Democrats, the main opposition party, was barred from competing in Sunday's vote after failing to secure enough parliamentary endorsements, which critics say is a threshold engineered to keep out rivals. (AP)

US forces to join drills in Philippines

JIM GOMEZ ■ MANILA

More than 17,000 American and Filipino military personnel will participate in one of their largest annual combat exercises in the Philippines that underscore the United States' staunch commitment to Asia despite its preoccupation with the Middle East, a US military official said Tuesday.

During the April 20-May 8 manoeuvres, called the Balikatan, Japanese forces will fire a missile in a ship-sinking exercise in north-western Philippine waters facing the disputed South China Sea. Japan's defence chief has been invited to witness the live-fire drill, Philippine military officials said. The large-scale



combat drills between the US and Philippines, which are longtime treaty allies, will expand this year to include other friendly forces, including those from Japan, France and Canada, which have signed visiting forces agreements with Manila, the Philippine military said.

"Our message is our dedication and commitment to our alliance and region-

al security," Col. Robert Bunn, a spokesperson for US forces, said in a news briefing when asked what message the US military wanted to send with its large Balikatan deployment despite the war in the West Asia.

Bunn did not immediately specify the number of US forces joining the combat drills.

Last year, about 9,000 US military personnel joined the Balikatan – Tagalog for shoulder – to shoulder – exercises.

"The defensive aspect of countering drones is very much a part of the exercise," Bunn said in response to a question on the types of mock combat operations to be expected. (AP)

PAKISTAN GOVT AMENDS HINDU MARRIAGE ACT TO SIMPLIFY REGISTRATION



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Peshawar

Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa provincial Government has amended the Hindu Marriage Act 2017 to simplify and streamline the process of registering Hindu marriages at the local level, an official said.

According to the official, under the newly enacted Hindu Marriage (Amendment) Act 2026, members of the Hindu community will now be allowed to appoint marriage registrars at the district level to facilitate the formal registration of marriages.

The amended law introduces changes in Clause 2 of Section 1, including the revision of the nomenclature of "Marriage Registrar", who will now be appointed under Section 7 of the act.

The amendment also provides that one or more registrars may be appointed in each district. The official said the key objective of the amendment was to empower local Governments to issue licenses for Hindu marriage registration, making the process more efficient, accessible, and organised.

Afghan migrants in Poland fear deportations as asylum applications remain suspended

CLAUDIA CIOBANU
■ Warsaw

Afghan migrants in Poland face forced deportations and fear for their lives at the hands of the Taliban-run Government back home, concerns that rights groups say have soared after Poland last year moved to partially suspend the right to seek asylum.

Rights groups warn that the measure, introduced in March 2025, is now being overused by authorities.

It's based on an amended Polish law that imposed temporary restrictions on the right to apply for international protection at the border with Belarus for those who

crossed into the NATO and European Union member state illegally.

"I tried more than a billion times to seek safety," an Afghan in his 20s, currently in a detention centre for migrants in eastern Poland, said over the phone. He recounted how the Taliban killed his father and also detained and beat him up.

The rest of his family is still in hiding in Afghanistan, he said, speaking to The Associated Press on condition of anonymity because he fears for his safety, should he be deported to Afghanistan.

All this he recounted to Polish authorities, he said, "but they did not care." The Polish Interior Ministry did



not respond to AP requests for comment about the deportations of Afghans and how it applies the new restriction. Like many of his countrymen, the young Afghan crossed into EU-member Poland from

Belarus and managed to reach Germany, where he was arrested and then returned to Poland to have his asylum request assessed under EU laws.

He now says Polish authorities decided to deport him

without properly reviewing his case, simply because he had first entered the country by way of Belarus – a fraught route that Warsaw has sought to crack down on after tens of thousands of migrants tried to enter the EU that way in recent years.

Poland says it's been overwhelmed by the influx and argues that the migrants were sent by Russia and its ally Belarus to destabilise Poland and other Western countries.

The temporary suspension – for a total of 60 days – of the right to seek asylum only applies "on the border with Belarus," the new legislation says. The Government has prolonged this time period multiple times, effectively sus-

pending asylum applications for over a year and more.

Legal experts such as the Polish Ombudsman, which protects civil and human rights in Poland, and the UNHCR have criticised Poland's suspension of the right to asylum.

They say it's incompatible with international law and especially the Geneva Conventions on refugee rights, which obliges receiving countries to examine each individual's claim for protection.

Poland's liberal Prime Minister Donald Tusk has said the security risks at the Belarus border warranted the new measures, an argument the EU did not reject,

though its member states are required to provide at least a minimum of rights to asylum-seekers even in cases of orchestrated migration crises.

Since the new law was introduced, rights groups and migrants say Poland has been stretching the measure to include not just migrants apprehended on the Belarus-Poland border but those found anywhere in the country, as long as they entered across that border.

In practice, this means that Afghan migrants, whose route to Poland almost always involves Belarus, cannot apply for asylum, regardless of their individual circumstances. (AP)

PROSPECT

Dr Kartik Sahni selected as Assistant Professor in GI surgery department

Dr Kartik Sahni has been selected for the post of Assistant Professor in the Department of Gastrointestinal (GI) Surgery at the Rajiv Gandhi Super Speciality Hospital under the Delhi Government. According to the official results released by the institution, he secured the top position in the selection process conducted for this post.

Dr Sahni is a resident of Singh Sabha Road in Shakti Nagar, North Delhi. He completed his initial medical education from Maulana Azad Medical College. He obtained his MBBS degree in 2018 from University of Delhi and later completed his MS in General Surgery from the same university in 2021. He further pursued super-speciality training at All India Institute of Medical Sciences, where he earned his MCh (Surgical Gastroenterology) degree in 2025. Dr Sahni's father, Inder Raj Sahni, expressed that this achievement is a matter of great pride for the family and a result of years of hard work. His mother, Seema Sahni, added that his interest in studies and the medical field was evident since childhood, which he consistently nurtured through dedication and perseverance.

Assam Rifles seizes codeine cough syrup worth ₹40 lakh in Agartala



In a continued effort to curb illegal narcotics trafficking, Assam Rifles, in coordination with Customs officials, successfully recovered a large consignment of banned cough syrup in Tripura.

Based on specific intelligence inputs, a joint operation was launched by Assam Rifles and Customs Department, Agartala in the general area of Taranagar, approximately 20 km North-East of Agartala on 13 April 2026.

During the operation, the team recovered 140 cases of Codeine-based cough syrup, suspected to be intended for illegal distribution. The total value of the seized consignment is estimated to be approximately ₹40 lakh.

The recovered items have been handed over to the Customs Department, Agartala for further legal proceedings. Assam Rifles remains steadfast in its commitment to combating drug trafficking and ensuring a drug-free society in the region.

NCLT orders insolvency proceedings against Dhoot

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) has directed initiation of insolvency proceedings against Videocon's former chairman and MD Venugopal Dhoot for defaulting on loans of ₹6,157.57 crore, as a personal guarantor of two group companies. Admitting a plea from State Bank of India (SBI), NCLT said Venugopal Dhoot has "committed defaults in repayment of loan amount" granted by the financial creditor.

"Venugopal Nandlal Dhoot, personal guarantor to Videocon Industries Ltd and Videocon Telecommunications Ltd has also committed default in repayment of the loan facility demanded by the financial creditor after invocation of the personal guarantee," said an order passed by NCLT on April 8, uploaded on April 13 evening.

The Mumbai bench of the insolvency tribunal has also appointed Ashish Narayan as a resolution professional and directed him to issue a public notice within seven days of passing this order on the website of the NCLT.



Videocon's former chairman and MD Venugopal Dhoot

"The Resolution Professional shall submit the repayment plan along with his report on the plan to this authority within a period of 21 days from the last date of submission of claims, as provided under Section 106," said NCLT.

Under Section 95 of the Insolvency & Bankruptcy Code (IBC), insolvency proceedings are initiated against a person, after being "satisfied that Corporate Debtor (Videocon) has committed default in repayment of loan amount granted by the financial creditor and personal guarantors have committed default in repayment of the loan facility".

Two other Dhoot brothers - Rajkumar Nandlal Dhoot and Pradeep Nandlal Dhoot - are already facing insolvency proceedings after they failed to pay a demand notice of ₹5,353.78 crore over defaults by Videocon Industries, the principal borrower, for which they were the personal guarantors.

Both had appealed the NCLT order passed in June last year before the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT), which had declined to stay it.

Two group entities - Videocon Telecommunications Ltd (VTL) and Videocon Industries Ltd (VIL) - had entered into Rupee Term Loan Agreement, Rupee Facility Agreement, among



others for which Dhoot had guaranteed due repayment through several deeds of guarantees. Both the group companies defaulted in repayment of the loan facilities, following which SBI moved NCLT, which in June 2018 directed the initiation of insolvency proceedings against VIL and VTL.

Later, NCLT on August 8, 2019 decided to consolidate the corporate insolvency resolution process of VIL with 12 other Videocon group companies VTL, Electroworld, Value, Techno Kart, Applicomp, Sky, Techno, Millennium, Century, Evans Fraser, PE and CE India, which is still pending before it.

Later a demand notice was also issued to the personal

guarantor under the provisions of the IBC. As Dhoot failed to pay the default amount within 14 days of receipt of the IBC Demand Notice, SBI filed a plea for personal insolvency against Venugopal Dhoot.

Dhoot had contended that no reliance should be placed on report of the RP since the Deed of Guarantee was entered between him and SBICAP Trustee Company, whereas the present application has been filed by State Bank of India.

He also contended that debt claimed by them is barred by law of limitation as the present application was filed on September 1, 2020, whereas the first cause of action to invoke the Personal

Guarantee arose on the first date of default by the principal borrower on May 1, 2016 and not from being NPA from non-payment of interest in January 2017.

Rejecting it, NCLT said the period of limitation for initiating proceedings against a Personal Guarantor commences from the date of default in discharge of the guarantee obligation, and not from the date of default by the Principal Borrower.

"Accordingly, the present petition has been filed well within the prescribed period of limitation," it said while allowing the plea moved by SBI.

Over SBICAP, NCLT said it was acting "onshore security trustee" on behalf of the lenders, one of whom is SBI.

"Considering the above facts and circumstances and upon perusal of the documents on record viz. the demand notices, proof of service, guarantee deeds, joint deed of guarantee, etc., filed under Section 95 of the IBC, 2016 is hereby admitted and the Insolvency Resolution Process stands initiated against Venugopal Nandlal Dhoot," said the April 8 NCLT order.

TCS case: Telangana Police engages with firms to ensure workplace safety

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

In the wake of an alleged sexual harassment and religious conversion case in Tata Consultancy Service (TCS) Nashik unit, Telangana DGP B Shivadhar Reddy has said the state police actively engages with companies to ensure a safe environment at workplaces. Responding to a suggestion from Union Minister Bandi Sanjay Kumar to convene an immediate meeting with heads of major IT companies, especially HR teams, following the Nashik IT firm sexual harassment case, Reddy said through initiatives like the Society for Cyberabad Security Council (SCSC)-a unique Police-Industry partnership- the Telangana Police works with organisations, HR teams and communities to strengthen workplace safety and accountability.

Proactive measures such as security and safety audits of working women's hostels and PG accommodations, free 'She Shuttle' (bus) services, and 'SHE Teams', ensure con-



tinuous support, especially for women professionals, he said.

The Telangana DGP in a post on 'X' on Monday said, "The concerns raised by Honourable MoS, Home Shri @bandisanjay_bjp are noted. However, it is clarified that the Telangana Police remains firmly committed to ensuring a safe, inclusive & harassment-free environment for every citizen. We believe in coexistence with harmony, dignity & mutual respect."

Ministry notifies amendment to streamline fee for overloaded vehicles

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Road Transport Ministry has revised the fee structure for the overloading of trucks, under which vehicles found carrying excess load on national highways will be charged based on the percentage of overloading. The Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH) on Tuesday said it has notified the National Highways Fee (Determination of Rates and Collection) Fourth Amendment Rules, 2026, aimed at strengthening enforcement and ensuring rationalised fee collection for overloaded vehicles on National Highways.

The amended rules will be effective from April 15, 2026. According to the notification, a revised framework has been introduced under Rule 10 for the levy of fees on vehicles carrying



loads beyond the permissible Gross Vehicle Weight (GVW).

The amendment seeks to promote compliance with prescribed load limits and enhance road safety while protecting highway infrastructure. According to the ministry, no overboard fee will be charged for up to 10 per cent of excess load.

"Over 10 per cent and up to 40 per cent excess load, fee charged at 2 times the base rate," it said, adding

that above 40 per cent, the fee is charged at 4 times the base rate.

The ministry said overloading will be determined using certified weight measurement devices installed at the fee plaza. "In cases where weight facilities are not available at fee plazas, no overload fee shall be levied," it added.

According to the ministry, overloading fees will be collected through FASTag only.

DAILY SUDOKU

		9		4		6		2
7					8			9
		8	3				1	7
1				7				
	3						9	
				8				1
8	1				5	2		
2			8					6
5		3		6		9		

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

SOLUTION (14.04.26)								
8	4	6	5	9	2	1	3	7
1	9	7	6	8	3	5	2	4
5	2	3	7	4	1	8	9	6
2	8	5	4	1	9	7	6	3
4	3	9	8	6	7	2	1	5
6	7	1	3	2	5	9	4	8
9	6	8	2	5	4	3	7	1
3	1	4	9	7	8	6	5	2
7	5	2	1	3	6	4	8	9

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
WEDNESDAY | APRIL 15, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6	7
8	9			10		
	11		12			
13		14		15	16	17
		18		19		
20		21				
22				23		
		24		25		
26	27	28		29		30
31				32		33
		34			35	
36					37	
		38				

ACROSS

3 It's seed, but a songbird has an ear for it! (5)

8 Gong that could give you a dizzy head during dinner? (5)

10 Draws the line at Australian football (5)

11 Garment that takes a bit of machining (3)

12 New angle, we gather (5)

13 The overgrown boy continues to be resented (7)

15 Depend on keeping a brave heart in a race (5)

18 Recite, let's suppose (3)

19 Airmen crashed in the sea (6)

21 Best position to make a dramatic observation? (3,4)

22 Having a relationship in the making (4)

DOWN

1 One of the many macho males (2-3)

2 In general, knaves get ahead! (7)

4 The painter possesses about a pound (4)

5 To an artist, simply desert; but actually it's a mountain (6)

6 Sounds fishy, bit it's a hi-fi component (5)

7 An American saloon (5)

9 Chap with a black belt (3)

12 They can help get people into hot water (7)

14 Being slack, is said to be one of the "have nots" (3)

16 Survived upsetting the devil (5)

17 Long to get the bit of money you deserve (5)

23 What a scorcher will do at a tourist centre by the sea (4)

24 Bored by all the square-bashing? (7)

26 Not the only one given short change out East (6)

29 The mien of an absolutely topping redhead (3)

31 Measure used by the tiler? (5)

32 The debacle when a couple separate (5-2)

34 To be invited, apply to the Editor (5)

35 A guy can get attached to her (3)

36 It involves kings and queens in a witches' sabbath (5)

37 Modestly having a fling at the ultimate Aunt Sally (5)

38 Regarding a bit of monkeying (5)

19 Flier making a drama out of fifty quid? (7)

20 Alias Coral? (5)

21 Coastal feature of great height, it would seem! (5)

23 Angelic phrases, possibly (7)

24 Elegant, like a frock (6)

25 Is it among the sillier attempts at deception? (3)

27 A taxing part (5)

28 Remove those pointed ears, possibly? (3)

30 Instrument a bighead stuck together with glue (5)

32 A runner can be one (4)

33 One of the bunch has a bit of a black eye! (3)

Culinary Delight: The Inspiring Journey of Chef Pradeep Biswal



The culinary journey of Chef Pradeep Biswal, aptly titled "Culinary Delight," is a story defined by passion, perseverance, and an unwavering commitment to excellence.

Chef Biswal's journey began in 2008 when he enrolled at PTU Ghaziabad's Institute of Hospitality and Tourism Management (IHTM), overcoming numerous personal and professional challenges to pursue his dream. During his formative years, he diligently honed his skills, laying a strong foundation in the culinary arts.

He went on to gain invaluable experience working with renowned, old-world hospitality groups, as well as a diverse range of restaurants and hotels. His career saw a significant leap when he worked with prestigious establishments such as Hotel Broadway, Indian Accent, Habitat World, and Epicentre.

During this time, he had the opportunity to collaborate with celebrated chefs including Manish Mehrotra and Rajiv Malhotra, further refining his craft.

Chef Biswal's talent was notably recognized during his tenure at Chor Bizarre Restaurant, where he served as a Kitchen Executive. In this role, he not only supervised kitchen operations but also continued to evolve his culinary identity.

His journey then took an international turn as he moved to the United States to join Feringhee - Modern Indian Cuisine in Arizona. Here, Chef Biswal began developing his own distinctive style, creating innovative interpretations of modern Indian cuisine.

Driven by a desire to learn and push boundaries, he collaborated with acclaimed chefs such as Sujan Sarkar and Karan Mittal, experimenting with new techniques and contemporary expressions of Indian flavors. His culinary exploration further expanded across global kitchens, where he continued to innovate and refine his approach.

Today, Chef Pradeep Biswal is based in New York as the Head Chef of Ambassadors Clubhouse Restaurant, where he is actively experimenting with new flavors, ingredients, and techniques. His work reflects a seamless blend of tradition and modernity, showcasing his deep respect for Indian culinary heritage while embracing global influences. Chef Pradeep developed recipes with Michelin starred chef Shantil Bhushan at Ambassadors Clubhouse London.

Chef Biswal's journey is a testament to resilience and dedication. Despite early challenges, he persevered, continuously learning from some of the finest minds in the industry. His story serves as an inspiration to aspiring chefs around the world.

With his innovative approach to Indian cuisine and a remarkable ability to craft unique, memorable dishes, Chef Pradeep Biswal continues to win admirers globally solidifying his place as a rising force in the culinary world. His cuisine has already made Ambassadors Clubhouse as one of the top-rated restaurants in New York City.

No broadcaster for FIFA World Cup in India – A bad sign for football?



SHAKYA MITRA

With just under two months to go before one of the year's biggest global events, the FIFA World Cup, there is still no confirmed broadcaster in India. For a country that has steadily grown into one of the largest sports consumption markets in the world, India currently stands out as the only major territory yet to secure a television or digital partner for football's biggest global spectacle. The situation is particularly striking when viewed through a historical lens. The World Cup first appeared on Indian television screens in 1982, albeit limited to the semifinals and final, before being broadcast in full from the 1986 edition onwards.

At the heart of the issue lies the economics of broadcasting rights. FIFA's initial asking price for the combined India rights for the 2026 and 2030 editions reportedly stood at \$100 million. However, in response to lukewarm interest, the figure was sharply revised downward to around \$35 million. Even at this reduced valuation, no broad-

caster has stepped forward. In contrast, just for a single Indian Premier League match, the broadcast rights were sold for \$13 million in the 2023-27 cycle.

A major factor dampening enthusiasm is the timing of matches. With the 2026 tournament set to be hosted across North America, time zone differences pose a significant challenge for Indian audiences. The majority of the early matches are expected to begin between 11.30 pm and 12.30 am IST, while many games will commence deep into the night. Some fixtures will even kick off in the early morning hours, between 6.30 am and 9.30 am. Late-night broadcasts traditionally attract lower advertising rates, and brands may hesitate to invest heavily in slots that do not guarantee mass viewership.

The ripple effects extend beyond just television ratings. Major global tournaments like the FIFA World Cup typically energise a parallel economy; restaurants, bars, fan parks, and community screenings thrive during such events. However, with matches scheduled at inconvenient hours, this ecosystem was, in any case, at a natural disadvantage. Additionally, broadcasters may find it difficult to justify elaborate



studio programming, a key component of sports coverage, given the limited audience engagement expected during odd hours.

Concerns over the timing of matches may not be a phenomenon restricted to international football, a sport with limited global participation by Indians. Even the most popular sport, cricket, had a lukewarm response during the 2007 Cricket World Cup

held in the West Indies, with matches concluding well into the late-night and early-morning hours. India's early exit from the group stage after playing only three games further compounded the problem, leading to a sharp decline in viewership for the rest of the tournament. India has never played the FIFA World Cup, meaning that global stars and traditional footballing nations largely

drive viewership. Over the years, the World Cup has nonetheless built a loyal following in India, cutting across regions and demographics. However, the expanded format of the 2026 edition, with an increase from 32 to 48 teams and 40 extra matches, introduces new complexities. While greater inclusivity is a positive step globally, it may dilute the overall competitiveness of early-stage fixtures,

especially those involving less prominent teams. Combined with inconvenient timings, this could make it harder to sustain viewer interest throughout the tournament, even if matches by the round of 16 onwards can get exciting.

The broader football broadcasting ecosystem in India also paints a concerning picture. Domestic television coverage of major European leagues has declined.

Competitions like the English Premier League and the Bundesliga are shown live, while leagues such as La Liga and Serie A currently lack television broadcasters in the country. This trend suggests a cooling of commercial interest in football properties, even as digital consumption continues to grow. Yet, it would be premature to interpret the current situation as a definitive decline of football in India. The World Cup occupies a unique position in the global sporting calendar. It transcends club loyalties and regional preferences, drawing in casual viewers who may not follow the sport regularly. Importantly, the tournament will take place in June (and run into July), a period when schools and colleges across India are typically on vacation. This timing has historically allowed younger audiences to engage deeply with the World Cup, often shaping lifelong sporting interests. For many fans, their earliest memories of football are tied to late-night World Cup screenings during summer holidays.

There may be a glimmer of hope in that the Government of India has recognised the FIFA World Cup as an event of national importance, with the opening game, semifinals, and final to be broadcast

on the national broadcaster Doordarshan. Before the 2002 World Cup, the first ever shown on satellite television, the World Cup was broadcast on Doordarshan in India.

Despite the current uncertainty, there remains cautious optimism. Historically, high-profile sporting events in India have often found broadcast partners closer to their start dates, once commercial terms become more favourable. The same could happen with the 2026 World Cup. Whether through television, digital streaming, or a combination of both, it is hoped that a solution will emerge before the tournament begins.

However, if no broadcaster ultimately steps forward, it would represent a significant setback for football fans in India. The absence of the World Cup from mainstream platforms would not only limit access but also risk eroding the sport's hard-earned gains in popularity. For a generation that grew up watching the drama of the World Cup unfold every four years, such a scenario would be deeply disappointing.

Shakya Mitra is a sports management consultant with over a decade of experience in sports promotion and development. His work across both the private and government sectors gives him a well-rounded view of India's sports ecosystem.

BRIEFLY

Ghana seeks Carlos Queiroz as coach weeks from World Cup

World Cup-bound Ghana appointed Carlos Queiroz as the new men's national coach, less than two months out from the tournament. "Coach Queiroz begins work immediately," the Ghana Football Association said in a statement. Ghana opens its World Cup campaign in Group L against Panama on June 17 in Toronto, then faces England outside Boston and Croatia in Philadelphia. The Black Stars also have warmups against Mexico on May 22 and Wales on June 2. "This is not just another job – it is a mission," Queiroz said in a statement on the GFA website. "And I am ready to give everything of my experience and knowledge once again, in service of the game and the happiness of People." Queiroz was chosen from more than 600 local and foreign applications because of his extensive World Cup experience. He qualified South Africa for the 2002 World Cup, guided his native Portugal to the knockout phase in 2010, and coached Iran at the 2014 and 2018 tournaments. Queiroz was most recently in charge of Oman, which failed to qualify for the World Cup. He stepped down three weeks ago. He's replaced Otto Addo, who was fired on March 31 after four straight losses in warmup games.



Levante rises off bottom of La Liga points table



Carlos Espi scored his seventh goal in six games as Levante beat Getafe 1-0 and moved off the bottom of La Liga. The 20-year-old Espi had an early let off after eight minutes when the referee downgraded a red card to a yellow and he was decisive with eight minutes left when he stooped to head home the only goal. Levante should have wrapped up the points more easily but Getafe goalkeeper David Soria saved two penalties, one from Adrian Dela after an hour and then again from Ivan Romero in stoppage time. To make matters worse for Getafe, Zaid Romero was sent off in the dying seconds. The result lifted Levante off the bottom of the table and continued a recent revival that has seen Levante take 11 points from a possible last 18. It was two points ahead of Oviedo. Elche was third to last. The bottom three go down.

Fiorentina beats Lazio to allay relegation fears



Fiorentina beat Lazio 1-0 and moved eight points clear of the Serie A relegation zone. Fiorentina's season-best five-game unbeaten run lifted Paolo Vanoli's men above Cagliari into 15th place. Robin Gosens got the only goal in the 28th minute when he headed home a cross from Jack Harrison, the winger on loan from Leeds United. Lazio lost for the first time since March 1. Lazio dominated the match, particularly in the first half. It remained in ninth place.

Iranian club to play Asian Champions League last-16 match in Saudi Arabia

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Jeddah

Iranian club Tractor has arrived in Saudi Arabia amid the war in the Middle East and confirmed it will play in the AFC Champions League Elite round of 16.

The West Asia playoffs were postponed in March after the United States and Israel launched a war against Iran. After the round of 16 was rescheduled and Iran's game against Shabab Al-Ahli of the United Arab Emirates moved to the Saudi city of Jeddah, questions lingered over whether Tractor – the 2025 Iranian league champion – would take part.

Iran has fired missiles into Saudi Arabia, a US ally.

Tractor arrived in Jeddah on Sunday after a long journey; traveling by land from its home city of Tabriz in northwestern Iran into Turkey and then flying from



Istanbul. "Our situation going into this match is complicated, and the 90 minutes against Shabab Al-Ahli will be difficult for us," Tractor coach Mohammad Rabiei said in a press conference on Monday, a day before the match. The team has not played a competitive game since Feb. 28 as the Iranian league has been suspended. "We have high ambitions

to win our upcoming matches and reach the Asian final," Rabiei added. "Starting tomorrow everyone will see the high level we possess, despite the major challenges we have faced recently."

On Monday, Karim Benzema missed a penalty in a shootout as Saudi Arabia's Al-Hilal lost to Qatar's Al-Sadd 4-2 after their round-of-16 match ended 3-3 after extra

time. Sergej Milinkovic-Savic opened the scoring for Al-Hilal, a four-time champion, in the first half but Brazilian forward Claudinho equalized seven minutes later. Shortly after halftime, Salem Al-Dawsari put Al-Hilal back in front, only for Rafa Mujica to level again.

Marcos Leonardo restored the lead in the 67th minute, and three minutes later former Liverpool forward Roberto Firmino made it 3-3 to send the game into extra time and then penalties.

Elsewhere, Riyad Mahrez scored after 117 minutes to give defending champion Al-Ahli of Saudi Arabia a 1-0 win over Al-Duhail of Qatar. Earlier in extra time, England striker Ivan Toney missed a penalty for Al-Ahli.

Jeddah will stage the rest of the tournament. The quarterfinals begin on Thursday and the final is scheduled for April 25.

LIVERPOOL TARGETS COMEBACK AGAINST PSG



JAMES ROBSONAP
■ Liverpool

Liverpool is aiming for another famous Champions League comeback against Paris Saint-Germain on Tuesday. The six-time European champion trails 2-0 after the first leg of the quarterfinal in Paris. But it is hoping for the type of Anfield night that saw it rout Barcelona 4-0 in the semifinals in 2019 to overturn a 3-0 first leg loss.

"There is a belief that we can do special things... but we need to be very, very special," coach Arne Slot said ahead of the match. "We know we need an exceptional performance to go through to the next round." Defending champion PSG totally dominated the first leg last week and could have ran up a more commanding lead if it had taken its chances.

Coach Luis Enrique warned his team about the potential to slip up with the semifinals within touching distance. "You need to be very careful, there could be pitfalls and it could be a trap," he said. "Everyone says, You won (the first leg) easily and you were much better than (the) opposition." (AP)

Barcelona desperate to return to Champions League semis

TALES AZZONIAP
■ Madrid

Barcelona and Atletico Madrid meet for the fifth time in less than two months on Tuesday, with the Catalan club needing to overcome a two-goal disadvantage to return to the Champions League semifinals.

Atletico is at home to defend its 2-0 win from the first leg and try to make it to the last four of the European competition for the first time in nearly a decade.

Before last week's first leg, Barcelona beat Atletico 2-1 in Madrid in a Spanish league game on April 4. The teams had already met twice in the Copa del Rey semifinals, when Atletico



won 4-0 at home and then advanced to the final despite a 3-0 loss in Barcelona in the second leg.

Atletico last made it to the semifinals in 2017. Barcelona lost to Inter Milan in last year's last four.

Coach Diego Simeone has not ruled out Jan Oblak's return even though the goalkeeper hasn't played since March 10 because of a muscle injury. He has been practicing with the squad for the last few days and is expected to be fit to play.

Barcelona coach Hansi Flick has not ruled out midfielder Frenkie de Jong making his first start after a long absence because of a hamstring injury.

Whichever team advances on Tuesday will face Arsenal or Sporting Lisbon in the semifinals. Arsenal won the first leg 1-0 in Lisbon last week. Their second leg in England is on Wednesday. (AP)

In Miami, soccer balls are turned into one-of-a-kind art

TIM REYNOLDSAP ■ Miami

Lili Cantero thinks of soccer as family.

The artist from Paraguay – someone who has built a devoted following in the soccer world, with her work admired by Argentina captain and Inter Miami star Lionel Messi, among others – still has fond childhood memories of gathering with relatives around a radio to listen to matches almost every weekend.

"That's where my love for the game began," Cantero said. "For me, soccer, futbol, is being with family and being with friends. The game is not just a game. It's a culture. It's love. It is family.

It is friendship."

And now, it is her work.

Leading up to the start of the World Cup in June, Cantero will be putting her specialty – painted soccer balls – in 10 different businesses in the Miami neighborhood known as Wynwood, a place known for having turned warehouses into art galleries and where just about anything can be turned into a mural. It is the heartbeat of the Miami art community, and for Cantero, the marriage of her work and soccer seemed a perfect fit.

"I think it's the perfect combination in the perfect moment with the perfect people," said Cantero, who has called Miami home for



about 2 1/2 years. "Messi coming in this city was ... an interesting way to grow this sport here in this city and in this country. Because many kids, they look at him with so many aspirations and dreams and everything, so

think they can make a decision to play this sport and also to grow in this sport. And I think that's beautiful."

Cantero's approach is simple: she believes soccer, like art, can bring people of different races, different

with which it is tied on points.

Leeds started on the front foot and almost scored in the second minute but Senne Lammers made an excellent point-blank save from Dominic Calvert-Lewin.

However, its pressure paid off two minutes later when Okafor side-footed home with style after everyone missed Jayden Bogle's deep cross from the right.

Leeds was all over United during the opening half hour and a second arrived in the 29th. A ball was half cleared to Okafor, whose first-time shot from outside the box took a slight deflection as it flew past Lammers and into the far corner. United interim

well," Carrick said. "We didn't quite have the rhythm or click. "I'm pleased the way we went about the second half but it was more difficult when you are a man down."

Farke, meanwhile, was ecstatic at taking all three points from one of Leeds' fiercest rivals at such a crucial juncture in a testing campaign. "A win is always good for the mood and the confidence. It is also good for the table," he said. "A few more points are needed but tonight we edge three points closer. Nothing is achieved yet. We have to stay humbled, grounded and hungry to make sure we get as many points as possible."



Diego Maradona and Pele both knew of her work. Same goes for former Brazil forward Ronaldinho, FIFA President Gianni Infantino and Messi's former Barcelona and Inter Miami teammate Jordi Alba, among many others. (AP)

Chennai Super Kings beat Kolkata Knight Riders by 32 runs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Chennai Super Kings beat Kolkata Knight Riders by 32 runs to record their second consecutive victory in the Indian Premier League here on Tuesday.

After putting on 192/5 on board, CSK restricted KKR to 160/7, with Noor Ahmad returning excellent figures of 4-0-21-3.

Rovman Powell (31 not out) and Ramandeep Singh (35) fought well with valiant knocks but could not avert a defeat despite a 63-run stand.

Sanju Samson (48) and Dewald Brevis (41) made useful contributions as Chennai Super Kings crossed 190. Ayush Mhatre hit six fours

and two sixes to make 38 off 17 balls.

Earlier in the game, Kolkata Knight Riders produced one of their best bowling performances, riding on the spin trio of Sunil Narine, Anukul Roy, and Varun Chakaravarthy, to restrict Chennai Super Kings to a manageable 192 for five in an IPL match here on Tuesday.

After Sanju Samson (48 off 32 balls) and Ayush Mhatre (38 off 17 balls) took the score to 72 for 2 at the end of the powerplay, off-spinner Narine (1/21 in 4 overs), slow left-arm Anukul (1/21 in 3 overs) and Varun (0/26 in 3 overs) gave only 68 runs in the 10 overs that they sent down cumulatively, while getting two wickets.

In the 14 overs post power-



play, CSK managed only 120 runs at less than nine runs per over, and it was all down to the KKR spinners.

At the back-end, Kartik Tyagi (2/35 in 4 overs) bowled fast, in the late 140s, and also mixed it with pace off deliveries out of batter's arc to make things difficult.

Dewald Brevis (41 off 29 balls) showed glimpses of his class while Sarfaraz Khan (23 off 18 balls) once again displayed his cheeky cricketing smarts in a half-century plus stand, but CSK were at least 20 runs short of a par score on this track.

At the start, Samson teed off with three boundaries, including a streaky one off Vaibhav Arora's in his opening over. However, it was U-19 World

Cup winning captain Mhatre, who upped the ante straight-away with back-to-back sixes off Cameron Green, apart from hitting a couple of boundaries.

The standstill would be a Kapil Dev-style 'Nataraja Shor' behind square. He also hit another open-chested six over mid-wicket. Mhatre's knock really gave the CSK innings the required momentum, even as Samson played the second fiddle during that phase.

While his innings could be termed far from being a smooth effort, he did show his touch with one straight six off Kartik Tyagi, who later came back with a fast 148.1 click-off-cutter to breach Samson's defence.

I had written this somewhere that I'd take 4-5 wickets on debut: Hinge

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

"I wrote it down somewhere that I could take four or five wickets on debut," said Sunrisers Hyderabad's Praful Hinge (4/34) after a historic outing against Rajasthan Royals in the IPL on Monday.

The Vidarbha pacer turned his manifestation into reality with a sensational three-wicket first over burst that effectively dismantled the table-toppers' chase of 217 before it even began.

Hinge ran through RR's in-form top order in a stunning opening spell of 2-0-6-4 which paved the way for SRH's massive win by 57 runs and first defeat in five matches for the visitors.

"I had written this somewhere that I will take 4-5 wickets on my debut. I thought of dominating the powerplay. I believe in it (manifestation)," Hinge told the broadcaster after the match.

"At the age of 13, I started cricket. Did not know what leather ball cricket was. Asked my father to join a club. But he said I was too young. Then he just took me there, and I kept playing after it. Want to dedicate this award to my family."

Hinge claimed he had told his teammates that he would dismiss RR's Vaibhav Sooryavanshi off a bouncer.

"I had told people that I would bowl a bouncer to him and get him out. I just



wanted to get him out. Varun bhai (our bowling coach) helped me plan it, so thank you," he said.

Hinge's four-for was

accompanied by a fine spell by another debutant pacer Sakib Hussain, who claimed 4/24.

"Every player hopes for a

debut like this, so it feels really good. I'm very happy. The (SRH) bowling coach informed me a day before the game that I would be playing. From then on, my focus was simply on performing well. Mentally, I prepared myself to give my best," Hussain said.

"Varun (Aaron) bhai has been working with me for the past four years. Whatever improvement you see in my bowling is because of him. I give him full credit. It felt amazing. To have such a performance in my debut match is very special," he added.

SRH skipper Ishan Kishan said it was crucial for his side to gauge the hunger in their uncapped fast bowlers

Hinge and Hussain.

"You also have to look how hungry your young bowlers are, how motivated they feel and you know how much they are hungry to play these games and I think they were working out throughout the season," he said.

"They were working with fielding, our bowling coach Varun Aaron and they were just trying to give their best, talking to all the experienced players. They especially did well in the practice matches as well, so I think this was the right move today," Kishan added.

Kishan said he found communicating with the bowlers difficult while keeping wickets.



COVID vaccines caused legend's death: Warne's son

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Sydney

Four years after Shane Warne's death left the cricketing world in shock, his son Jackson has asserted that the spin legend's demise was probably caused by the "three or four" COVID vaccines that he was "forced to take for work."

Speaking on '2 Worlds Collide' podcast, Jackson, however, also acknowledged that his father's underlying health issues. Warne was 52 when he died in Thailand in 2022 after suffering a heart attack.

"I definitely think that it (COVID vaccine) was involved. I don't even think saying that is controversial anymore. Even if dad had underlying health issues, I think this brought it out right to the surface and that's one thing that I've always struggled with," Jackson said.

"My first impression, as soon as I hung up the phone (after receiving the news of Warne's death), I instantly

blamed the government. I instantly blamed COVID and the vaccine."

Jackson said he barely managed to stop himself from vocalising his exact thoughts at the memorial service.

"It was probably smart I didn't, I would be in a very different position if I did. But that was how I felt," Jackson said.

"Yes, a lot of people were dying of heart attacks before. But dad was okay, I think he might have got three or four (vaccine doses), he didn't want to get them, he was forced to get them for work. He was forced to get them like everybody else," he asserted.

"...I try not to think about it too much because all that does is fester into anger. That anger is not good for anybody," he added.

Giving an insight into the lifestyle of his father, who was known to be indulgent, Jackson said it was relatively healthy despite the smoking and drinking.

T20 WC star Samson named ICC Men's Player of the Month for March

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dubai

India opener Sanju Samson was on Tuesday named ICC Men's Player of the Month for March, capping a stellar run that saw him play a defining role in the team's triumphant T20 World Cup campaign.

Samson did not get to play in the early part of the tournament but was the standout performer in the big games towards the end and helped India retain the title.

His latest honour also extends a unique streak, with players from different countries winning the award over the past five months including South Africa's Simon Harmer, Australia's Mitchell Starc, New Zealand's Daryl Mitchell and Pakistan's Sahibzada Farhan.

"Winning the ICC Player of the Month award is an incredible feeling, especially as it comes during what has been the most unforgettable phase of my cricketing journey. Playing a part in India's triumph at the Men's T20 World Cup was truly a dream realised, and it took some time for the magnitude of that moment to fully sink in," Samson said.

"This is an exciting era for Indian cricket, with immense talent across the board. I feel grateful for the opportunities I've received, and for the trust and support from my team-mates and coaching staff that has allowed me to perform at my best."



Not a regular part of the playing XI in the initial stages of the tournament, Samson was eventually called up for India's must-win Super 8 fixtures. After starting off with 24 against Zimbabwe, he picked form and didn't look back.

The opener missed out on a century against the West Indies by just three runs, but his attacking 97 not out set up India's spot in the semifinal.

A blistering 89 against England at the Wankhede helped India to 253 for 7, and the target proved elusive for the English who missed out by seven runs on March 5.

An equally amazing 89 was churned out during India's successful title defence in Ahmedabad, securing a 96-run win.

Indian cricketers dominate Wisden awards

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

Indian cricketers dominated the Wisden Almanack 2026 honours, securing seven of the nine awards, with Deepti Sharma and Abhishek Sharma leading the way after being named Women's Cricketer of the Year and T20 Cricketer of the Year respectively.

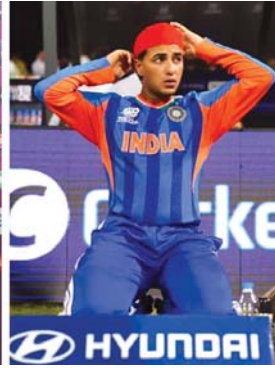
Shubman Gill, Mohammed Siraj, Rishabh Pant and Ravindra Jadeja were named among Wisden's Five Cricketers of the Year, following their exploits in last year's Test series in England.

The only non-Indian winners were premier Australian pacer Mitchell Starc, who was named Men's Cricketer in the



World, and England batter Haseeb Hameed, who was also included among the Five Cricketers of the Year.

Deepti earned the honour after emerging as the top-wicket taker in last year's ICC Women's ODI World Cup with 22 wickets.



The all-rounder's effort helped India land their maiden global title, beating South Africa in the final in Mumbai. She also made 215 runs from nine matches with three fifties.

Abhishek had a breakout 2025 season, scoring

859 runs from 21 matches at an awesome strike-rate of 193 with a hundred and five fifties.

India's Test skipper Gill was in prolific form during the English summer, scoring 754 runs, which played a crucial role in India securing a 2-2 draw in the five-match series. Notably, he amassed 430 runs in the Edgbaston Test alone.

Pacer Siraj was the top wicket-taker in the Anderson-Tendulkar Trophy series, taking 23 scalps. While Pant made 479 runs before an injury that he suffered in the fourth Test forced him to sit out of the fifth match. He braved a toe fracture to score a 54 in the second innings at Manchester.

Suryakumar Yadav's future could be discussed post UK T20Is

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ New Delhi

Suryakumar Yadav may have led India to an impressive T20 World Cup title defence but given his patchy batting form, serious questions remain on whether he will be in the scheme of things for the country's Los Angeles Olympics campaign in 2028.

And in this backdrop, India's tour of England and Ireland in June-July will be crucial for the skipper as more than his captaincy, his batting would be under scrutiny.

The tour could decide whether he will be given another two years till the next phase of big events in 2028 which includes the

Olympics and T20 World Cup in Australia.

Suryakumar still remains the first choice for head coach Gautam Gambhir, who is expecting a contract extension till the 2028 T20 World Cup in Australia.

However, it will be interesting to see whether the Ajit Agarkar-led selection committee agrees with his view as the T20 skipper will be pushing 38 at the time of Olympics.

"Obviously Surya is now leading the team. But he also has to ensure that as a batter, he maintains a level of consistency in his performances. Obviously, he will lead in the UK but after that, discussions going forward till 2028 could



be purely performance-based," a BCCI source told PTI on conditions of anonymity. Suryakumar had a torrid

2025 in which his strike rate dropped to less than 120 and he couldn't manage a single fifty.

Ben Stokes shuts down talk of a rift with Brendon McCullum

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

England captain Ben Stokes says any suggestion he and coach Brendon McCullum are not aligned "is a massive overstatement."

Were there disagreements between them during their Ashes debacle in Australia? Yes.

Was it any different than normal? No.

Stokes and McCullum have been in lock step since 2022 and they crashed and burned when they lost to Australia 4-1 last winter.

Both men supported the other after being humbled but the Ashes review threw up signs of tension.

Stokes wanted to play more conservatively while McCullum wanted to double down on all-out attack.

Since the Ashes, Stokes has kept a low profile. When he and McCullum kept their jobs last month following the Ashes review, he posted on social media that he was happy to continue working with McCullum and the post-Ashes period had been



the hardest period of his captaincy.

The captain has used an in-house interview with the England and Wales Cricket Board to address his relationship with McCullum.

"Saying we weren't aligned, I think, is a massive overstatement," Stokes said. "When you're in a position of leadership along with someone else, if anyone thinks that you're always going to agree on everything then it's just impossible."

"To me, that isn't a healthy

environment for sport, in particular. You need debate. You need discussions. Then you end up getting to the place you both want to end up getting to."

"As similar as me and Brendon are, we're also dissimilar in other areas as well. We agree 95 per cent of the time on things, but those 5 per cent things that we might have different views on, we talk about it between each other and then we end up getting to the place where we want to get to."

PSL hands Muzarabani 2-year ban for choosing IPL

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lahore

Blessing Muzarabani has been handed a two year ban by the Pakistan Super League (PSL) after the Zimbabwe pacer chose to play the Indian Premier League while having a deal with a PSL franchise.

Muzarabani was signed as a replacement player for Islamabad United but he decided to withdraw from PSL after being approached by Kolkata Knight Riders in the IPL.

"Professionalism in franchise-based leagues requires participants to act with transparency and consistency. Entering into a conflicting engagement while a prior binding agreement subsists represents a departure from the expected standards of the game."

"Such conduct, if left unaddressed, erodes the reliability of dealings and the confidence that franchises, regulators, and stakeholders place in professional engagements."